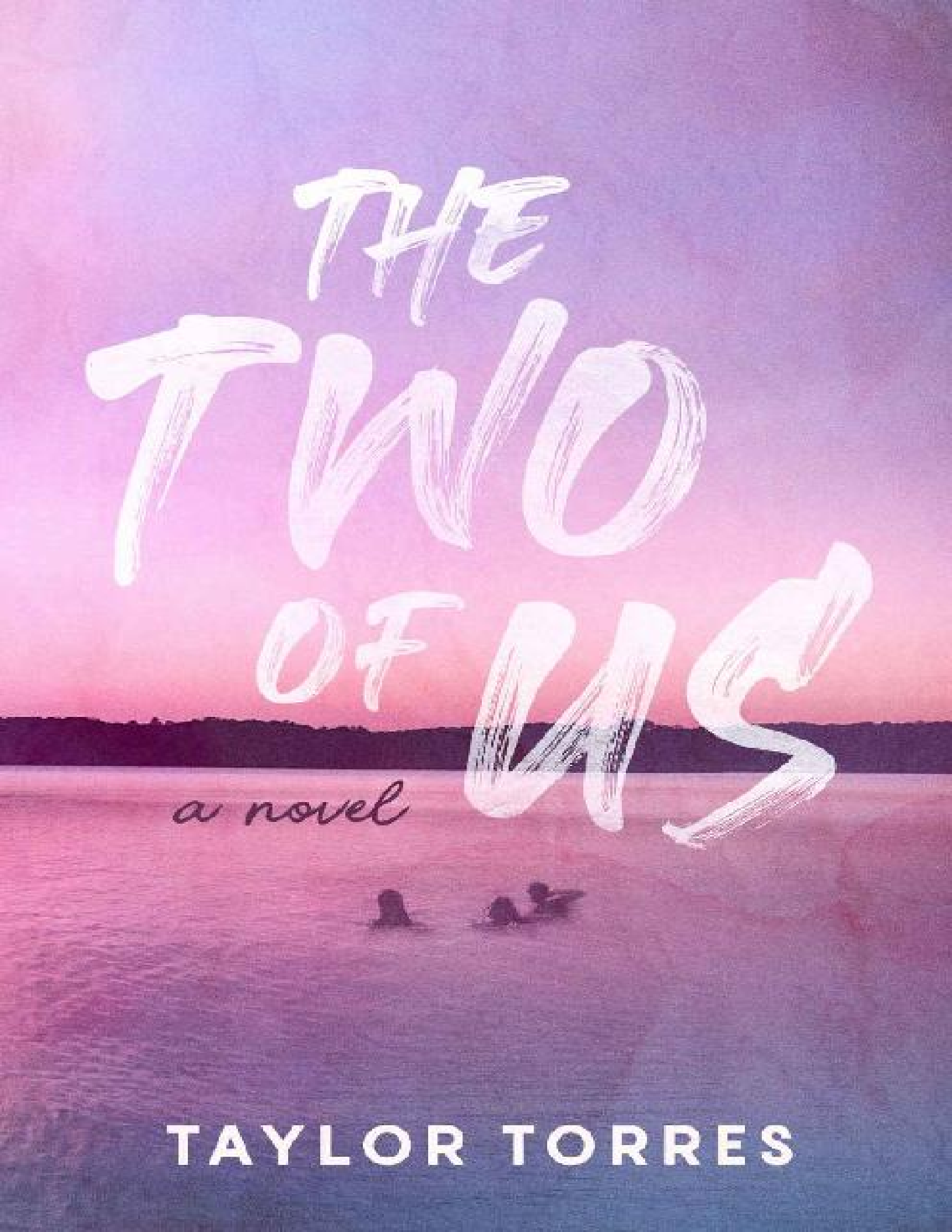


The background of the cover is a photograph of a sunset over a body of water. The sky is a gradient of purple, pink, and orange. The water is dark and reflects the colors of the sky. In the distance, there is a dark silhouette of a shoreline. In the foreground, two people are swimming in the water, their heads and shoulders visible above the surface.

THE TWO OF US

a novel

TAYLOR TORRES

THE TWO OF US

OceanofPDF.com

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, places, events, and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

Cover Design by Derek Wade Creative

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*To all the girls who are told they are too sensitive in a world that
desperately needs to be sensed.
Feeling deeply is not your curse.
It is your gift.*

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Readers, please be advised that this book is intended for readers 18+ and deals with mature themes. There are mentions of addiction and death.

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*You pierce my soul. I am half agony, half hope.
Tell me not that I am too late, that such precious feelings are gone forever.*
—Jane Austen, *Persuasion*

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1

NOW

I don't know how I ended up hiding behind the bar. I mean, if we're talking *literally*, then yes, I'm very aware of how I got myself into this situation because I practically somersaulted over the cool marble in a matter of seconds. Perfect landing. Ten out of ten. Olympic-worthy.

Move over, Simone Biles.

But now that I'm here, I can't help but wonder about the series of events in my life that have gotten me to this point. The point where I'm hiding behind a bar counter next to the bottles of vodka, trying to ignore the sticky residue touching my back.

Don't get me wrong, the man in the bathroom was a great time. He was nice enough, and I liked the juxtaposition of his straight teeth and crooked nose. His lips were soft and his large hands swallowed the small of my back. Plus, I thought he was a gentleman for giving me one of his tequila shots even though it was buy one, get one night.

Apparently, I'm a landing pad for men who do the bare minimum.

Everything was going *swimmingly* until he asked me out on a date. Which was comical, because I'm pretty sure everyone who hooks up in a bathroom knows the bathroom hook-up rule: thou shall not ever see each other again after this. So I tugged my skirt back down, claimed I was receiving an important phone call even though my phone never rang and told him to hang tight.

And when I saw him exit the restroom before I could close out my tab, I quickly made eye contact with the barback.

"I'm so sorry," I said.

Cue the Olympic-worthy somersault.

The barback with the full sleeve tattoos only sighed, like this happened to her a lot and I hated being added to her list of people who do weird shit at bars. She started to tell me I had to leave, but she must have seen the straight-teeth, crooked-nose guy searching for me because her nose scrunched in disapproval before looking down at me.

“Baby girl, you take *all* the time you need.”

So I do take all the time I need and for all I know, it’s been hours because alcohol makes time an arbitrary concept. I’ve become Harry Potter, except instead of my address being The Cupboard Under the Stairs, it’s The Floor Under the Bar. I live here now. Does that make the bottles of vodka near my head my property?

“You can come out now, he’s gone.”

I lift my hand to cup my ear so I can hear her over the music and it’s covered in something wet and unidentifiable. Surprisingly, I’m able to hold back my gag.

“I said, you can come out now,” she says, louder this time.

“Oh. Great.”

I slowly rise to my feet, groaning against the sensation of a million needles poking at my half-asleep legs. I cast a glance around the bar and sure enough, the woman with the tattoos didn’t only have the bar’s back, but mine as well. I attempt to hop over the counter but thanks to the excessive sitting and the exorbitant amount of alcohol in my system, it’s not nearly as impressive as the first time.

I take back what I said, Simone.

“Thanks. I know this probably isn’t what you signed up for when you came into work tonight.”

“No worries,” she says, drying a martini glass. “Happens all the time.”

I cringe. “Really? People get behind the bar *all* the time?”

“Unfortunately.”

“Jeez, well in that case...” I pull a crumpled twenty from my pocket and stick it in her tip jar. She snorts like this also isn’t the first time someone’s done that, and I sigh. So much for being original.

I grab my phone from my bag and call the only number I have favorited on my contacts list. Playing favorites with phone numbers feels immature, like having a top ten during the Myspace days, but it comes in handy when you’re drunk and the apps on your phone resemble hieroglyphics. She answers on the second ring.

“Where are you this time?”

Her voice sounds tired, and I feel guilty for calling her this late, but not guilty enough to try to make it home on my own. The last time I tried to get home while drunk, I ended up taking the R-line to Roosevelt Island. If you want to scare the shit out of a drunk person, have them end up in a location completely surrounded by water when they’re supposed to be in the concrete jungle.

“Cross Tavern,” I pout, even though she can’t see me.

“Be there in a few.”

Tally is the kind of best friend that I definitely don’t deserve. When we were paired as roommates during freshman orientation, I did my best to keep my distance. The last thing I was looking for in college was new relationships. But when someone sits at your bedside for three days feeding you chicken noodle soup while you battle strep throat, they kind of carve a space into your heart. Even if it’s made of stone.

Her black Sentra pulls up to the curb fifteen minutes later and I climb in with my head hung in shame as if this isn’t a regular occurrence. The smell of her leather seats makes me gag, so I lean my head against the cool window.

“Couldn’t sleep again?”

I’m afraid if I open my mouth, the smell of the leather will infiltrate it, so I just grunt as a way of saying yes.

“You can always stay with me, you know that.”

I snort because we both know her comment is absolutely ridiculous and now I’m mad because I have to open my mouth to respond.

“If you brought me home drunk, Jeremy would have a conniption, and you know that.” Jeremy’s a health nut and one of those people who refers to his body as a *temple*. Cringe. But more than his tendency to casually drop words like “chard” and “clean eating” into every conversation, he has a knack for giving unsolicited advice on people’s health choices. But the joke is on Jeremy because his girlfriend dumps the smoothies he makes her down the toilet and hides Hershey Kisses in her underwear drawer.

“Besides,” I say, “the problem isn’t sleeping alone. It’s turning my mind off.”

Tally clicks on her blinker, making a smooth turn onto my street. “Mitsu’s accepting new clients, just say the word,” she sings.

My groan lasts a full five seconds. “Tally, what did we say about psychoanalyzing me?”

She rolls her eyes. “Only on Tues—”

“—only on Tuesdays, that’s right.”

“All I’m saying is, Mitsu’s like a laxative for emotionally constipated people. And you, my friend, are red in the face constipated.”

Mitsu this. Mitsu that.

You know who will change your life? Mitsu.

Blah blah Mitsu blah.

We roll to a stop in front of my walk-up and I peer out into the dark at my dingy apartment building. Something heavy settles in my stomach. I

don't want to be alone, but I don't want to let Tally into everything I'm feeling. It's the shittiest catch-22 I've ever experienced. I lean over the console to peck her cheek. "You're a lifesaver. I swear this is the last time."

"You know, I actually think you believe that."

I wave goodbye with my middle finger and she laughs as I swing the door shut.

I begin my ascent upstairs and by the third floor, I'm on all fours, trying to drag my ass the rest of the way. New York City isn't for the fainthearted.

When I walk into the kitchen, Cheddar's perched on the sink, unmoving, and staring at me like an axe murderer. If cats could be axe murderers. I don't doubt they could be.

"Hey, big boy," I croon. "You enjoy the solitude while I was gone?" The fat tabby huffs at me and slinks away. Clearly, I came back too soon.

I pull a mini bottle of vodka from the freezer and head straight toward my room, chucking off articles of clothing along the way. It only takes a few swigs before my mind fogs over just the way I like. The way I need. And when I finally see the back of my eyelids, I'm grateful that the darkness doesn't turn into the memories I desperately try to keep at bay.

The purring vibrations from Cheddar radiate throughout my skull and I groan out in protest. He has a nasty habit of nearly suffocating me awake to feed him, obviously missing the memo that only one of us has nine lives. I shoot my arm out, searching for his chunky leg, but he dodges my advance and skitters from the room. My eyes squint against the sunlight and I once again scold myself for choosing lace curtains over blackout shades. Flashes of last night trickle into my mind: a brilliant smile, the curve of a nose, my skirt bunched up around my waist, and a man by the name of... of... whatever. A man. I make a silent vow to ease up on the alcohol, and a small

laugh escapes me.

Yeah right.

I wipe the stray hairs sticking to my sweaty forehead and throw my duvet back, crawling out of bed and making my way into the bathroom. I turn the creaky nozzle all the way to the right, praying for at least ten full minutes of scalding hot water this morning. The building is ancient and a shower past nine a.m. usually means you accept your fate of cleansing yourself with ice water.

I stick my fingers under the showerhead to test the temperature and it starts to warm.

“Yes, yes, yes. You can do it,” I chant, coaxing it along.

Steam fills the tiny bathroom and as the mirror fogs up, I yank the scrunchie out of my hair, the errant curls bending in different directions. I sigh. It’ll have to be a wash day.

It doesn’t take more than a minute of standing under the pelting water before negative thoughts attempt to consume me. What is it about showers that force us into downward spirals? Why is it that my brain decides that right now—the moment I’m sopping wet and naked and vulnerable—is the best time to drum up the past?

I lather on body wash and scrub my skin raw, imagining that if I rub hard enough, I’ll be washed down the drain alongside the suds. I absentmindedly run my finger across the two-inch scar on my right palm and close my eyes, a tell that signifies my unease. And I shouldn’t feel that unease. I’m a healthy twenty-five-year-old with a roof over her head and a booming career in her grasp. But that’s that thing about unease. It can live within the body for years without an expiration date, settling into the very fabric of your being. I don’t just feel unease. I *am* unease.

I don’t need to look down at my palm to know that the two-inch scar

there retains its flush of pink even though I've had it since I was thirteen. It's the only physical reminder of my childhood best friend. Evidence of the night we learned what a "blood oath" was. Now all I'm left with is damaged skin and painful memories.

The shower enters freezing territory, signaling that my pity party has gone on long enough. Wrapping myself in my favorite terry bathrobe, I pad into the kitchen. Cheddar's tail curls around my damp ankle, which is the sweetest gesture he's shown me this week. If the only pity I can get is from my cat, I'll take it.

I start brewing a pot of coffee when my phone buzzes in harmony to someone banging at the front door. I quickly snatch the phone off the counter, curious as to who'd be calling this early on a Saturday.

Unknown.

I click *Ignore*. The last time I answered an unknown number, it was my student loan debt collectors and if I wanted to cry this early in the morning, all I'd have to do is contemplate the fact that I'll probably never be out of debt and never own my own house, so yeah. No thank you.

The incessant banging continues and I don't have to guess who it is because I've memorized my landlord's knock and this shit isn't it. Skull-splitting migraine in full force, I run to answer it knowing she'll continue attempting to break my door down until I do.

"I hear you!" I yell, swinging it open.

Tally has her hands on her hips and I can feel her bored stare penetrating through the black shades swallowing her heart-shaped face. I thought I looked bad this morning, but Tally looks like she's just returned from the Seventh Circle of Hell. And she's not even hungover, this is just what mornings look like for her.

"I need coffee," she grumbles, pushing past me into the kitchen.

Most weekends when Jeremy goes to the gym, Tally treks over to my place to indulge in the foods Jeremy's put on the "no-no" list. Which pisses me off because if anything should be on that list, it's men in general and not food. And Tally's excuse for her absence is always that she's helping me because it's my time of the month. *Every weekend.*

Jeremy isn't the brightest man we know.

I fill a large mug to the rim and add a splash of the vanilla creamer I keep on hand for her. She gives me a quick side hug before yanking the mug from my hands, causing a bit of the hot liquid to slosh onto her shirt. She doesn't even flinch. It's more serious than I thought.

"When I woke up this morning, Jeremy tried getting me to drink a massive glass of green shit. He claimed it was banana, spinach, and avocado, but he was lying, Mar. It was green shit. I'm not kidding, I saw my entire life flash before my eyes. I almost snapped like one of those killers from the true-crime documentaries—are you *laughing* at me?"

I can't help the cackle storm brewing in the pit of my stomach. My phone vibrates again and when I glance down, it's the same unknown number.

Jeez, they're really trying to make their money today.

I face Tally. "I'm sorry. I don't mean to revel in your pain, but why are you with this guy again?"

"Because." She pouts. "He has lickable abs, and he lets me lick those abs anytime I want."

I shake my head. "You weak, weak fool. Come on, let's watch some trash TV," I say, leaving the kitchen. I throw myself onto the couch but Tally stays rooted in place, throwing back her coffee like a twenty-one-year-old during spring break.

"Dear God, woman."

She wipes her mouth with her sleeve. “I can’t stay. I promised Jeremy I’d meet him after his workout for brunch.”

I purse my lips. “So what you’re saying is, I’m nothing more than your goodies dealer? You’re just gonna hit it and quit it?” I lay my palm over my heart. “I’m hurt.”

She skips over with her infamous apologetic smile and bends at the waist, pecking my cheek. “But you’re my favorite dealer,” she whispers.

I roll my eyes. “Get out of here.” She laughs and I chuck the nearest throw pillow at her face.

As soon as I latch the dead bolt in place behind her, my mind immediately goes back to the unknown calls I received. Could it have been my mom? I’ve been ignoring her calls more than usual lately, but I don’t think she’d go so far as to call me from an unknown number. Then again, the woman is a Virgo.

Someone could write an entire dissertation on the complex nature of mother-daughter relationships and ours would be the perfect subject. Our relationship is... strained.

After she moved to Paris when I was ten, I’d diligently spent summers with her as per my parents’ divorce agreement, but by my junior year of high school, I’d become so bogged down by the stresses of teenage life and AP courses, we all decided it would be best if I spent the summers resting at home. The following two years consisted of holiday visits, but even that dwindled down to nothing. She didn’t put up much of a fight. But then again, she has the emotional range of a teaspoon.

Pot, meet kettle.

I’m placing Tally’s coffee mug in the sink when my phone buzzes again like clockwork. Frustrated that she can’t take a hint, I thrust the phone to my ear, lashing out my voice like a whip.

“What?”

“Is this Mara Makinen?” The man’s voice is an unfamiliar one. I pull back the phone to confirm it’s the same unknown caller.

“Who is this?”

“Miss Makinen, this is Dr. Flemming from Seaview Hospital. I need you to confirm your identity before I continue.”

Seaview Hospital. That’s where my dad’s been living for the last few months. Bile rises in my throat.

“Is my father okay?” I whisper.

The doctor’s tone turns agitated. “Miss Makinen, I need you to conf—”

“This is she,” I rush out. “This is Mara Makinen.”

He blows out an exasperated breath and my fist clenches at his lack of patience. Isn’t that something they teach them in medical school? Asshole. “As I’m sure you’re aware, your father has been at Seaview since his diagnosis, receiving the utmost attention and care. I’m calling because while we saw a bit of progress in the beginning, the results from recent tests we’ve run allow us to believe...”

Dr. Flemming continues speaking but the edges around my vision blur. It’s as though someone’s holding two conch shells up to my ears and his words become a jumbled mess in my mind. Their meanings are lost on me. Dr. Flemming’s words zoom through one side of my head and shoot out the other before I can grab hold of them. Where will they go? Into the air? Maybe they’ll fly around—directionless—until landing in the ears of the nearest living thing. Maybe Cheddar will absorb the words I can’t seem to grasp but it doesn’t seem likely. He’s fast asleep on the couch and I envy his ignorance.

“Miss Makinen?”

“Yes.”

“Miss Makinen, did you understand anything I just said?” His condescending tone makes me feel so small for someone who’s just been told something so big.

I clear my throat, but my voice still comes out wobbly. “I’m going to be honest with you, Doc. You’ve thrown a lot of complicated medical jargon at me in the last two minutes and while I’ve seen all eighteen seasons of *Grey’s Anatomy*, I’m going to need you to dumb it down for me. What *exactly* are you saying? I get that my father’s condition has worsened but what does that mean? Do I need to hire another in-home caretaker?”

And for the first time since he’s called, Dr. Flemming’s voice softens, causing terror to fill me. Because I don’t want it. I don’t want the soft voice, the *sorry* voice, that promises to breathe life into my deepest fear. But life isn’t known for giving us what we want.

“Miss Makinen... it means it’s time you come back to Speck Lake.”

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2

NOW

“Hold on. You’re telling me you’re at the airport *right now*? About to board a plane. This very second.”

“As we speak,” I mutter, shuffling a few steps forward in line. The person behind me steps on my heel and has the audacity to snicker at me as if we aren’t all going to the same place and have assigned seats.

“Who’s going to take care of Cheese?”

“You know his name is Cheddar. And you are, my sweet friend.”

Tally’s laugh blares through the receiver. “And why the hell would I do that?”

“Because,” I say, handing my ticket to the ticket agent. “I stocked the fridge with all your favorites before I left and I have every streaming service you love.”

She sighs in defeat. “How do I even get in? I don’t have a key.”

I roll my eyes as I make my way to my row. “You and I both know that you made a copy of my key after you watched that documentary on the dangers of women living alone.”

She’s silent for a few seconds. “You tell no lies.”

“Exactly. So just stop by once or twice a day to clean out his litter box and refill his food bowl. Other than that, he’s as self-sufficient as it gets.”

“Litter box?” She makes a disgusted sound. “You owe me.” I hear shuffling on her end. “Where did you say you were going again?”

I pause. “Um, I didn’t. I’m going to Maine to see my dad.” The shuffling stops.

“Didn’t you say he was sick?”

“...yes.”

“Has he gotten worse?” she says, her voice softening. “Mar, do you need me to come with you? Because I can, I—”

“Tally, I gotta go. We’re getting ready to take off and the flight attendant is giving me the death glare.”

“Mara—”

“I’ll call you tomorrow. Bye, I love you!” I hang up before she has the chance to respond.

I pinch the bridge of my nose. Tally is the closest—correction—*only* friend I’ve got, and I still have a hard time letting her all the way in. But I’m afraid if I peel back my layers, even a little, the floodgates will open wide, threatening to release everything I’ve kept neatly tucked away for years.

Cinching the seat belt tight around my waist, I lean back on the headrest and exhale for the first time today. I thought waking up this morning with a hangover would be the worst of my problems.

As we pull out onto the tarmac, I decide to send one last text to Helen, my boss. We spoke this morning and she was more than okay with me working remote, but a small part of me hopes she’ll give me a reason to stay.

Me: Are you sure you’ll be ok without me?

A text bubble with three little dots pops up immediately.

Helen: Aren’t you on the plane by now?

Me: There’s an emergency exit.

Helen: You millennials and your theatrics. I lived through a war and never shed a tear.

Me: That... that’s concerning, Helen.

Helen: Look, you knocked the FlaxForm account out of the park with your web design. You haven’t slowed down since you started at the

agency three years ago. You're my best employee, but I'm afraid I've created a monster.

I go to respond but she beats me to it with another message.

Helen: I promise you can keep your workaholic tendencies intact with the smaller projects I've added to your docket but try to do any more than that and I'll fire you.

Me: That seems a bit excessive.

Helen: I'm an excessive woman, dear. Excessively rich, excessively genius and excessively tired of this conversation. I'm logging off now, goodbye!

Me: You can't log off of text messaging, Helen.

Me: Helen?

Me: Helen!!!

"Miss, we need you to put your phone on airplane mode as we prepare for takeoff." The flight attendant's smile is warm but her eyes are tired so I nod and do as I'm told, not wanting to make her job harder than I'm sure it already is.

The man in the window seat leans slightly over the empty middle seat between us and gestures toward the shade. "Do you want the window open so you can see out when we land?"

I give him a small smile. "Oh, no. That's okay, thank you."

He smirks. "Not interested in the view, huh?"

I shrug, putting on my headphones. "I'm from there. It's a view I'd never forget even if I tried."

The flight to Maine is fast. Too fast. The pilot is obviously racing his fellow airliners, and quite frankly, I find it irresponsible. *Reckless*. He can and should take all the time he needs; there's no rush. *Seriously*. I haven't been

back to Speck Lake in seven years and here I am, arriving in less time than it takes for me to reach the halfway point in my novel. My nerves are shot and I avoid eye contact with the stewardess every time I order another Bloody Mary.

Just keep them coming, Carol. Nothing to see here.

Before boarding my flight, I'd called my dad's nurse, Laura, for the fourth time to make sure I had all the information I needed to make his transition from the hospital seamless. She must have heard the panic in my voice because she assured me all I'd have to do is head straight home and she'd take care of the rest.

Home.

I haven't thought of that word in a long time. I'm not sure I'm allowed to use that title anymore. Can I call a place *home* if I've abandoned it without a second thought?

When I left, I swore to myself I'd never come back. It feels masochistic, returning to the place where it all went wrong. Where I made the biggest mistake—*stop it. Don't go back there.* There's no reason I can't stand by my dad's side and leave everything else at the proverbial door. He needs me.

Dad never complained about the fact that if he ever wanted to see me post-high school, he had to fly to New York. I still allow shame to eat away at me for not coming to his side when he first told me of his cancer diagnosis a year ago. All I can do now is be the daughter he deserves. My mind ruminating on just how little time he has left causes my hands to tremble and I set my plastic cup down. There aren't enough napkins on this plane for the Bloody Mary bath I'm giving myself. I wait for the tears to fall but my face remains dry and I remain numb. Mitsu would have a field day with me.

"Are you visiting?"

The woman sitting near the aisle of her row mirrors my own seat assignment. I attempt a smile, but the alcohol makes it look like a grimace. A scuffed-up book on the history of the Latin Church rests on her lap. Her gray-speckled auburn hair drapes over one shoulder and she's the picture of ease in a sweater and faded jeans. I crave that kind of comfort in my own skin, but mine always feels itchy and unwelcome—like it's not the right fit.

My laugh is shaky. "No, I'm from here. But I haven't been back in years, so maybe I am visiting."

"Oh, how nice. Don't take this the wrong way, but I wouldn't have pegged you for a local."

Years ago, I might have been offended, but I don't consider myself a local anymore. I glance down at the clothes I threw on this morning, positive they're what threw her off. A crisp white button-down hugs my chest while a pair of structured black trousers accentuate the calf muscles I attribute to my fifth floor walk up. They're tailored to perfection, but only because it's impossible to find pants that don't drown my short legs. Suddenly, I feel too overdressed for the small lake town we're approaching.

"I guess I wasn't really thinking when I got dressed this morning."

A voice blares from the speaker overhead, informing the cabin that we've begun our initial descent, and I lift my drink back up to my lips, not caring if my trembling causes it to spill again.

"Not a fan of flying?" She smiles.

"Something like that."

The plane drops and my heart with it.

Almost there.

I nod at the woman's book, desperate for a distraction. "The history of the Latin Church. I take it you enjoy light reading?"

She laughs and it settles my nerves by a fraction. "I like learning about

the saints.”

“Ah. And which ones are you learning about right now?”

She flips through the tattered pages. “Saint Thomas Aquinas. Saint John Bosco. Oh, and Saint Ambrose.”

My body goes rigid.

“What’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” I say, blowing out a breath. “I just knew, *know*, somebody by that name, that’s all.”

“Really?” She smiles. “Which one?”

My tongue works itself around the name I’ve refused to speak in seven years, *his* name, and when I’m finally able to say it, something deep within me stirs.

I look the woman straight in the eye.

“Ambrose,” I say, expelling a breath. “Ambrose King.”

3

THEN (AGE 10)

The boy stares back at us in silence, making it clear he won't speak first. I shift from one foot to the other, taking him in. He's taller than me, but the baby fat around his cheeks makes me think he's my age or very close to it. Midnight hair falls in a mop of disarray on his head and I wonder if he's ever heard of a brush. He's average and unassuming until you catch hold of his eyes. Sandwiched between thick black lashes, their moss color pops against the rest of his appearance. They're sharp and intimidating, but I can't look away. Those eyes land on me with curiosity and my back stiffens under the attention. My father clears his throat.

"Hey there. My name is Solomon Makinen, and this is my daughter, Mara. We live across the street," he says, jutting his thumb out behind him. "We saw your family move in and wanted to introduce ourselves. I think you and Mara might be in the same grade. I'm sure you both have a lot in common." His smile is strained, and it's obvious he's trying to pitch me to this kid in hopes that he'll be my friend. I blanch at his desperation.

The boy's silence makes me itchy but then he tilts his head at me. "Do you like animals?"

I shrug, dipping my chin at the cat in my arms. "I like cats. This is Cheddar."

His brows furrow. "Cheddar? Why would you name a cat Cheddar?"

"Because my cousin's name is Brie, so that was already taken."

His lack of a reaction means he either didn't understand my joke, or he just doesn't find it funny. My money is on the latter and my dad clears his throat for the second time in three minutes. This is going *great*.

"Are your parents home, son?"

“Sure, just a second. Mom!” he calls into the house.

After a minute, a petite woman takes up the space in the doorway. The smile plastered on her face immediately puts me at ease. The hijab she wears is a myriad of blues, making her face look like it’s being held by the ocean. She’s beautiful. Her son takes after her with his warm skin, but where his eyes are striking and intense, the brown in hers is warm and inviting.

As my dad repeats the introductions and talks about things adults talk about, I steal a glance at the boy again, only to find he’s already studying me. Rather than look away, I hold his gaze, waiting to see who will break eye contact first. It’s as if he senses the gauntlet I’ve thrown down because he turns his body just slightly to line up more directly with mine, his eyes narrowing a fraction. We stay like that, unblinking, until his mom directs her next words at me.

“Mara, I’m taking Ambrose and his little sister to the zoo in half an hour. Would you and your father like to join us? We’d love to have you.”

I begrudgingly accept defeat and look at the kind woman in front of me. If her offer stems from pity, I can’t tell. Her smile makes me believe she really does want us to join, and that’s how me and my dad find ourselves in our old hatchback on our way to the zoo, trailing behind the King family.

We drive with the windows down and I bury my face in the crook of my elbow, taking in the familiar town I’ve known all my life. Speck Lake—a town so small it resembles nothing more than a speck on a map. If you blink fast enough, you can drive through it without even noticing. When I asked my dad why there were so few children around while growing up, he said it’s because Speck Lake is a retirement community.

My parents moved here in the ’90s because there were a lot of new job opportunities at the time. My dad led a construction team to renovate

facilities to accommodate the elderly and my mom's art background put her in high demand at the recreational center. They fell in love with the familial atmosphere and the tight-knit community and decided to put down roots. But when the town's extensive renovations recently came to an end, there was nothing left for my dad's construction company to work on, and not long after, the rec center's interests shifted away from art classes. My mom moved to Paris a month later.

I know everything about this town and the ten kids I've shared a classroom with since kindergarten. Nothing ever changes in Speck Lake and it's confusing why our new neighbors would want to live here. Besides the actual lakes, everything loses its excitement after one visit. Our only movie theater plays the same five classics every Sunday, and the local library feels less like a library and more like a living room full of hand-me-down books from the next town over. Even the zoo, which is considered the largest establishment in town, is small enough to explore in under two hours.

To be fair, Speck Lake has some special qualities as well. Fewer children mean that the ones who do live here get doted on by every old person in town. The community event calendar is always bustling and you can hardly go a week without being invited to someone's Bake-Off or block party. Everyone in town has each other's backs, and that became even more evident when my mom left for Paris. Our fridge overflowed with casseroles and other food-train concoctions. You would have thought someone had died, but really everyone just wanted to make sure my dad had what he needed to take care of a ten-year-old girl.

"Mrs. King seems nice, doesn't she?"

"I guess so."

I overheard Mrs. King telling my dad that her husband would be home

later tonight, but I still have a tingling sense of anxiety at my dad even mentioning the existence of another woman. Even if she is kind.

“She was telling me her husband, Robby, plans on starting the very first soccer program at your school. I’m surprised they have enough interest to get one going, but I think it’s great. We’ve never had anything for you kids to be active in. Maybe we should have you try out.”

I know what he’s doing. It’s the same thing he’s been doing since my mom stepped on that plane and chose croissants over her only daughter. He’s trying to get me involved in anything that will pull me out of my slump. And he must be running out of ideas because we both know how uncoordinated I am.

I should make more of an effort to assuage his fears. His white hairs are starting to make him look like the retired folks he used to work for.

I lean forward in my seat. “Yeah, I guess I could give tryouts a chance. Too bad he isn’t starting a rugby team, or else you could train me yourself.”

“That’s the French, *princessa*.” He chuckles, using the sentimental nickname—the only term of endearment he’d learned in Spanish. We have this running joke where I mention traditions of other countries and incorrectly attribute it to his Finnish heritage. I see his shoulders visibly relax. As we turn onto the gravel parking lot I’ve seen a million times, something infiltrates my thoughts.

What does Ambrose think about soccer?

The zoo’s packed for a Saturday. And by packed, I mean there are more than five families here. The colosseum-shaped building is newly renovated and inviting, and pride fills me knowing my dad had a hand in its construction. Mrs. King, who insists I call her Alima, moves ahead of us to grab the tickets. When she returns, she throws an arm around my shoulder

and squeezes me affectionately, as if she's known me longer than half an hour, and suddenly the trip doesn't seem so bad. We make our way through the exhibits and my initial hesitation surrounding the King family dissipates.

Ambrose stalks off in his own direction to observe the animals with a small notepad and pencil he pulled from his pocket while I find myself quietly trailing the younger sister, who I found out is the same age as me. I casually stand next to her and take in whatever animal she looks at, but she's constantly on the move. I can't tell if she's too disinterested to care about reading the informational plaques or if she's so interested, she's trying to learn about as many animals as quickly as possible. When she turns away from the ledge after only watching the capuchin monkey for a few seconds, I give up on chasing her around and remain in place. Cool, delicate fingers wrap around my wrist.

"Aren't you coming?" She has a brilliant smile. She doesn't wait for an answer before dragging the both of us to a giant tank in the center of a brick wall. It's filled to the brim with jellyfish.

I consider asking her what animal she likes best so far, but I have a feeling even she won't know the answer, so I watch the jellyfish, curious if their squishy heads feel like Jell-O.

"You should come over to my house to play sometime," she says, her finger following a jellyfish across the glass. "Do you have a Pocket Princess? The one that just came out, not the old ones. You can always tell which ones are the old kind because their hair falls out when you brush it too much. Ambrose accidentally ran over one of my new Pocket Princesses with his skateboard, and my mom tried to replace it without me knowing, but I figured it out after I brushed her hair. I have the entire village expansion pack if you want to bring yours over."

Her genuine smile confirms that she's not trying to brag about her possessions. The Pocket Princesses recently spiked into popularity and most girls my age have one or five, but because of my parents' layoffs, I haven't even bothered to ask for one.

It's as if she understands the reasoning behind my hesitation because her eyes are gentle when she says, "You should just use mine, you know, that way yours don't get lost at my house. My mom would kill me if someone lost something at our house." She's offering me an out, and my chest expands with gratitude. Kids our age rarely save each other from embarrassment. She changes the subject by pointing at her brother who stands to the left of us. He's engrossed by that tattered notepad.

What are you finding so fascinating that you have to immortalize it on paper?

"Ambrose is only eleven, but he acts like he's so much older," she says, rolling her eyes.

I giggle and decide right then that I want to be her friend. Her wheat-colored hair glows around her face. She doesn't resemble her mom or brother, so she must look like her dad.

"Look! Penguins!"

She flits away before I can ask her to remind me of her name. I quietly stalk Ambrose's movements until he plants himself in front of a glass aviary enclosure. I walk over and peer inside, curious to know what's capturing his attention. Behind the glass walls are hundreds of birds flying from one branch to the other. Some drink from the hanging water bowls while others intricately build makeshift nests with the scattered twigs and branches that litter the enclosure's floor. They're a chaotic blend of colors soaring across my vision, and the image reminds me of a rainbow, bouncing from left to right. They seem so different from each other, I worry that some of them

might be targeted for not fitting in. I watch a puffy yellow bird the size of my fist linger in the corner by itself and have trouble finding others that match its features.

“Why do you look sad?” Ambrose watches me with that curious expression again.

“I’m not sad.”

He waits expectantly, unsatisfied with my answer and I have a nagging feeling that he won’t look away until I offer up something more truthful.

I sigh. “I’m just wondering if any of these birds feel out of place. You know, if they ever get picked on by the other birds for looking too different.” I turn my attention back to the yellow puff, it remains isolated in its corner as Ambrose mulls over my concern with careful consideration.

“Teamwork is common between birds of different species. Some of the smaller birds build their nests near the larger birds because they know they’ll be more protected from predators. Some of them find food together, even though they look different.” He scratches his chin and it makes him look years older. “I think they know that you need friends who are good at the things you suck at. Animals are a lot more like people than we think.”

For someone who seems so sure of himself, I’m surprised when I see the hint of red blooming on his cheeks. Does he think I’ll find him weird for knowing so much about animals? He has the opposite effect on me. I’m completely enamored. I want to plant myself right here forever and listen to anything and everything he has to say. But for the time being, I offer him a small smile.

Awkward silence stretches between us, and I contemplate searching for my dad.

“Quiet,” Ambrose says.

My brows scrunch in confusion, and he smirks, making my belly flop.

“It’s a game. I say a word and then you say whatever word comes to your mind from that word. Give it a try. *Quiet.*”

“Um... talking?” I whisper.

“Whisper.”

“Secret.”

He grins. “Best friends.”

I frown.

“What’s wrong?”

“It’s kind of hard to think of another word. I don’t have any best friends,” I say, shifting from one foot to the other.

Ambrose turns back to the enclosure and smiles to himself like he’s in on some secret. He tears a blank page from his notepad and pulls an extra pencil from his pocket before handing it to me.

“For now.”

4

NOW

It takes a million phone calls to various car services before I finally find one that will drive me from Bangor to Speck Lake. I almost lost my shit when the fourth company I called said they'd never even heard of the town. The driver picking me up makes me shell out a hefty tip before we hit the road and I make sure to throw my luggage into his trunk with a heavy hand. The next two hours fly by as I work on the website of an up-and-coming fitness brand. When we cross over the town line, I peek out the window, taken aback by how much the town's changed. Changed is putting it lightly. It's completely unrecognizable.

We slow at a stop sign near Nadine's Nursery and it's nothing more than a dilapidated warehouse overgrown with ivy. Nadine's Nursery used to be the go-to spot for all things plant related and it still holds a special place in my heart for being the nursery where I got my first succulent. I named it Jerry. Jerry died a week later because I was convinced succulents didn't need water, but we had fond memories, nonetheless. RIP Jerry.

"Miss! This it?" the man yells.

His customer service skills are crap, and now I know why he required the tip up front. We've turned onto Winsome Lane—the street I could find my way back to in my sleep. The cul-de-sac is quieter than I remember, but I guess that makes sense considering the three kids that gave it life are all gone now.

I sigh. "Yeah. This is it."

"Which house?" he says impatiently. I forgot how difficult it is to see the numbers on the houses in this area and the GPS gave out on him ten minutes ago.

“That little yellow one, right there.” I point.

“Looks like a lemon drop.”

I tilt my head as I take it in. “Huh. I guess it does.”

When I conjured up the image of home over the years, it looked dull and muted. It didn’t seem as inviting as it does now, but memories have a tendency of painting over the truth. The house stands out on the street with its wraparound porch and nautical-blue shutters, and it suddenly dawns on me that Dad must have paid someone to freshen up the house to increase its market value. My chest tightens. I was never offered the house, but that says more about me than him.

“Are you gonna get out or what?”

“Yeah. Sorry,” I mutter, flipping him off with the hand hanging low at my side.

I step out of the car, making sure to keep my eyes trained forward. I don’t have to look across the street to remember what their house looks like because it’s the last image I see every night. It’s what keeps me searching for sleep at the bottom of a liquor bottle.

A tingling sensation sweeps across the back of my neck like I’m being watched, and I’d bet anything it’s Mr. and Mrs. King wondering what made the prodigal daughter decide to return home. They once loved me as their own, but those days are long gone.

I gesture for the driver to pop his trunk and I lug my suitcases out, dragging them behind me. He doesn’t even offer to help. Again, I’m fucking bitter about the tip. I thrust the bundle of cash through his rolled-down window and watch him peel out of the driveway like he’s afraid he’ll get trapped in this ghost town the longer he lingers.

It’s not until I’m standing in front of the door, which smells of freshly coated varnish, that I realize I don’t have a key. I don’t have a key to my

own house because I didn't think I'd ever need it again. I knock on the door, cursing under my breath. Having to be let into your own home is embarrassing. As a last-ditch effort, I begin looking around the porch for the garden gnome that usually hides a spare key when the door opens. A woman in pale-pink scrubs with little hearts all over them smiles at me.

"You must be Mara!" She pulls me in for a hug before I have the chance to respond.

"Yes. Thank you for getting the door. I forgot I didn't have a key."

"No problem at all, hon. Come on in." She opens the door wide enough for me to slip past her and I'm immediately thrown off by the smell. It smells clean in the way that reminds me of a hospital. Like disinfectant and plastic bed covers. Anxiety pulls at my nerves.

I take in the walls around me and notice the only photos left hanging are of me, my dad, and my childhood friends. My mom's colorful paintings and ceramics that used to plaster the entryway have been replaced with more modern, Nordic pieces. Making my way into the living room, I'm caught off guard by the scraping of nails across the hardwood floors and before I know it, I'm flat on my back. Something licks every inch of my face with a tongue that feels like a Brillo pad and I gasp, struggling to come up for oxygen.

"Otso, no! Down, boy!" Laura screeches, reaching down to wrangle the dog away from my face.

I didn't go to Harvard, but this is not a dog. This is a creature you'd avoid out in the woods. A yeti of sorts. It's impressive that Laura's small frame is able to hold the beast back.

I scramble to my knees. "Is this your dog?" The front of my shirt looks like it's been submerged in a bucket of water.

"Otso? Absolutely not. No, this guy here is your dad's." She laughs,

amused that I'd think such a thing. I take in the "dog" again, shocked he hasn't turned one of my limbs into a chew toy yet. The Saint Bernard towered over me when he'd jumped on his hind legs and there's no way his weight is under two hundred fifty pounds. When I meet his eyes, they tell me he wants to make out with my face again.

Think again, beast.

Since when does my dad like dogs? The news startles me. When I'd asked for a dog on my thirteenth birthday, he told me I wouldn't be content in life if I had to clean a butt other than my own. On sheer principle alone, I decide not to like the dog in front of me. I smooth out my crumpled trousers as Laura drags him into another room, quickly closing the door behind her.

"Otso, huh? That's an interesting name."

"It means *bear*."

My laugh is dry. "How fitting."

"Come, leave your suitcases for a second and I'll take you to your dad." She's already turning the corner. I almost forgot why I'm here. My dad's somewhere in this house, dying, and I'm about to lay eyes on him for the first time since he was diagnosed.

Laura stops in front of a spare bedroom and I hold my breath as she gives a gentle knock before opening the door. She motions me forward and I enter the room that used to store holiday decorations and the treadmill machine my dad used for all of two weeks. I immediately picture him running and the image is at odds with the man I see now. My dad is a motionless figure on a small bed, positioned to face the open window so sunlight shines over his face. The golden glow fails to mask his pallid complexion, and he looks skinnier than when I last saw him—his eyes like sunken weights on his face. My nerves scream to look away, but I'm captivated by his protruding cheekbones in a morbid sort of way. He's asleep, but if Laura wasn't

standing next to me, I would have thought he'd passed away already. A gentle hand touches my shoulder.

"I didn't realize he would fall asleep this soon after his lunch. Would you like to sit with him? I need to run to the store and grab a couple of things for the house," she whispers.

She's already pulling out a yellow piece of notepad paper with illegible markings all over it. My eyes flit to the lone chair stationed near the head of his bed and alarm bells go off in my mind. The thought of sitting alone with him, wondering every few seconds if he's still breathing, makes me want to get back on the plane and encourage the pilot to race back to New York.

"You know what, let me go to the store for you," I say, reaching for the list.

"Oh sweetie, you don't have—"

"Really, I don't mind at all. It would be nice to stretch my legs after that flight and there are things I want to pick up anyway. I saw my dad's car keys on the kitchen counter, so I'll just run out quick."

I tuck the list into my pocket and practically run from the room, tripping over my feet, before Laura can refuse my offer. I snatch the keys from the bowl and pull out onto the road in record time. And it's in my haste that I miss the black Jeep Wrangler simultaneously pulling out of 164 Winsome Lane.

I'm parked at Hensen's Super, taking my sweet time getting out of the car to make this trip last as long as possible. I silently scold myself. If I can't face my dad while he's sleeping, how am I going to stand by his side while he gets worse?

I step out of the car and grab an abandoned shopping cart near the hood before heading into the store. It's surprising a small grocer like Hensen's is

still in business, considering the state of the other small businesses in town. I peruse the aisles one by one, inspecting every item on the shelves even though there are only five things on Laura's list. I cling to the idea that I may come across something she'll find useful. Some might call it denial. I call it wishful thinking.

A mother passes me with a toddler seated at the front of her cart and I offer a friendly smile. The little girl thrashes her legs about, filling the aisle with uninhibited giggles. The world hasn't hurt her yet, and I want to beg her mother to shield her from what's to come. The woman bends down to grab a bag of flour from the bottom shelf and the little girl takes the opportunity to snatch a bag of cookies, throwing them into the cart behind her. She catches my eye, hiding a mischievous giggle behind the palm of her hand and I dip my chin into my shoulder to muffle my laugh. When her mother turns back around, she notices the addition to their cart.

She grins at me. "Kids," she says, tickling her daughter's sides. "Do you have any?"

A laugh bubbles out of me. "Kids? Gosh, no. I don't make enough money to pay for the therapy they'd need."

She frowns.

I cringe.

"Happy shopping," I say before fleeing to the next aisle over.

I bob my head to the '90s song playing overhead, thankful for the distraction as I read and reread the ingredient list on a jar of pesto. Who knew pesto has pine nuts in it? I extend my arm toward the shelf above, suddenly curious about the real contents of aioli.

"Mouse?"

The aioli slips from my hands, rolling away on its side as the hairs on my arms shoot straight up. The voice is unfamiliar, but there's only one person

in the entire world who calls me that. My throat constricts as I stand there, unmoving. As if by remaining still, I can make myself invisible.

“Mara.” He’s closer now, and my body hums, waking up to the sound of his voice.

I’m both relieved and disappointed he’s switched to my real name. Resigning to the fact that my attempt at invisibility hasn’t worked in the slightest, I white-knuckle the jar of pesto still in my clutches and turn toward the boy I left seven years ago.

Except he’s not a *boy* anymore.

He’s anything but.

Ambrose King’s watchful stare burns into me as I shamelessly check him out from head to toe. The last time I saw him, he was attractive, but he was still young. This Ambrose is no longer attractive.

He’s *devastating*.

And while I’m all for self-punishment, this was a cut I wasn’t expecting. His towering figure casts a shadow over all five-foot-four of me and my eyes devour the sight of him, flitting over every inch of his body, branding him back into my memory. His sun-soaked arm bulges as he clenches the handle of his cart.

My Ambrose.

My golden boy.

Not yours, Mara. Not anymore.

I finally allow myself to meet his gaze and his moss-colored eyes strike me with immediate knowing.

Another cut.

They’re the same eyes I’ve always loved but they’ve aged. They carry a hint of sorrow, and if I’m not mistaken, a shade of regret. He crosses his arms over his chest, waiting patiently for the quiet little mouse to speak up.

“Ambrose...” I breathe. “Hi.”

“What are you doing here, Mara?”

“Oh, you know. Visiting.” My casual facade cracks under my unsteady voice.

“No, I don’t know,” he says bluntly. “I haven’t seen you in seven years.”

Let’s get right to it then.

My ears burn, my eyes burn... everything. Everything burns. Ambrose King is my inferno. He always has been. My feet begin to backtrack on their own accord. “Listen, I can’t stay and talk. I’m in a rush and I need to get all these things back to my dad’s.” I gesture in front of me, but when I swivel my cart, Ambrose imitates my movement, blocking my escape.

“That’s it?” he bites out. “You’re just going to leave again?” He’s not angry, he’s *furious*. I watch with rapt attention as his hand flexes and he runs it down his face, blowing out a harsh breath. “Look. Can we just talk? I have so many questions. Where have you *been*—are you okay?”

He steps toward me and suddenly he’s in my space, our bodies only a few inches apart. The very marrow in my bones is drawn to him, so much so, I find myself leaning in.

NO.

I jerk back with my cart and it hits a table with a pyramid display of bagels. They begin rolling onto the floor and suddenly I’m scrambling, trying to catch them in my arms. “No, Ambrose. I don’t think that’s a good idea,” I squeak, scrambling to fix the display before drawing any more attention to ourselves.

Ambrose grabs my wrist, stopping me. “Forget the fucking bagels, Mara.” His breath brushes across my face and I don’t miss the way his eyes fall to my mouth. The bagels fall from my hands to the ground with a soft *thud*. “Is this about what happened with Cat?” he says, breathing hard and

my blood runs cold at the mention of her name. Once he sees my disposition shift, his voice softens. “Mara... if you left because of what happened—”

“No,” I say with more force than I intend and his eyes widen at my tone. “There’s no need to rehash everything. It’s in the past. I don’t think about any of that anymore.”

Lie.

“I’ve moved on and I’m happy and I hope you’re happy too, I really do. I’m not the same person I was seven years ago. We have nothing to talk about. *Nothing*. So please... please just leave me alone.”

The thing about Ambrose is that you don’t have to tell him something twice. He respects boundaries and if you tell him to leave you alone, that’s exactly what he’ll do. Do I really want that? A small part of me, the part of me that hopes and wants for things, says to retract my words, but I smother it down.

Ambrose dips his chin in a stiff nod. “Take care of yourself, Mara.”

Cuts. Cuts everywhere and I’m bleeding out.

His retreating footsteps are drowned out by the music I danced to not five minutes ago and now I know what it feels like to have the person you love walk away from you.

I haul my heavy limbs toward the self-checkout lane, seizing three bottles of wine along the way. And for someone who’s a mouse, I despise the hell out of the silence that envelops me.

5

THEN (AGE 11)

“What’s it supposed to be?” I ask.

“Can’t you tell?”

The crunch of leaves beneath my boots signals the onset of fall and I delight in the sound. The massive tree in front of me has transformed into varying shades of burnt sienna—colors my mom would use generously on her landscape paintings.

I’ve always loved this tree. My dad said when he and my mom were looking for their first house in Speck Lake, they knew they needed to find one befitting for a child. Other homes boasted bigger backyards or beautiful docks that led straight out to the lakes, but this house had Old Maple. That’s what he named it. A maple tree so old that being called Old Maple seemed like a no-brainer. Old Maple’s branches spread out toward the sky like arms reaching out to grab the clouds. Its trunk so wide, I often pretend it’s my protector; my shield. I shift on both feet, avoiding the exasperated look on my dad’s face.

“Mara. It’s a tree house.”

I look from the tree to him and then back to the tree again, squinting. “Where?”

“Where? she asks,” he mutters in disappointment.

Solomon Makinen is a big, burly construction man, but unless he’s following an intricate floor plan, he can’t build anything to save his life. When I was five years old, I entrusted him to assemble my Barbie dream house after I accidentally threw away the manual. The result was him crushing Barbie’s elevator with his bare hands and me screaming in horror.

So that’s how I know this tree house is a product of desperation in its

purest form. He'll do anything to prevent me from holing up in the house like I did when Mom left. It's not enough that I've made friends with Ambrose and Cat across the street, he wants me outside.

And if this sad excuse for a tree house isn't proof of how deeply he loves me, all I need to do is look at his hands buried under blisters and Band-Aids. His love means more than any perfect tree house ever could. I take another look, forcing myself to view it in a positive light. The planks, I assume are supposed to be the stairs, are uneven, but I'll take it as a fun challenge. At least it's wide enough to fit a few kids if we all sit cross-legged.

"It's perfect, Dad. Really. It's unique. Actually, I know for a fact that no other kid in Speck has something like this," I say, biting back a laugh.

His eyes narrow with doubt. "Really?"

I nod like a bobblehead. "*Oh, yeah.* Besides, who wants one of those big, over-the-top tree houses anyway? That's what houses are for, and I'd much rather hang out with you than be in a tree house all day. Cat's going to love it. Ambrose will probably ask if there were any bird nests when you—what?" I stop rambling, noticing the sheen in his eyes.

Is he about to cry?

He clears his throat. "Thanks, *princessa*," he chokes out before gently clapping the back of my shoulder and retreating into the house.

I kick the pile of leaves near my shoe before I venture across the street to invite Ambrose and Cat over to my new wooden castle.

Okay, maybe "castle" is a little too generous.

A month passes and the citizens of Speck Lake begin pulling out the pumpkins and cable-knit sweaters. The crisp air whispers the promise of change, and for the first time, I welcome it. I turned eleven three days ago

and this year, I feel different. Dad respected my wishes to keep the festivities small. We began the day by snagging my favorite glazed twists from Cheaper by The Dough-zen before picking up a few pumpkins from Nadine's Nursery. Then, he graced me with his famous homemade Karelian pasties along with my favorite pastelles while we curled up on the couch watching one of my favorite movies, *Jurassic Park*. Golden hour was in full force when I heard the knock at the door. Failing to hide his grin, my dad jumped off the couch, returning a few minutes later with three bodies trailing behind him. The Kings stood there with dessert platters in their hands and I was annoyed until I devoured the tangy lemon bars Alima made. Surprisingly, having Alima there ended up soothing the pain of my mom forgetting to call.

It's the weekend before Halloween when I invite Ambrose and Cat over to help make Old Maple look spooky. I rummage through the box of decorations my dad dragged out of the storage room, hearing multiple sets of footsteps approach.

"Boo!" Cat screams, jumping in front of my face.

I laugh. "Cat, you can't scare someone if they see you walking up."

"But you'd never expect it, so it's even *more* scary. Trust me, I know what I'm talking about."

I glance at Ambrose by her side. My hands clam up and I wipe them on my jeans.

"Hi." I smile.

"Hey." He smirks. And what a smirk it is. I almost die right there on the spot. We continue staring at each other.

"Well this is awkward," Cat says.

Ambrose pulls her into a playful headlock, and thankfully, it breaks the tension.

I nod toward Old Maple. “Let’s go up.”

We’re climbing one at a time when a voice calls out behind us. Reaching the top, I stick my head out the side of the makeshift window my dad created last week and see Jackson Healey, a boy in Ambrose’s grade, running toward us. I’ve seen them hang out a few times, but it’s hard to believe they’re friends. Where Ambrose is still and pensive, Jackson is rambunctious and quick on his feet. He’s like a woodpecker, but instead of pecking a thousand miles per hour, he talks. Despite all that, he’s nice and he’s notorious for giving love notes to girls in every grade. He doesn’t discriminate.

Noticing my confusion, Ambrose leans down close to my ear and says, “I didn’t invite him.” His closeness sends a shiver down my spine.

“Jackson!” Cat squeals, waving so hard I’m afraid her arm might detach from her shoulder. He climbs Old Maple, not bothering to wait for an invitation.

“Hey, Kitty Cat,” he says, shooting Cat a lopsided grin, and Ambrose tenses beside me. Jackson unleashes his boyish charm on everyone, but Ambrose doesn’t seem too thrilled to see his little sister on the receiving end.

Jackson clasps his hands behind his head and leans back against the wall. “So, what are we doing today?”

I wait in silence. I never voice what I want to do first. It’s much easier to avoid conflict by going along with what everyone else wants.

“I say we play capture the flag!” Cat suggests.

Ambrose scrunches his nose. “We don’t have a flag.”

“Obviously. We can use any piece of fabric—use your imagination, Ambrose,” she says, shooting me a funny face and I smile.

Ambrose rolls his eyes. “I think we should go on an animal exploration. I

was reading a book the other day that said every American's backyard holds up to four thousand species. If we all split up, we can—"

"*Nope*. Next?" Cat interrupts, clamping her small hand over his mouth. I bite my lip to hold back a giggle and while most brothers would be annoyed, I see Ambrose's chest shake with laughter.

Ambrose's eyes suddenly land on me. "What do you think we should do, Mara?"

Shocked, I open my mouth but nothing comes out and Jackson cuts in, "You guys are so boring. Let's play Truth or Dare!"

I avoid eye contact with Jackson, who's wagging his eyebrows suggestively. I've played Truth or Dare a few times before with Cat, but never with a boy who's said to have kissed most of the girls in his grade *and* mine. When no one answers him, he raises his eyebrows as a challenge.

"What? Are you guys scared?"

Cat takes the bait. "I'm in."

Ambrose watches me for a second before turning to him, answering for the both of us. "Fine. We'll do it."

Jackson whoops in place and repositions his crisscrossed legs, making himself comfortable. His expression goes from playful to downright serious and sweat pools in my armpits. "I'll go first," he says. "Cat, truth or dare?"

"Truth."

"Did you really hold hands with Marco Sanchez on the bus ride back from the field trip last week?"

Cat smirks, unimpressed. "Yes."

He stares back at her with slight shock. He's met his match. He nods, signaling her turn.

"Mara. Truth or dare?" There's a mischievous glint in her eyes. One that only Cat can make look adorable instead of intimidating. I settle on truth

knowing she'd never abuse the opportunity.

“Who is your best friend in the entire world?”

I want to laugh because she knows it's her, but her expression reveals an undercurrent of fear. Have I given her the impression she isn't my best friend? I'm not as expressive about my emotions as Cat. I used to be until my mom started calling me “overly sensitive.” But I always thought Cat knew how much I loved her. Shame that my nonchalance may have stirred up doubt within her fills me.

I reach across our small circle and squeeze her hand. “You are, of course. Always.”

Her smile is wide and satisfied.

It's my turn and I'm unsure who to choose. Ambrose comes to mind, but I can't think of a dare he won't do and I don't want him to know which truths I desire from him. I pin my stare on Jackson.

“Jackson, truth or dare?”

“Hit me with the dare, baby.”

His overexcitement alarms me.

“Um... I dare you to sing us your favorite lullaby in an old lady voice.”

“Oh, Mara. That's cute,” he snorts. He then proceeds to sing the most earsplitting rendition of “Rock-A-Bye Baby” in a voice one could only describe as ancient. We all burst into a fit of laughter and I clench my side to ward off the cramp that's beginning to settle in. Jackson may be unpredictable, but we're all having fun.

It went on like that for a while. I shocked everybody by licking the wall of the tree house for five seconds and Ambrose brought tears to our eyes when he admitted that the dumbest thing he'd ever believed was that stepping on a crack really would break his mother's back.

“It made sense at the time!” he yelled defensively.

We laughed and laughed and if the game ended there, I might have gone so far as to say that Truth or Dare was a new favorite for me. But it didn't end there and I should have known Jackson wouldn't let us off so easily.

"Ambrose. Truth or dare?"

"Dare."

His smile is wicked. "I dare you to kiss Mara."

The silence that ensues is enough to make me believe that the world has stopped. That we're officially frozen in time and the sounds from the outside have joined in the standstill. No birds in the trees. No dogs barking down the street. Nothing besides the sound of my heart clanging against the bones in my chest. I shouldn't feel embarrassed—it's not my dare. But I'm terrified. I'm terrified at the idea of Ambrose kissing me and how quickly my mind tells me it's something I actually *want*. But more than that, I'm terrified of seeing his disgust at such a ludicrous dare.

Ambrose opens his mouth, then closes it just as quickly. "I don't think..."

"I knew you'd chicken out, dude. It's fine. So I dare you to dare *me* to kiss Mara." Jackson's intention suddenly becomes crystal clear. He knew that given any alternative to kissing me, Ambrose would take it. My lunch threatens to climb out of my stomach and I wring my hands in my lap.

I gather the courage to look at Ambrose but his face is unreadable. Of course he doesn't want to kiss *me*. But he's also too kind to let another boy kiss me when it's clearly something I'd rather avoid. When Ambrose fails to come to a decision, Jackson happily moves things along.

"Mara, are you ready?"

He scoots closer to me and the tree house feels ten times smaller.

It's just one kiss.

Kids my age kiss all the time. Cat has already kissed two boys in our

grade. I swing my eyes in her direction, surprised to find her watching Ambrose with an expression I can't decipher.

I dig down deep for a kernel of courage. I'm shy, but I have too much pride to let Jackson think he's won. Determination washes over me and I angle my body toward his. Not wanting to watch the gap between our lips close, I shut my eyes and lean forward.

I wait.

And then I wait some more.

I'm no expert in kissing, but I don't think it's supposed to take this long. The sound of shuffling causes my eyes to fly open, stunned to see Ambrose holding Jackson by the collar of his shirt, his face inches from his.

"This game is over now," he grits out.

Ambrose is seldom angry, which is why we're immobilized. I expect Jackson to put up a fight, but he simply nods his head and plasters on a phony expression of indifference.

"No worries," he says, smiling at me. "It's getting dark out anyway. I should head home."

We scramble to our knees and in an awkward formation, make our way down from Old Maple. Jackson is right, the sun has already set—the sky's orange tones changing to soft blues. My dad will call out for me to come inside and clean up before dinner any minute.

Jackson runs in the direction of his neighborhood and Cat squeezes me before grabbing Ambrose's hand, tugging him forcefully because she's been "holding her pee for years." I wave them off, avoiding eye contact with Ambrose as I turn around to clean the few items left scattered around the yard.

I'm throwing my jump rope into a wicker basket when a hand grabs my shoulder, turning me. Before I can process what's happening, Ambrose

leans down and kisses me on the cheek.

“That’s how I wanted to do it.”

I stare up at him blankly, and he turns on his heels, casually walking in the direction of his house. It’s unclear how long I stay glued in place. I learned in science class that our sense of smell holds strong ties to memories, but I’m positive it’s my sense of touch that will remember this moment for the rest of my life. My dad’s voice floats through the sliding door, telling me to come in and shower before dinner. I walk on wooden legs, only sure of one thing. There’s no way I’m washing my cheek clean tonight. You couldn’t even double-dog dare me.

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6

NOW

I'm an intruder in my own home.

I know these walls and I know these floors, but I feel like an intruder all the same. The creaks in the walls at night are no longer familiar and my insomnia makes them hard to ignore. A part of me expects the comfort of my childhood home to lull me to sleep.

It doesn't.

Laura flits through the house like a hummingbird, completing tasks, while I remain a background player. I can picture her now, beckoning me with that gentle smile of hers, encouraging me to try adjusting my dad's oxygen mask or change him into a fresh set of pajamas, but the coward inside pulls me to the chair in the corner of his room every time. Unlike that damn dog who elicits a smile every time he leaps onto my dad's bed, I resign myself to the silence I know I can't fill and spend my nights working on my laptop in my little corner when Laura heads home.

That's where I am tonight when I expand the tab on a project Helen's listed as important, the blue glow from my screen the only light in the room. The consistency of his faint wheezes a few feet away keep my concern at bay. Otso lays claim to the corner of the bed, his shadow a monstrous shape in the dark. It must be nice being a dog. So oblivious to the heartache we'll soon endure. As if we aren't enduring it already. If I had the privilege of such ignorance, I'd run around licking people's faces too.

I click the mouse pad, enlarging my inbox. My fatal flaw is that I respond to emails faster than text messages. It's a pathetic sort of high, filing them away in the little categorized folders I've created. A *ping* notifies me of a new email from Helen.

To: Mara Makinen

From: Helen Redford

Date: Thursday, October 12, 2021, 10:45:33 EST

Subject: Urgent!

Health House wants more one-on-one attention than we previously discussed, so I'm having them sign an agreement for your billable rate. Please print and sign the attached form below and send it back to me as soon as possible.

Thanks,

Helen Redford

I groan. Didn't we, as a society, graduate to e-signatures years ago? They're much more convenient and the cursive fonts provided always upstage my chicken scratch handwriting. I rub my eyes, unsure of where I can access a printer at this hour. The library is already closed, and it's not like the city where I can run to a Staples until eleven p.m. I sit up, suddenly remembering the printer in my old room upstairs. My dad is sure to have packed it away by now, but it wouldn't hurt to check. It's unlikely Helen would chew me out for sending the form tomorrow, but I want to make a good impression.

Since coming home, I've avoided my childhood bedroom, too afraid to look inside because I already know what I'll see—emptiness. But a part of me wants to retain the image of my room from the past rather than let it be replaced with something so foreign.

I traipse up the stairs, the light sound of paws padding behind me. Otso's closing the distance between us, eager to join, and I turn, narrowing my eyes at him. "Stalker."

He responds by panting and plopping drool onto the floor.

Classy.

I continue up a few more stairs and glance back when he doesn't move.

"What are you waiting for, an invitation?"

He grunts and follows me into the room. I don't want to see the room in its entirety, so I retract my hand before it hits the light switch, opting instead for the flashlight on my phone. Boxes are scattered against every wall, stacked on top of each other at differing heights. It reminds me of New York City and I yearn for the other half of my double life. The easier half.

An oak desk sits in the corner as the only piece of furniture left. I move closer to inspect it and jump in excitement when I see the clunky printer resting on top. I plug the dinosaur machine into the nearest outlet and do a victory dance when the green light sputters on. I'm not superstitious, but I should have knocked on the wood of the desk because the red blinking light next to the green one informs me that there's no ink. Morning field trip to the library it is.

The dust-infused room makes me sneeze four times before I walk to the window that looks out onto the cul-de-sac and crack it open, letting the crisp night air in. Every house but one is swallowed in darkness. I envy the families sleeping soundly in their beds, taking advantage of the rest night offers.

Chalking my rashness up to exhaustion, I sneak a glance at the house across the street. Once so pivotal in my life, it now looks like any ole house. Nothing's changed in seven years and the front yard is still well maintained.

A black jeep pulls into the driveway and it has me pushing my nose against the glass for a better view. My legs weaken at the thought of catching a glimpse of Mr. and Mrs. King, but I can't look away. The body that steps out of the driver's seat is tall and all I can make out is that it's a man. Even the shadows can't hide his broad chest and thick arms. He walks

around the hood of the car, stopping at the passenger side to open the door. I haven't seen Mr. and Mrs. King in years, but this isn't them.

A petite body sways outside of the car, falling into the man's arms. She practically climbs him like a tree to bury her face into his neck. She looks like she's about to collapse, but his grip is firm on her waist. Steady. My pulse quickens, but I ignore the voice urging me to look away. The voice that I'm sure is my rationale. They chat for a minute, neither one making a move toward the house.

I'm still mulling over their identities when the porch light flickers on, casting them under a direct spotlight. Ambrose stands in clear view and my heart plummets. He and the woman remain unmoving in place. She's beautiful, even from a distance. Her skin glows in the moonlight and the long silky hair falling down her back looks more pearl white than blonde. She resembles the fairy doll I used to play with when I was five and before I decide I don't like her, I remind myself that I have no right to be jealous over the man across the street cocooning her in his arms.

Ambrose's quiet confidence can make any woman swoon, but I've never allowed myself to imagine him with a partner over the years. The dust must be compromising my remaining brain cells because I crack the window another inch, attempting to eavesdrop on their intimate conversation.

I strain my ear toward their mumbling, and I can almost make out—my phone rings. The chorus to "Shoop" by Salt-N-Pepa blares out at full volume. The phone fumbles in my hand and I catch it before it cracks on the hardwood.

"Hello?" I hiss.

"Why are we whispering?" she whispers.

My heart thrums at the sound of Tally's voice even though I'm glad to hear from her. I've been slacking in the friend department. I texted her a

few times with updates about my dad, but this is the first time we've spoken on the phone.

I keep my voice low. "Why are you calling me?"

"I can't begin to explain to you how special that question makes me feel."

I flinch. "Shit. I'm sorry. I meant, why are you calling me so *late*?"

I peek out the window. Ambrose and his girlfriend or wife or whoever she is are still talking. The sight of her in his arms makes me feel ugly things and I force my eyes to seek solace in the dark room.

She talks between the sound of chips crunching. I bet she's hiding from Jeremy. "I knew you'd be awake. You're like a hamster. And besides, Jeremy's getting on my nerves—wait. Why are you whispering and why do you sound so out of breath? Are you in the middle of sex or something?"

"I'm hanging up now."

"You saucy little minx! Pass him the phone. I want to say hi."

"You're out of your mind. I'm not having sex. I'm trying to be quiet because I don't want to wake my dad."

Lie.

Her voice softens. "Oh, damn. Of course. I'm sorry, Mar."

I feel terrible for fibbing, but if she thinks I'm with a guy, this call will never end.

"I just wanted to check in on you, but I'll let you go. Swear you'll call me tomorrow so we can have a legitimate conversation instead of texting like two middle schoolers trying to play it cool?"

I smile even though she can't see me. "I swear."

I end the call and push the silent button back in place. I shut the window and tug on the heavy curtain, permitting myself one last glance. The woman no longer stands in the driveway and the automatic light has turned off, but

I can see Ambrose's large frame angled toward my house. And he's staring right at me.

The questions that riddle my mind the next morning all center around Ambrose King. *Shocking*. Why is he still living in that house? Where are his parents? Who's that woman and am I going to have to watch them live happily ever after every day that I'm here? As much as I try to convince myself I want nothing to do with the past, Ambrose remains at the forefront of my mind. The time I have left with my dad is limited and I shouldn't be wasting it consumed by thoughts of him.

Have some self-control, Mara.

After faxing over the form to Helen, I welcome the distraction of the open road by driving aimlessly around town. When I find myself in front of a run-down Nadine's Nursery, I'm surprised to see it's still open for business. As I pull in, the sound of gravel crunching under the wheels of my dad's car makes me anxious. The last thing I need is a flat, so I park far from the entrance, not willing to test my luck.

The outdoor nursery is eerie and quiet, with overgrown ivy splayed across every wall. I grab two succulents from a nearby cart, hoping the greenery will add a bit more life to my dad's barren room. I'll continue visiting him, but a person can only stare at all-white everything for so long. If I wanted to spend time in a hospital, I'd go to Seaview.

An employee pops out from the shadows and I jump, causing the mini cactus in my hand to prick my fingers.

"Hi there! My name's Grace," she chirps. Her name tag says Shannon. "Can I help you find anything?"

"Mara," I say, shaking her outstretched hand. "And I was just looking for a few low-maintenance plants. I don't really—"

“Mara as in Mara Makinen?” Her face falls.

I could lie but the town is too small. The truth would be out by tomorrow.

“Yes.”

“I’m so sorry,” she says, squeezing my hand again.

And it dawns on me that I don’t know which tragic event she’s referring to.

“Your father is a great man. Here, take these. Free of charge.” She begins shoving an array of plants into my arms before grabbing a nearby cart and filling it up. She starts toward the parking lot before I have a chance to decline the offer.

You’d think by the sorrow on her face that she’s the one with the dying father. I thank her for the plants, not having the heart to tell her I lack a green thumb. But I figure I can use the gardening to replace eye stalking Ambrose through windows.

The afternoon drags. Speck Lake is boring enough when you have friends but when you don’t, it’s downright torture. I miss the ability to walk out my door without a destination in mind and get lost among a sea of people swarming the sidewalks. My one desire in life is to fly under the radar, and Speck Lake makes me feel like I’ve been thrust back under a magnifying glass. I scratch my cheek, picturing the bottles of wine I stuck in the fridge. I want a glass to take the edge off, but it’s too early in the day to start drinking, even for me. I’ll save the liquid gold for tonight when my body evades sleep.

When I get home, I remove the plants from the trunk and haul them into the backyard. The next twenty minutes consist of pitiful Google searches on how to properly dig holes for plants and before I know it, I have thirty tabs pulled up with answers to my novice questions. How do I decide where to

put the plant? Will I need to water it every day or does the rain take care of that?

I'm rummaging through my dad's toolbox for something called a hand trowel when my peripheral catches movement. I look up, squinting at Old Maple, but nothing seems out of the ordinary. I turn back around slowly, keeping my eyes trained on the tree house in a way that isn't obvious. The second movement is barely discernible, but I see it. Someone's up there.

"Hello?"

Nothing.

I harden my voice. "I know you're up there. This isn't a spot for squatters. It's my home, so if you don't come down, I'm going to call the cops."

I pray the stranger doesn't call my bluff. David Lang's still the town sheriff and is notorious for being perpetually slow to the scene. I tighten my clutch on the hand trowel, ready to use it as a weapon if need be.

"Please don't call the cops. I'm too young to go to jail!"

A kid?

I haven't seen any kids on this street, so the admission surprises me. Where did he come from? And what's he doing in my tree house? I'm in no rush to go back to gardening and unfortunately for the boy, I decide to have a little fun at his expense.

"Fine. Come down right now and I'll make sure you don't wear an orange jumpsuit for the rest of your life."

I should be ashamed of myself, instilling the fear of God in a child, but it's the most entertained I've been all day, so I relish in the moment. A small body climbs down the old ladder at lightning speed, taking my threat of prison time a little too seriously. I bite my cheek to stop my chuckling. When his feet make contact with the grass, he turns fully toward me, eyes

wide with fear, clearly begging for mercy. His carrottopped hair sticks out in all different directions, his face home to a constellation of freckles. He can't be older than six years old. Big brown eyes flicker from me to the street and I can tell he's thinking about making a run for it, so I ease up.

"What's your name?"

"Matty!" a voice bellows from behind us.

The boy smacks a hand to his forehead. "Crap."

I don't have to turn around to know who it is. Ambrose's long strides swallow the distance between us and he halts at my side, glaring at the scrawny boy.

"Matty, where have you been? I've been looking for you for over an hour!"

It's the type of panic that fills a parent's voice when they can't find their child and unease washes over me at the idea that I might be looking at Ambrose's kid. I search for the answer on his face, but he avoids my eyes. He doesn't look as good as the day I saw him in the grocery store.

He looks better.

Serves me right.

The olive T-shirt stretched across his chest pales in comparison to his eyes under direct sunlight and his jeans hang viciously low on his hips. I quickly remove my gaze from his ass, ignoring the smell of fresh linen dancing off his skin. I can't believe I'm checking him out in front of a six-year-old.

"Sorry. I was just playing in Old Maple," Matty says, his head hung low.

Wait a minute.

"How do you know..."

Ambrose doesn't meet my eyes when he chimes in. "It's my fault, Mara. Your dad's been letting Matty play in the tree house for a while, but I forgot

to tell him it was off-limits now that you're back."

It shouldn't, but the fact that Ambrose won't even look at me feels like a knife to the side.

"Matty, you can't play here anymore. Let's go," he says, reaching out his hand.

"But—"

"Let's go. *Now.*"

Matty looks at me with desperation in his eyes, pleading for a lifeline. I don't want to be on the receiving end of Ambrose's angry grown-up voice, but I also don't want to ruin this kid's fun. Old Maple symbolized a safe place to retreat to when I was his age. If it can offer him the same kind of solace, I won't be the one to take that away.

"Actually, it's fine. I think it's great Old Maple is finally seeing some action after all these years. You're welcome to play here whenever you want, Matty," I say. "Just know that I'll be collecting your rent starting next week."

When Matty's eyes widen, I have to rush to assure him that I'm joking. I could be better with kids.

"Are you sure?" Ambrose says, finally looking at me, curiosity lining his face.

"Of course."

"Alright. If he gives you any trouble, let me know."

The brief interaction is stiff and formal and it's all my doing. I basically put a sticker on my forehead saying *Ambrose, Stay Away*. But it's better this way. I don't mind if carrottop comes over, but I don't want it to seem like an open invitation.

"I'm sure he won't be. I barely heard him up there."

He checks the time on his phone before nodding his head once. "Come

on, Matty. You need to wash up before dinner. You stink.” As he turns away, I’m only able to catch a sliver of the smile he gives Matty, but it’s enough to knock the wind out of me.

Ambrose’s large hand on Matty’s shoulder guides him in the direction of his house and once again I wonder if the last seven years have gifted him a child. Matty’s features contradict Ambrose’s, but that still leaves stepfather on the table. Hell, if that blonde pixie asked me to care for her child, I’d probably say yes too. I drop to my knees and bury my hands into the soil, letting the mess on the outside mirror the mess on the inside. But before I slip in my headphones, I catch a snippet of Matty’s voice as they exit the backyard.

“Is that the girl you played Truth or Dare with?”

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“I’m not doing it.”

“Come on, Ambrose. Please?”

“Not a chance. I told you guys I’d be Harry Potter, but this is too weird.”

“I told you a million times why we can’t do those costumes. Right, Mara?”

I look up from the book in my lap, taking in my favorite brother-sister duo. I’m no stranger to their disagreements, so tuning them out has become second nature.

We’re lounging on the floor in Cat’s room on the night before Halloween. Tiny orange pumpkins lie haphazardly around the room while felt bats hang from her ceiling. Cat loves all holidays, but Halloween is her favorite. She always says it’s the one time of year you can pretend to be someone you aren’t and get rewarded for it. And with candy of all things. I look forward to the hot apple cider, the pumpkin donuts and jumping out of dark corners to make Cat pee her pants, but the candy doesn’t hurt either. It’s our second year doing group costumes and this year Cat begged Ambrose to join in.

Our costume plans were solid until Cat called an emergency meeting after school today. Apparently, Cat heard from Sarah Winters, who heard from Caleb Santos, who heard from Macy Lang, that the Robertson triplets are also planning on being the iconic movie trio for Halloween. It’s a popular series and Speck Lake’s a small town, so it’s not surprising that our costume idea has overlapped with other kids.

“I think we can still do it if we really want to, but I get why you think the Robertsons will look better, them being triplets and all,” I say, attempting a

Switzerland approach.

“And this new costume idea is *perfect*,” she says. “It’s different. No one will forget it.”

“Of course, no one will forget it! Who would forget seeing three people walking around as the human personification of *Rock, Paper, Scissors*?” Ambrose replies incredulously.

I fake a cough to cover the laugh bubbling in my throat. I don’t mind the untraditional costume idea Cat came up with, but it *is* a bit odd.

“Besides,” he continues, “I’m thirteen now. A teenager. You two are too young to understand but my friends would tear me apart if they saw me in a costume that ridiculous.”

Cat and I blink at him, taken aback. Ambrose has never given a second thought to what anyone thinks about him, much less about what people might think seeing him with *us*. It’s the first time he’s emphasized the year between us and it feels as though an invisible line has been drawn in the sand.

I hate it.

The air grows heavy with tension and he scratches his ear in discomfort. I see the anxiety amplifying within him and I worry he’ll need to grab his inhaler from his backpack. Cat masks her hurt, adopting a flippant attitude.

“Fine. Mara and I will go as rock and scissors and you can dress up as a *teenager* or whatever it is you want to be these days,” Cat huffs.

She gathers the scraps of notebook paper off the floor where she’d doodled costume ideas and jotted down pros and cons in the margins. I watch, torn and unsure on how to remain Switzerland in this particular moment. Ambrose’s words hurt me too, but I’m not brave enough to voice it. Uncertainty mars his face as he watches Cat gather her things. Without a word, she grabs my hand, pulling me to my feet, and I realize this is the part

where we dramatically storm out.

“Wait!” Ambrose calls.

We pause at the doorframe.

“You both understand where I’m coming from, right?”

Cat’s spine straightens with confidence and I follow suit.

“No. But maybe you can explain it to us when we’re older.”

We leave and don’t look back, all the while contemplating why we’ve just excommunicated ourselves from Cat’s own bedroom.

I’m securing the elastics on my French braids while Cat laces up her knee-high Converse and I’m wondering how we got here. We match in black long-sleeved tops and tights as the base of our costumes. Thanks to the help of my dad and two rolls of Scotch tape, we were able to cut out cardboard shapes of a rock and scissors before securing them to our chests. We look absolutely ridiculous. I remind myself that at the end of the day, it’s about fun. And no matter what I wear, if I’m with Cat, tonight will be just that.

“You look perfect, *rock*.” Cat smiles.

“You don’t think I look like a potato?”

“Definitely not.”

“Why can’t I be the scissors again?” I groan.

“Because you’re not *cut* out for it,” Cat drawls, humor glinting in her eyes.

I snort as we put the finishing touches on our costumes. The plan is to start trick-or-treating in the neighborhood parallel to ours because it’s where all the well-to-do retired folks live. They’re notorious for passing out full-size candy bars instead of the chintzy mini ones. There’s a soft knock at my door and my dad’s head appears, one hand shielding his eyes.

“Are rock and scissors decent?”

“Yes, Dad.” I laugh.

“Great. You girls should get going if you want a leg up on all the cute little toddlers out there. I wouldn’t be surprised if they hog most of the inventory.”

His point is valid and I’m not sure if I should be proud or disappointed in him for basically encouraging us to steal candy from babies. *Ruthless man*. Cat and I snatch our white pillowcases off the bed.

“Is it okay if we stop by Macy Lang’s house after we trick-or-treat? Her parents are letting her throw a party in their basement for the kids from school, but they’ll be upstairs the whole time,” I recite. Cat made me practice the script she wrote all day so I wouldn’t choke up when asking my dad’s permission.

“And what exactly will a bunch of middle schoolers be doing in a basement on Halloween night?”

“Um. Well. We’ll probably play board games and trade candies... those kinds of things.”

His nose scrunches up as if I reek of suspicion. But he must remember who his daughter is and how I’ve never so much as had a bad note from a teacher because his shoulders relax.

“Fine,” he relents, leaving the room. “But no kissing!”

“Ewww!” Cat and I respond exaggeratively.

We’re no longer at the age where we find kissing gross. In fact, we welcome it. But I figure it doesn’t hurt to put on a performance for my dad if it sets his mind at ease.

Trick-or-treating is a bust. I hide my disappointment from Cat because I know how hard she’ll take it, but there’s not a single person who understands our costumes. Four people ask if I’m a potato and Cat is

reduced to office supplies. We handle the embarrassment well, but what we can't get over is the fact that we've been refused candy at multiple houses. Somewhere between last year and this year, twelve-year-olds apparently became too old to receive treats. It's ageist and unjust, and it makes my blood boil. After getting our pillowcases filled up a third of the way by the houses that take pity on us, we call it quits and walk over to Macy's.

Macy Lang's house is the most well-known house in Speck Lake. The pressure-washed, white colonial-style home sticks out like a sore thumb in our small lake town. Her dad is the head sheriff in town and her mom is the school district's superintendent. They're basically the Kennedys of our small corner on the map. Macy is the second-born child. The eldest, Brandon, is kind and laid back—the opposite of Macy—and her twin sisters, Kira and Kerrigan, are adorable, but have a knack for biting. They're seven.

The tree in their front yard boasts an idyllic tire swing and rumor has it that Macy's dad let her pick out the tree herself before paying men from my dad's construction company to come in and plant it. I heard it took over two days to finish the job because Macy kept changing her mind on where she wanted the tree to be placed. We walk up to the house, the excessive decorations stopping us in our tracks.

The stairs of the front porch light our steps with the glow from the orange-and-purple firefly lights. "Monster Mash" blares from a hidden speaker and the legs of the Wicked Witch of the West stick out from a bush. We rush to the rocking chair nearby where the biggest goblet we've ever seen sits, filled to the brim with candy. King-size chocolate bars *and* bags of cookies lie inside. There isn't a single adult manning the goods, and Cat and I give each other a knowing glance before stuffing our pillowcases.

Cat rings the doorbell and the sound is a laughing ghoul. Macy answers

the door and squeals, racing forward to hug Cat. “I’m so glad you came! Everyone’s here already. Are you supposed to be a pair of scissors? So cute!”

I don’t understand how a pair of scissors could be considered cute, but I’m not surprised. Macy adores Cat, like everyone does, and she’s constantly trying to replace me as her best friend. It’s not lost on me that my presence has yet to be acknowledged and I clear my throat.

“Oh. Mara. Hi,” she says with an expression that resembles the one you’d have if you realized you had a dead bug under your shoe.

“Hey Macy. Thanks for inviting us.” I smile, hoping the gesture thaws her ice-cold heart.

“Sure... so what are you supposed to be exactly? A potato?” She laughs.

“She’s a rock. The rock to my scissors. Like Rock, Paper, Scissors, except my brother—oh never mind. Are you gonna invite us in?” Cat hooks her arm with mine.

Macy shoots one last disapproving look in my direction. “Follow me.”

“So, Macy,” I say. “What are *you* supposed to be?”

“Do you have eyes? I’m obviously a witch.”

Yes, she *is*. And it is obvious, but I can’t help asking, knowing it’ll rub her the wrong way. The pointed hat on her head has real feathers around the brim and her tulle dress and striped stockings look like something straight from a high fashion Halloween magazine. Cat sticks out her tongue at Macy’s turned back in solidarity.

The basement is packed with kids and being that it’s Speck Lake, it’s most likely every student in grades six through eight. A disco ball hangs in the center of the room, its light bouncing off the kids playing at the pool table and vintage arcade machines. A six-foot-long table sits in the corner, decked out with every junk food you can think of. The cupcakes look like

mummies, the marshmallows look like ghosts, and a red punch fountain spews out of the mouth of a giant vampire head. Cat and I gather our food on paper plates and settle into an unoccupied corner. I allow myself a few seconds to wonder about Ambrose's whereabouts. According to Alima, he went trick-or-treating with a few of his older friends, but after the fallout the day before, we haven't seen him.

Girls flock around Cat then as if she's a beacon, guiding them to her, and she's kind enough to hold eye contact with me, telepathically sending me assurance that she won't abandon me tonight. It's not a secret that Cat severing our friendship would catapult her higher into the social status stratosphere, but she's never given me any indication that I'm not enough. Besides, sharing her with the masses means I can disappear into the background for a little while.

"I'm going to find a bathroom!" I call over the music.

Cat instantly begins removing herself from the clutches of Leonna Stine and Shai Pavarti. "I'll go with you!"

The two girls fix their glares on me, letting me know I'm being an inconvenience.

"Stay, it's fine. I'll be right back." I smile.

The downstairs den is huge, but the bodies milling about give it a lived-in feel. The rest of the house is cavernous and lonely—an exhibit on display. I glide up the velvet-lined staircase, passing paintings that are probably worth more than my house. It's quiet and I wonder where Macy's parents are. After popping my head into three different rooms, I find the bathroom at the far end of the hall. The toilet is a fancy one with too many buttons and instead of pushing what I think is the flush button, I push something that causes a spray of water to shoot out onto my costume.

"Great," I groan.

My eyes are downcast as I leave the bathroom, focused on drying my shirt with the hand towel I found. The towel falls to the floor as I bump into a firm chest.

“Oh, I’m so—Ambrose.” Ambrose’s hands are on my shoulders, keeping me from tipping over.

“Hi.” When he realizes his hands are still on me, he removes them quickly, blushing. It’s then that I look down at what he’s wearing.

Ambrose King dons a black jumpsuit with cardboard attached to his chest resembling a piece of paper. Ambrose came as *paper*. When he registers what I’m thinking, his eyes lock with mine, smiling, and I take a mental snapshot, storing the image away for safekeeping.

“Nice costume.” I grin.

He rolls his eyes and chuckles. “Yeah, yeah.”

I pretend to look confused. “What are you supposed to be?”

“Ha!” he says, shooting his hand out to tickle my side and I shriek in delight.

I flick the cardboard on his chest. “What will your friends think of you?”

“I don’t know,” he sighs. “But I realized I care what you and Cat think of me a lot more.”

The fact that he includes me in on that—that my opinion matters so much to him—it’s enough for me to think this may be the best Halloween of my life.

I cross my arms, grinning from ear to ear. “Surprised.”

“Oh, okay. Um...” He taps his chin in thought. “Birthdays.”

“Party.”

“Kids.”

“Friends.”

He hesitates but recovers quickly. “Us!”

I giggle. “You’re losing your touch, slowpoke.”

“That’s more than one word.”

“That wasn’t my word!”

He grins. “That’s four words. You do know how this game works, right?”

I playfully pinch his arm and he laughs, swatting me away. “Mara,” I say.

He looks at me in a way I don’t think I’ve ever seen him look at me before. “Pretty,” he says and we both go still.

Something blooms inside of me and I want to water it every day and let it grow because it’s one of the most beautiful things I’ve ever felt.

A group of kids race up the stairs and Ambrose and I jump like we’ve been caught doing something we aren’t supposed to. When we look at each other again, we start laughing.

“Come on,” he says, grabbing my hand. “Let’s find Cat before she sends a search party for you.”

It’s the first time I’ve ever held Ambrose’s hand and I’m suddenly convinced that my hand was made to fit perfectly inside of his. I don’t want to let him go. And I promise myself in that very moment that even when we get back downstairs, even when we find Cat and we break our physical connection, I never will.

I’ll never let Ambrose King go.

8

NOW

It's not a good idea.

"This isn't a good idea," I say, verbalizing my thought.

"Hon, I'll be back before you know it. It'll only take me forty-five minutes. An hour, tops."

"But what if he needs something? What if there's an emergency and I don't know what to do?"

It's Wednesday morning and I was enjoying a scalding mug of black coffee, catching up on work emails. I was in my element until I wasn't. It only took seven words out of Laura's mouth to throw my body into fight-or-flight mode. *I need you to watch your father.* She retrieves her keys from the fruit bowl near the sink and points at a yellow piece of paper held to the fridge by a rainbow magnet. Hers, I'm sure.

"These are all the numbers you'd ever need in case of an emergency, including mine. Mara, you're going to be fine," she says, hands on my shoulders. "I'm going to come back." She sounds like she's talking me down from a ledge. She might be.

But I refuse to go down without a fight. "Is it the store? Because I told you, I don't mind doing the grocery shopping."

"No, it's not the store. What I need to do isn't something you can help me with."

Her voice is somber, and for the first time since meeting her, she looks uncomfortable. I don't want to push, so I remain silent. But to my surprise, Laura divulges anyway. "It's my sister. She's a bit... all over the place right now and she needs me." Her mouth turns downward, and it looks unnatural on her usual chipper face.

I instantly regret my incessant protests. Of course she has her own family with her own problems and it's selfish of me to expect her to overexert herself when the whole reason I'm here is to pick up some of the slack.

"I'm sorry, Laura. Take your time. I'll be alright—I'm just being a baby."

I don't even sound convincing to myself. She graces me with one of the warm smiles I'm becoming accustomed to and moves a stray curl from my forehead. The gesture's gentle and motherly and I lean into the feeling of safety it offers.

Glancing at her watch, she quickly slips on her shoes. "I just fed your father, so no need to worry about that. He's actually having a pretty good day. He was awake and alert when I left his room. Maybe you can go in there and talk to him for a bit. I know he's been wanting to catch up with you since you've been here."

"I've spent a lot of time in his room," I reply defensively.

An amused snort comes from Laura. "How about spending some time in there when he's actually *awake*? Hmm?"

I stick my tongue out at the door she exits like a five-year-old and slam my laptop shut. The house is hushed and I realize I don't care much for the quiet during the day. It's been strangely comforting hearing Laura's humming throughout the house and the clinking of pots and pans as she makes herself food. The night is made for silence. Stillness. But the daytime? It deserves more movement, more sounds, more *life*. I crane my neck around the corner and spot Otso passed out on his doggy bed, which looks more like a twin-size bed.

I crack the door to my dad's room just slightly, careful not to wake him just in case he happened to doze off while Laura and I talked.

Please be asleep.

"Mara?" a soft voice speaks.

I mutter a curse under my breath as I enter, dragging my feet to the visitor's chair near his pillow. Nobody's ever stopped by to visit but I imagine Laura sits and talks with him sometimes. She's too kind not to.

"Hey, Dad."

Laura was right. If you're going solely off his appearance, he's having a good day. His eyes still look sunken but they're wide open instead of their usual half-mast state and his brown eyes are as warm as I remembered.

"How are you feeling?"

His voice is scratchy, but when I go to grab water, he makes a sound as if to say *leave it*. "I don't want to talk about me right now. You can see for yourself what I look like. How have you been since coming home, *princessa*?"

Only my dad would ask about me while he's on his deathbed. My shame magnifies. I don't deserve this man.

"I'm fine, Dad. You know you don't have to worry about me."

"That's *why* I worry. Your old man is wasting away in hospice and you're *fine*."

I scrunch my nose. "You're not wasting away, Dad, jeez. Don't be so morbid."

"You can't carry all of this on your own, *princessa*. It's too heavy a burden to bear, even for you. Your mom would come here if you just asked."

"Dad, the last thing we need is that woman flitting around here spewing off her criticisms of the American ways of life as if she didn't live here the majority of her life."

He laughs and it turns into a dry cough, racking his fragile body. He knows I'm right. "Laura said you've been helping spruce up the place so it'll be ready for the realtors. Thank you."

“It hasn’t been too bad.” I shrug. “You can learn pretty much anything if you’re willing to spend a few hours on YouTube.” I smile. “But I refuse to fix the planks on the front porch. Too many splinters. You’ll have to find someone else for that.”

He opens his mouth and closes it as if he’s choosing his next words carefully. “Have you seen Ambrose yet?”

My eyes narrow. “Yes. In fact, I have. Thank you for preparing me for that. It was *lovely* running into him without warning.”

His sigh is soft and I roll my eyes because this man is using his precious energy to admonish me. “I know you and you know you. If I’d told you Ambrose didn’t move away with the rest of his family, you wouldn’t have come.”

Is he right? Would I have avoided this critical time with my dad if I’d known Ambrose still lived across the street? I want to feel insulted, to tell him he’s wrong, but I can’t. The Mara from seven years ago wouldn’t have hesitated in her loyalty to the people she loved. But fear has kept me distanced from my old self for a long time. If my dad doubts my loyalty now, it’s only because I’ve given him a reason to.

“You should catch up with him. He’s turned into a fine man over the years.”

“Dad,” I warn.

“Stubborn as ever,” he says, his laughter mixing with another cough. “But... he stayed. Mara, after what happened between you two that night, he *stayed*.”

His words suck up all the oxygen in the room, making it impossible for me to catch my breath. He takes pity on me and changes the subject to topics that won’t make me squirm. We talk about my job, and our suspicions of Laura being a saint reincarnate. I grill him on the fact that he

got a dog after denying me one my entire childhood, and I promise to spend more time with him during his limited wake windows. It's not long before he falls back into unconsciousness, and when Laura comes to tell me I can go back to whatever I was working on, I tell her I'm fine right where I am.

Laura's an exceptional cook. Exceptional doesn't fully encompass what this woman is capable of in a kitchen. When she eyed me warming up ramen noodles on the stove, she snickered and dumped it down the garbage disposal before rummaging through the fridge. We're sitting around the breakfast nook as she ladles a generous helping of lemon ricotta pasta onto my plate. The smell alone is enough to elicit strange sounds from my mouth and I'm not even embarrassed about it.

"Teach me your ways, Master Laura," I moan around a bite of pasta.

She laughs. "Honey, you already know how to cook noodles. You just need to get more creative with the rest of it."

I inhale the contents of my plate along with two bread rolls drenched in garlic butter before helping myself to seconds. When I die, I hope they remember to bury me with carbs.

I take a swig of my water. "Have you always lived in Speck Lake?"

She shakes her head. "I made the move after nursing school. My parents wanted to retire here and they convinced me I wouldn't have a hard time finding a job with the demographics. I've always wanted to work in geriatrics." She smiles.

"Do you have any children?" I ask and her smile dips. I smack my palm to my forehead, groaning. "Please forget I just asked that. It's none of my business."

"No, that's okay. I wanted children," she says, looking off into the distance. "But life doesn't always move in the direction we expect."

I understand the sentiment more than I care to.

“I have a younger sister, but she’s always felt like my baby. My mother had a surprise pregnancy while I was in nursing school and when I moved here, she needed more help with Anya than I’d realized,” she says, pushing her food back and forth with her fork. “She passed away from a heart attack when Anya was five.”

“Laura... I’m so sorry.”

Her smile is sad when she says, “That’s life for you. But losing a mother at such a young age... it does a number on someone. I’m sure you can understand that. Anyway, let’s just say I’m still taking care of that girl. I may not be a real mother, but I have more than enough people to take care of these days.”

I make Laura leave the cleaning to me since she was generous enough to cook. She excuses herself to tend to my dad, graciously sparing me the details of his bathing routine. As I dry the same dish in my hand for five minutes, I think about everything she’s told me. I don’t have siblings, but there was a time when the two kids across the street made me feel like I did. Would I have put my dreams aside to take care of them if the situation called for it?

I would.

I would in a heartbeat.

The doorbell rings and I leave the kitchen, dish towel still in hand. When I open the door, a freckle-faced carrottop stares up at me.

“Hey, Matty.” I smile. “Something wrong with the tree house?”

“Do you like birds?”

I tilt my head in confusion. “Pardon?”

“Birds. You know, the animals with wings that fly around in the sky?”

Smart-ass. I raise an amused brow. “Yes, I know what *birds* are. And I’m

impartial to them. Why?”

“Ambrose is taking me to the zoo today. You should come.”

I peek across the street and see Ambrose tossing a cooler into the back seat of his jeep. He turns toward us, his expression telling me he’s just as surprised as I am to see Matty at my front door. I can hear the deep sigh he releases from where I stand. I try and fail not to focus on how good he looks today as he saunters over.

“Matty,” he says, his low voice laced with suspicion. “What are you doing?”

“I’m inviting her to the zoo!”

Ambrose clenches his jaw and I want to run my finger along the vein that appears.

Shit.

“Mara has better things to do today. Come on.”

“What better things do you have to do today, Miss Mara?”

I haven’t known Matty very long at this point, but I do know two things:

1. He’s smarter than most kids his age.
2. He has the kind of face that makes it impossible to say no to.

I actually do have things I need to get done today. Helen called me this morning to tell me that a client was unsatisfied with the mock website a fellow colleague put together and she begged me to add their project to my docket. Her begging was unnecessary because we both know I love adding extra work to my plate. It’s the perfect distraction. But a small part of me wants to go to the zoo with Matty and Ambrose, if only for nostalgia’s sake. The place holds some of my favorite memories.

Before I can give myself the chance to overthink it, I say, “I’d be up for the zoo.”

Ambrose pins me with a heavy glare. To say he doesn’t look pleased

would be the understatement of the century. “Matty, go wait for me in the car.” He points at the jeep.

“But—”

Ambrose only has to raise an eyebrow.

“Fine,” Matty huffs, making his way to the Wrangler.

I give Ambrose an awkward smile, feeling like a child who’s about to be reprimanded.

“What are you doing?”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean, what are you *doing*, Mara? You basically told me to fuck off and now you want to spend the day with me and Matty? You’re being confusing as hell.”

I blow out a breath. “You’re right. I’m sorry—I’m not being fair.”

Ambrose grunts in agreement but doesn’t move. Deep down, I know I shouldn’t be spending time with him. I’d told him what I wanted and he respected my decision. It’s unfair of me to play the hot-and-cold game. But if I’m being honest with myself, I’m lonely. Work only consumes a fraction of my time, Tally is too far to keep me distracted and Laura is becoming suspicious of the never-ending supply of alcohol in the fridge.

If I can just have one day to escape the thoughts my solitude stirs up, I will gladly punish myself with isolation for the rest of my stay. As if Ambrose sees my internal struggle, he turns away from the house without a word, his jaw tight, motioning for me to follow. I thrust my feet forward before he can change his mind and my shoelace catches on a piece of wood sticking up from the stairs, causing me to stumble face-first. His arm shoots out and clutches my waist, saving me from eating concrete. Ambrose holds me tight in his arms, his minty breath falling over my cheek. He lets me go abruptly and continues toward the car, flexing his hand by his side as if

touching me burns.

My ears aflame with embarrassment, I offer shotgun to Matty. He's stoked until Ambrose informs us that six-year-olds use booster seats and I'm once again reminded how little I know about children. Ambrose drives in silence, granting every song request Matty has, including a mind-splitting tune about a baby shark.

When we finally reach the zoo, I'm comforted to see it hasn't changed in the slightest. It's like it was thrown into a state of stagnancy and time danced around it, never pulling it into its orbit. It's the parking lot that shocks me the most. It hosts more cars than I thought existed in Speck Lake. How did the zoo get more popular while the rest of the town fell to shambles? We get in line and before I have the chance to pull my wallet out, Ambrose hands me an all-exclusive wristband.

"Oh. You didn't have to cover for me," I say.

"I didn't."

Okay.

Matty tugs on the hem of my shirt. "Ambrose always gets us in for free because it's his zoo!"

I assume Matty's referring to an employee guest pass of sorts, so I don't think much of it. We start with the amphibian exhibit before reaching the aviary enclosures. Matty runs to the birds and pulls a tiny journal from his pocket. Déjà vu washes over me and my heart aches to go back in time when that little boy was Ambrose, his eyes lighting up with awe in the same way.

Ambrose motions me over to a small picnic table off to the side and I follow. He pulls out a thermos and fills the cap up to the rim. "Coffee?"

"Yes, please." He pushes the cap toward me, opting to drink straight from the thermos himself.

We drink in silence while we watch Matty watch the animals. It's not the most comfortable silence I've ever experienced, but it's not stifling either.

"He's lucky to have you," I say, swirling my coffee.

Ambrose's eyes remain glued on Matty like the responsible adult he is. "You'd think that. But I'm the lucky one, really. I was just going through the motions before Matty. Eat, work, sleep, repeat. He reminded me that we need people. Relationships."

The little devil on my shoulder pushes me to pry. "Well, he couldn't have asked for a better father. I'm sure his mother feels the same."

Ambrose looks at me with an expression I can't decipher. "Matty isn't my son."

"Oh. I guess stepdad—"

"No." He shakes his head. "Matty isn't my son, period. I'm his big brother."

When my face crumples in confusion, he clarifies.

"Big brother, as in the Big Brother's Club. I joined three years ago and got paired up with Matty. He doesn't have the best homelife, so I take him a lot of the time when I'm not busy with work."

The more I mull over Ambrose's words, the more it all makes sense. Ambrose had always been the best big brother to Cat. Matty couldn't have asked for someone better to look out for him.

"I saw the woman at your house. I guess I thought... I thought you were all together."

His Adam's apple bobs around his coffee. "You saw his mom. We were together for a while, but things got complicated. Something kept getting in the way."

"What?" I ask without thinking.

Ambrose's eyes bore into me. "Don't ask questions you already know the

answer to.”

I shouldn’t feel relief, but I do. My pathetic heart clings to the fact that Ambrose is no longer involved with the woman who could’ve easily been mistaken for a Victoria’s Secret model. I want to ask more about their situation but I stop while I’m ahead.

“So, you work here, huh?” I say, switching gears to lighter material. “I’d say I’m surprised, but that would be a lie. You would have lived here if you could when we were kids.”

Ambrose tops off my coffee. “I own the place.”

“Come again? I think I misheard you.”

“The zoo. It’s mine. I bought it.”

“You bought... the zoo. When did you buy the fucking zoo?”

“*Language*. This is a family establishment,” he says, but the corner of his mouth tips up just slightly. “When I graduated from college with my business degree, I didn’t know what I wanted to do with it. You know my dad, he always pushed us to be practical. When I came back home, the zoo was going under like a lot of other businesses in town and I couldn’t let that happen. Too many memories. So, I took the leap and got a loan to purchase it. The place always had great bones; it just needed some modern-day marketing.”

“Ambrose, that’s amazing!” I gush. “Your family must be so proud.”

“Yeah, I’d like to think so.”

We engage in more small talk about our jobs. A safe topic. I fill him in on what I’ve done for work over the years and we fall into a familiar rhythm, almost as if the past doesn’t exist at our tiny picnic table. I want to stay here forever.

On the way home, we drive with the windows down, letting the cool evening air kiss our faces. Matty’s passed out in the back and even my eyes

become heavy. My exhaustion is catching up with me, regardless of the coffee I downed at the zoo. Ambrose taps his fingers on the steering wheel, humming a song I can't put my finger on, and when we pull into his driveway, I catch a glimpse of Matty's mom standing up from the curb. As Ambrose carries a sleeping Matty from the car, she rushes to his side, her face scrunched with irritation.

"I could have taken him today. That was really shitty of you not letting me come, Ambrose." Her eyes fly to me. "But I see you had no problem inviting *her*," she hisses.

Ambrose's voice is low, but stern. "You and I both know why you weren't there today. Don't play stupid, Anya."

Anya? The name sounds familiar, but I can't place it.

"Oh, bite me, asshole. You can stop pretending like you're his father. Give him to me," she snaps.

Ambrose squints his eyes at her in the dark, noticing something I can't see from where I stand. His voice gentles when he says, "Anya... you don't look good. Why don't you come inside?"

"Give him to me!"

She yanks on Matty's slack body, pulling him into her arms. Ambrose looks like he wants to protest, but she has a point. He isn't Matty's father and there isn't much he can do to stop her from taking him. No matter the circumstances. Beads of sweat break out on her forehead and as beautiful as she is, Ambrose is right. She doesn't look good. She turns away, stomping off toward her house next door. Tension locks in Ambrose's shoulders and I can tell it irks him, me witnessing something so personal after being gone so long. He flings the car door shut and slams his fist on the hood.

"Ambrose," I start.

"Go home, Mara."

He turns on his heel and disappears into his house. And it's not until I'm twisting the key in my front door that I realize I came face-to-face with Laura's little sister.

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9

THEN (AGE 13)

I've avoided mirrors for two weeks until today. The foreign alien stares back at me in the mirror. When my mom held me captive on the phone, against my will, I might add, to discuss what happens when a young lady's body goes through "changes," this isn't what I was expecting. I look like a caterpillar entering a cocoon to transform, but instead of turning into a butterfly, I've remained the scary creature midtransition.

I hit a growth spurt, which isn't saying much because even though my limbs look spiderlike and long, I'm still short. The curls on my head have lost their childlike appeal and now, they're untamed and overwhelming against the backdrop of my aforementioned spider arms. The new developments on my chest are worst of all. While Cat lucked out with boobs that made even Macy Lang jealous, I've been gifted a pair of anthills. Big enough to require a training bra, but small enough to be made fun of for said training bra.

I suppress the memory of my mom calling my dad, informing him that he needed to take me to buy my first bra. He took the mission in stride, his Finnish strength absolving any hint of discomfort or embarrassment. His confidence only exacerbated my discomfort. Nothing in the world could have prepared me for my own father knowing more about the changing female body than me. And while I'm sure one day I'll appreciate his extensive research and parental proactiveness, that day is far away.

He had to practically drag me into the intimates section of the department store. "Mara, we need to have you measured to find your cup size."

I groaned, slapping my hands over my ears. "Dad. For the love of God, please don't say *cup size*."

“Oh, *princessa*. You shouldn’t be ashamed of your body. You’re a woman now. I know you’d rather have your mother here, but we can get through this together, right?”

He was wrong. My mom would’ve made the experience ten times worse.

I glanced around before finally conceding. “Fine. But let’s hurry, please.”

I study my appearance in the full-length mirror one more time before throwing my hands up in defeat. No matter how long I stand here, nothing’s going to change this second. I do the one thing Cat tells me that always makes her feel better on days she doesn’t feel pretty. I smile at myself. A full-out, say-cheese-for-the-camera smile. I ignore the metal and rubber bands encasing my teeth and the smile lifts my mood slightly. I move to my bed, throwing my favorite hoodie over my head. I refuse to spend any more time in front of the mirror. There are more important things in life.

I scoop up my bike from the garage and ride over to Cat’s. I could walk, but these days we spend a lot of time riding over to the convenience store with her on my pegs. Cat owns her own bike and it’s a million times better than mine, but she says she feels safer with me leading the way. Probably because she eats reckless pills for breakfast and attempts stunts on her bike that leave her with all kinds of injuries.

I hop off, walking my bike up the driveway, and see Ambrose and his friends hanging around, fixing up an old four-wheeler. I have no idea when Ambrose got into four-wheelers, but that isn’t much of a surprise. Ever since he’s started high school, he’s changed. Gone is the boy who shamelessly hung out with his little sister and her best friend. Now, you can’t find him without the most popular kids in their grade glued to his side. *The Lucky Four*, people call them.

Jackson Healy—Speck Lake’s youngest and most notorious player. Jackson never goes out of his way to ignore me, but he makes it clear he

isn't interested in wasting *too* much of his breath on an eighth grader. Shayla Marks sits on Jackson's lap. She moved to Speck this year, but she has a face that drew her into the most desirable social circle without hesitation. She's tall and has long limbs like me, but where mine look gangly, hers looks ready to strut down a runway. Her deep skin glows under the sun and she constantly refers to herself as the next Naomi Campbell, even though none of us knows who that is.

Beside her is the girl who manages to stick closer to Ambrose than the very clothes on his back. Sasha Baker, Ambrose's girlfriend, is my personal tormentor. I'm unsure who offered her the job, but she takes it very seriously. If they had awards for this kind of thing, she would get employee of the year. Her chestnut-colored hair and soft hazel eyes make her look sweet and approachable until she opens her mouth.

Ambrose's back faces me as she eyes me with pure disdain. "Oh look, Ambrose. Your stalker's here."

Ambrose turns, surprised to see me even though I visit like clockwork. He doesn't defend me, turning his attention back to the bolts on the ATV.

Jackson sees the heat in my face and graces me with a small dose of pity. "What's up, Makinen?"

"I'm just waiting for Cat," I mumble.

Shayla cackles into Jackson's neck. "Shocker. Say, Marta, do you have any other friends? It's kinda messed up that you make Cat hang out with you all the time."

If the heat from my face could ignite a fire, we'd all be burning in the driveway. "I don't make her do anything." My eyes sting at the accusation.

Sasha sticks out her bottom lip in a pout. "Aw, sure you do."

The front door opens, and footsteps run toward us. Cat throws an arm around me, her smile almost making me forget the interaction I'm being

forced to endure.

“Ready to go?” she asks, breathless.

I nod my head, not trusting myself to speak. I can usually master my emotions, but if Cat hears my voice, all bets are off. Suddenly memories of my mom calling me oversensitive flit across my mind and it’s like a switch is activated in my brain. I bury my emotions deep under a mountain of bricks.

Sasha clears her throat. “Cat, you know, you could hang out with us today. They say in order to get an animal to stop following you, you just have to ignore it.”

Everyone laughs except Ambrose, but his silence wounds me just the same.

Sasha narrows her eyes at me. “Because that’s what you are, Mara, the *mouse*. Following this poor girl around like she’s a pound of cheese.”

Tears threaten to overflow as I stare holes into the back of Ambrose’s head and I know he senses it because his back goes ramrod straight. Did he tell his friends he calls me mouse? Did the endearing nickname become the punch line to some cruel inside joke? I used to love it but now it sounds warped and ugly coming from Sasha’s mouth.

“What’s wrong?” she snorts. “Cat got your tongue?”

Shayla wheezes as if she’s never heard anything funnier in her life. Even Jackson chuckles at the insidious pun.

Cat takes a step forward, tapping her finger to her chin thoughtfully. “You know, I have heard that before. The whole, ‘ignore an animal if you want it to go away.’ But it must not work because I’ve been trying to ignore you since the day we met, Sasha.”

Sasha’s face goes sheet white.

“And if you’re wondering what animal you are, you can ask anyone.

You're a bitch."

Sasha and Shayla gasp in unison and Cat snatches my hand, pulling me toward the bike. She climbs on my pegs and we barely make it to the first stop sign before we burst into a fit of laughter.

"When I die, bury me with chocolate."

Cat and I sit on the curb outside of the convenience store, indulging in the weekly treats we buy with our leftover lunch money. I've already finished my Twix, but Cat's savoring every bite of her king-size Snickers bar.

"I can definitely do that," I say.

"But only Snickers. If you try to pull a fast one on me and throw in Kit Kats or something, I'll come back from the grave and haunt you."

I chuckle. "I wouldn't dare try to deceive your ghost."

She inhales a chunk of her Snickers and crumbs fall onto her chin. "What do you want it to be like when you die?" she mumbles, mouth full.

My eyebrows furrow. "What do you mean? I don't think I have much say in the matter."

"Like, what do you want to wear? Where do you want to be buried? What song do you want us to dance to in your honor?"

I fiddle with my shoelaces as I think. "I don't know. I've never thought about it. Have you?"

Cat snorts in amusement. "Absolutely. I want to wear a lavender dress. Like the one from *Holly's Greatest Adventure*. I want to be buried under a huge tree. The biggest tree there is. So everyone can come and rest under me," she says, a soft smile lining her face. "Oh, and my song of choice is hands down 'Shake A Tail Feather.'"

I gape at her. "Why on earth would you want that song played at your

funeral?”

“Because no one can stay sad listening to that song.”

“But Cat... it’s a funeral. It’s supposed to be sad.”

She contemplates that for a second. “No.” She shakes her head. “When I die, I don’t want people to be wrapped up in their sadness. I want them to remember the happy stuff. I want them to remember that I made them laugh. Made them dance.”

Before I can disagree, Cat stuffs the Snickers wrapper into her pocket and jumps up in front of me. She yanks me off the curb and begins twisting her hips, bending at the knees.

I can’t stop the giggles that escape my throat. “What are you *doing*?”

“I’m making you dance! This is how you’re going to remember me!”

She continues pulling on my arms, whipping her head back and forth to the nonexistent music. If it were anyone else, I’d be mortified. But when you’re around Cat, her confidence leaks onto you. It’s like she shields you with her self-assurance and you become bold by association. We dance together, right there in the middle of the parking lot, uncoordinated and unabashed. People leaving the convenience store pin us with wary stares, but we dance until our legs ache. And then we dance some more.

We take our time walking back to our neighborhood. I pull my bike alongside me, too exhausted to ride it with Cat on the back.

“Why do you think Ambrose hangs out with them?” I whisper.

I don’t need to provide context. Cat always understands my train of thought.

She sighs. “I don’t know. He hasn’t been himself lately. He’s so angry all the time.”

I think about that. He does seem different, but I’ve chalked it up to him becoming a high schooler. But Cat knows Ambrose like the back of her

hand and sometimes it's almost as if she's the older sibling.

"Don't get me wrong," she continues. "He's been a total douchebag. But I think he's carrying the weight of something heavy. He just won't tell me what it is. I kinda feel sorry for him."

I kick a rock out of my path. "I wish things could go back to how they were. Growing up sucks."

Cat hums in agreement and we walk for a while in silence. "I think my parents are getting a divorce."

I stop in my tracks. "*What?*"

She's already sniffing back tears. "They've been arguing a lot. They think we don't hear, but the walls are thin. I want to ask my mom about it, but I don't think I want to know. At least right now I can pretend it's not happening."

I understand all too well what she means and my heart breaks for her. I want to shield Cat from what divorce can do to a family.

"I think that's why Ambrose has been so distant. It's like he knows something I don't. He barely talks to me anymore."

Her sniffles grow into a full-on sob and I let my bike crash to the ground, enveloping her in my arms. I stroke her back. "I'm so sorry, Cat. I don't even know what to say."

She wipes the snot from her nose with her sleeve. "Why do people give up on the ones they love?"

Her question shakes me to my core. "I don't know. I wish there was an answer, but I'm not sure there is."

"Promise me something."

"Anything."

"Promise me we'll never leave each other. No matter what happens, no matter how many fights we have along the way... we'll never abandon each

other.”

I reach for her hand, wrapping her delicate pinkie around mine. “I promise.”

That night we curl up on the cloud sofa in Cat’s den. The sofa is so deep, we can extend our bodies and still have enough room for a fort of pillows and blankets. We decide on a movie night and Cat pops in our favorite, *Practical Magic*. We used to save the movie for Halloween, but at some point it became our comfort movie. We resonate with the premise of two sisters who’d do anything for each other. And there’s magic, so *duh*. A bowl of popcorn bigger than our heads is nestled between us and we’re wearing what we’ve penned as our “Sad Socks.” A pair of fuzzy socks with puppies and ice cream cones all over them. We have a difficult time staying sad with them on.

“I can’t believe I don’t have Nicole Kidman’s hair from this movie.”

I chuckle. “Just from this movie?”

She nods vehemently. “Yes. Her hair is something else in this movie. It’s iconic.”

I don’t disagree. It *is* iconic.

“Why do you get to be Nicole’s character anyway? Maybe I want to be her.”

Cat pats my leg mockingly and squeals when I swat it away. “Come on, you know you’re more like Sandra Bullock’s character!”

I gasp. “Why, because I’m boring?”

“She is *not* boring. She’s responsible and loyal. And give our girl some credit, she has killer hair in this movie too.”

I’m complaining for the heck of it, but what Cat says holds some truth. She resembles the wild boy crazy character, while I’m more like the sister who follows the rules and keeps her heart guarded with an iron gate.

“Cat, have you seen my tennis racket?” Ambrose asks, walking into the den. He pauses at the foot of the sofa. His shoulders tense, uncomfortable at the sight of me. What did I do to make him dislike me so much?

“It’s in my room next to my closet.”

Ambrose’s eyes narrow. “Why is my racket in your room?”

Cat’s unfazed by the irritation in his voice. “I was having a concert. I used it as a microphone.”

“I’m not even going to ask.” He sighs heavily before bounding up the stairs.

When I get home that night, my dad is sitting in the kitchen, engrossed in a pile of books and I squeeze his shoulder. “Hey, Dad.”

He lowers his glasses down the bridge of his nose and embraces me in a side hug. Warm and steady. That’s my dad. “Mara, what on earth happened to your hand?” he gasps.

I angle my body, pulling the hand wrapped in white gauze and tape out of view, and the lie comes easily. “Cat and I were dancing at the convenience store earlier and we got a little too excited. I tripped and fell on some rocks, no biggie.”

His eyes soften. “You inherited my two left feet, *princessa*.”

I slide into the chair next to him. “I sure did. What’s for dinner?”

“Actually, there’s something I want to talk to you about first.”

I freeze at the uncertainty in his voice. “Okay...”

“I told your mother it would be better if she spoke with you about this, but she insisted that every time she calls you, the call drops. She thinks there’s something wrong with our landline,” he says, raising an eyebrow.

I bite my tongue, refusing to admit I’ve hung up on my mom more times than I can count. I’m content allowing her to believe it has something to do with our signal and not the irritation her voice causes me. “That’s so weird.

Maybe we should have the phone checked.”

His expression is skeptical. “Like I said, your mother has some news she wants me to share with you.”

“Let me guess. She’s starting another business. Painting and bread baking this time. Or, let me see, she’s moved into another flat because she wasn’t feeling inspired enough by her old one. Or maybe she—”

“She’s getting married, sweetheart.”

The only thing I can hear is the sound of me and my dad breathing. I try to identify the emotions washing over me. I’m not sad. I’m not angry. I’m not even surprised if I’m being honest with myself. I feel nothing at all.

My dad puts his hand over mine, his eyes hopeful. “What are you feeling right now?”

I purse my lips. “I don’t feel anything, Dad. If she wants to get married, she should do that.”

He doesn’t look convinced.

I squeeze his hand and smile to show him I’m okay. “I’m *fine*. Thank you for telling me. I’m going upstairs to change. Can you get me when dinner’s ready?”

He nods slightly, concern pinching his eyes. I think he expects me to cry, but like my mom said when I was six years old, crying won’t change anything. I exit the kitchen before he can further psychoanalyze me. I’ve learned disappointment is a by-product of expectation. I no longer expect things from my mother, so she no longer has the ability to make me spiral. You can’t change people; I know that now. And I will no longer concern myself with begging people to stay. Begging them to want me back. I’ll take what I can get from those who will give it.

My mind drifts to Ambrose. The Kings have their own mess to muddle through. I want to be understanding but a part of me resents him and his

decision to ice me out in the midst of his pain while Cat pulls me closer in hers. His actions won't sway my emotions anymore. If he doesn't want to be friends, so be it.

I throw myself face-first into my bed, craving sleep until my twentieth birthday. I can't imagine life is this hard when you're an adult. One day, Cat and I will leave Speck Lake together. We've already talked about the places we dream of going. Cat's set on California because of the never-ending sunshine and surfer boys, but I always make my case for New York City. She said she'd consider it when I dangled the idea of going to Broadway shows every weekend.

I hold the picture frame on my nightstand above my face. Me, Cat, and Ambrose stare at the camera, huddled so close, you can't see where one body ends and the other begins. It's from last Halloween when Ambrose surprised us by participating in our group costume at the last minute. The flash from the camera washes out the background, but if I squint hard enough, I can make out Sasha Baker pouting off to the side. She has nothing to worry about now because she has Ambrose in her clutches, but this picture... it's just for me. A moment in time immortalized. Something that can't change no matter what happens from here on out.

Cat smiles brightly at the camera, throwing up her signature peace sign. It's one of the reasons it's my favorite, but something else convinced me to keep this particular photo at my bedside for the last year. I run my fingers over the frame. Ambrose and I hold up peace signs as well, our way of mocking Cat at the time. Our smiles are just as bright, but we aren't smiling at the camera.

We're smiling at each other.

10

NOW

“Oh honey, I can’t watch any longer. It’s hurting my eyes.”

I’m on my knees, attempting to pull rusted nails out of a dilapidated porch stair. I broke a sweat ten minutes ago when I managed to lift the nail maybe an inch. Laura watches me with the most pitiful look I’ve ever seen.

I wipe the sweaty hairs from my face. “Very funny. Are you on your way out?”

She’s still wearing the top from her scrubs, but she’s changed into a pair of jeans. “I am. My sister was a no-show at my nephew’s school today and they just called me to come pick him up.”

I pick at a frayed thread on my work gloves. “Anya, right? Yeah, I think I met her.”

Laura frowns. “You met her when?”

“The other day. Ambrose invited me to the zoo with him and Matty. We saw Anya when we got back.”

What I don’t tell her is that Anya looked strung out. She also looked like she wanted to feed me to a group of sharks. Which, thanks to Ambrose and his uncanny knowledge of animals, I know is called a *shiver*.

Laura fiddles with her bag. “And how was that?”

“She seemed like a nice girl!” I say, my voice pitchy.

“Ha! Now I know you’re lying. Listen, Mara... I love my sister. Lord knows I do. I would walk through fire for that girl, but she has baggage. Where she goes, trouble follows. That’s just the name of her game. So, trust me when I tell you to keep your distance. No use in spending time around the things or *people* in her orbit.”

Her subliminal warning is about as subtle as a freight train.

I tug on the nails with a heightened level of aggression. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Yeah and I’m Beyoncé. Don’t think I don’t see you staring at that house all day long, pining like a teenage girl.”

My mouth drops. “I do not *pine*.”

“Honey, you pine. She pines. Hell, even I pine. That man is someone worth pining for. All I’m saying is, be careful. You have a lot on your plate here.”

Some might think Laura is overstepping her boundaries, being my dad’s nurse and all, but I no longer see her as an employee whose only job is to clock in and out. She’s a friend and I’m thankful for her presence. She’s made my stay more bearable, considering the circumstances. If she has advice to offer, I’ll gladly take it.

“I hear you, Laura. Ambrose and I are just... well we aren’t even friends really. We’ve just known each other since childhood, that’s all.”

Laura cackles as she descends the stairs. “*That’s all.*”

I roll my eyes as she peels out of the driveway. I’m rewarding myself with a ten-minute break, chugging my third glass of water, when I hear a knock at the door. Otso races ahead of me, barking like I’m a damsel in distress and he’s my protector—the enemy being whoever stands on the other side of this door. Jumping on his hind legs, he scratches the door as his first plan of attack.

“Down, boy! I just repainted this, you little shit.”

I grab his collar, doing my best to pull him behind my small frame before opening the door a crack. Ambrose stares back at me, a large duffel slung over his shoulder.

“Ambrose... what are you doing here?”

“I’m here to work on the house.”

I tilt my head. “What do you mean?”

He looks down at Otso who’s soaking my hand in drool. “I came to fix some things around the house. I do it all the time, Solomon already knows about it.”

Why didn’t my dad or Laura mention anything? “That’s nice of you... but that’s unnecessary. I’ve been fixing things myself.”

Ambrose glances behind him at the porch stairs I’ve been working on with a look of amusement. “I can see that.”

“Like I said, we really appreciate it but we’re all good here.”

Ambrose gives me a tight smile before turning on his heels. “I’ll be working on the back patio if you have any questions about these stairs. Otso, come, boy.”

Otso rushes after him, pulling me forward, causing me to face-plant with the doorframe.

“Ow, fuck,” I mutter.

Not only has Ambrose disregarded everything I’ve said, he’s stolen my damn dog too.

By a quarter past five, I’m drenched with sweat after slaving away over the porch stairs. I want to have a very long discussion with whoever thought it was a good idea to construct stairs out of a material prone to rot. The sun still scorches overhead and my brown skin has deepened significantly just after a few hours outside. I’m terrible about wearing sunscreen, but it’s nearly impossible to remember such a thing when you never get sunburned. I blame my Caribbean roots. I wipe the sweat from my upper lip and examine my progress.

Planks of wood surround me on the ground and I give myself a mental pat on the back. Ambrose underestimated my ability to remove these

wooden bastards. He's still in the backyard working. I only saw him a handful of times in the last couple of hours when he'd walked into the house for a bathroom break or a glass of water. He said nothing but constantly looked at my progress, laughing under his breath. Bastard. He probably thinks my time in New York has stripped me of all my handiwork skills, which were minimal to begin with, but he can't be more wrong.

I brush my hands on the coveralls I borrowed from my dad's closet and begin sorting the wood into discard piles. I'm debating whether I should treat myself to a milkshake or cookies or both when Ambrose appears around the corner. He stops, staring at the empty space that used to consist of porch stairs, his hands propped on his hips. My skills have stunned him into silence. *Go me.*

My smile is smug. "Took a while, but nothing a determined woman can't handle."

Ambrose scratches at the scruff on his chin and the act sends a chill up my spine.

"When are you putting the new stairs in?" he asks, looking around.

I pause. "Come again?"

He tilts his head in my direction, squinting his eyes away from the sun. "You got all the stairs out, but when are you installing the *new* ones?"

I look back to the empty space where stairs should be in order to access the front door.

I still need to install the new stairs.

How has that thought not crossed my mind? I've been so focused on removing them, I forgot about replacing them entirely. The little pride I had drains from my body into the ground beneath my toes. I inhale a few deep breaths, but the hours spent in the heat make my blood simmer beneath the surface.

I rarely let my emotions get the best of me, if ever, but I explode like a defective pressure cooker. “*Motherfuckingbitch!*” I stomp my feet. “*Ayúdame, Santa Maria,*” I groan, throwing my head back.

Lost in my anger, I walk over to one of the piles of discarded wood and begin stuffing it into a garbage bag, forgetting to use gloves. A sliver of wood buries itself deep beneath the skin of my palm and I cry out in pain.

Ambrose, suddenly at my side, grabs my hand and when I try to tug it away, he yanks me closer. “Stop squirming and I can fix it,” he grinds out.

He closes the space between us and I’m almost flush with his chest. He prods the splinter with his thumb and I yelp.

“Ow!”

“Don’t be such a baby,” he whispers and I can smell the mint on his breath.

Heat pools in my core from his nearness and I begin counting down from one hundred to distract me from what his touch is doing to my body.

“I can’t get it,” he grunts.

“Just leave it,” I beg. “It’s not that bad—ow!”

Ambrose tilts my palm to get a better view before lowering his hot mouth onto my skin. He starts sucking and when a small gasp escapes me, I see his shoulders visibly tense but he doesn’t stop.

He sucks at the meaty part of my palm and the sight of his full lips around my flesh...

Kill me now.

A second later, Ambrose raises his head and there between his teeth is the piece of wood.

“Thanks,” I murmur, cradling my hand to my chest.

“Mhm.” He looks back at my mess. “Don’t be too hard on yourself. Not everyone’s good with their hands.” I jerk my eyes upward to find a playful

glint in his eyes.

He's teasing me.

I give him a mocking look. "If you're such a pro, let's see what you've accomplished."

I start in the direction of the backyard, more than happy to walk off my sexual frustration, and Ambrose follows in silence. When I come up on the back patio, I can't help but gawk. It's *incredible*. It looks like he snuck a construction team in to help him without me noticing. The patio has a fresh coat of paint—an eggshell white that makes the wooden accents of the house pop. Outdoor tiles lie perfectly in a herringbone pattern and there are chairs around a new steel firepit. Multicolored pebbles lie around the plants I've planted, giving everything a crisp, modern look.

"It's amazing," I breathe.

Ambrose shifts uncomfortably under the praise. "I still need to incorporate some other decor features, but this will do for now. The plants you put in were perfect."

He's being kind and my heart squeezes. We walk back to the front of the house and he helps me throw all my garbage into contractor bags, *with* gloves this time.

"I really don't know what I'm going to do," I say. "I didn't even order the materials for the new stairs yet. Who knows how long that's going to take to get here. Laura's going to have a field day with this one." I slap my forehead. "*Laura*. How is she supposed to get into the house?"

"Just tell her to use the back entrance for now, she'll understand. And don't worry about the install for the new stairs, I'll take care of it."

"How?"

"I know a couple of guys who have materials for projects like this just lying around. A few of them worked with your father back in the day."

I offer him an out I hope he won't take. "You don't have to do that. You've already helped enough and I know you're not letting my dad pay you a dime."

His casual shrug confirms my suspicion. "Why *are* you doing all of this for free?"

"I owe Solomon."

That gets my attention. "For what?"

He glances at his watch before clearing his throat. "Let me know a good time to bring the materials over and I'll get started."

His dance around the subject only fuels my curiosity. "Well, if you're not going to let us pay you, then the least I can do is thank you with a drink. Beer at Duffy's?"

I watch Ambrose's guard go up. I'm giving him mixed signals again. I'm giving myself mixed signals. But I can't help being pulled back to him, no matter the amount of guilt it causes me. My face falls. "I'm being confusing again, aren't I?"

"Yes." He's breathing heavy from being in the heat too long and lifts an inhaler from his pocket to his lips. He keeps his eyes trained on me as he pumps it and I mentally slap myself for thinking about his mouth.

Again.

"You're doing my dad a huge favor. The least I can do is be cordial. It's not like one drink makes us friends or anything." I laugh, but it's breathy. Unconvincing.

His eyes turn molten as they slowly rake down the length of my body, his gaze catching on the wet patch of tank top clinging to my ribs and my mouth goes dry. "I've never wanted to be your *friend*. I'll be back in an hour and then we can go."

Once he's out of sight, I raise my face up to the sky, letting the sun's light

blind me as I exhale. I've made a lot of bad decisions in my life but none of them have made my heart race as fast as Ambrose Young.

Duffy's is shockingly empty for being the only bar in town. Granted, it's a Tuesday before six p.m. We have no problem securing a seat—it's one of the perks of living in a small town. To get into a decent bar in New York means being prepared to wait upward of forty-five minutes or praying to the gods that some guy will find you attractive and offer his stool. If not, you can bet you'll be standing the entire night, knowing you'll have to elevate your aching feet later.

Duffy's is an Irish bar, which is hilarious because the owner, Lorenzo, is as Italian as they come. It has a warm, rustic feel and the acacia furniture looks even better with age. Ireland's national flags adorn the walls and the only option for entertainment is an ancient jukebox and an open mic.

Ambrose picked me up in his Wrangler exactly one hour after I'd made a complete fool of myself. He left his scruff untouched but used a pomade to keep the hair out of his eyes. His black jeans are fitted and his crew neck with long sleeves covers his big arms, though no one would blame him for showing them off. He's effortlessly attractive. I catch a whiff of his clean scent and have to stop myself from moving closer.

Everything I packed for my trip was either fancy enough for my remote work meetings or casual enough to lounge around the house in, no middle ground. Which is why I'm wearing a silky black camisole I usually wear under my blazers with an old pair of distressed Levi jeans. When I got in the car, Ambrose looked at me and said nothing before putting the shift into drive.

"Want to sit at the bar?" he asks.

"Sure."

Before our butts connect with the barstools, a voice explodes from behind us. “Well, I’ll be damned! Do I spy with my little eye, Solomon Makinen’s girl?”

Warmth spreads through me at the sound of the thick Italian accent. The graying man approaches the bar. Lorenzo’s five foot two, but his personality makes him the biggest guy in any room.

“Lorenzo.” I laugh. “It’s so good to see you!” I lean forward for double cheek kisses.

I’ve known Lorenzo since I was a baby. He was a part of my dad’s construction company before it went under. Thankfully, he’d already opened Duffy’s a few years prior and it provided him with a financial safety net. And thankfully, my dad had enough savings for the fallout. Most of the other men my dad worked with weren’t so lucky.

“It is good to see you, *cara*. Ambrose, nice to see you, my good man.”

Ambrose leans over the bar for a hug, clapping him on the back. “Always a pleasure, Renz.”

“What can I get you two?”

I look at Ambrose. “We’ll start with two pale ales?”

He nods. I pull my card out, sliding it toward Lorenzo.

“And you can keep the tab open.”

Lorenzo *tsks*. “Put that card away, *cara*. You think I take money from Solomon Makinen’s girl? Don’t be silly.”

I insist, but he’s not having it. I throw my hands up in defeat, accepting the generosity.

It takes a few beers, but eventually Ambrose and I fall into easy conversation.

“Okay. So you own the zoo. You’re a member of the Big Brother program. What else have I missed?” I take a swig of my beer.

Ambrose spins my bottle cap on the table. “Not much. After you left, I took some time off before going back to school to complete my undergrad. Then, I did an accelerated program to get my MBA. I’d been working for an accounting firm for a bit when I got the call about the zoo.”

I picture Ambrose in a suit at a corner desk and I snort. “An *accounting* firm?”

He chuckles. “I know. Not me at all. When the previous owner of the zoo explained their situation, I knew it was what I was meant to do. I’m just glad it’s an avenue where I can put my degree to use.”

I’ve almost finished my third beer and I’m feeling confident. And nosy. “When did you meet Anya?”

“About two years ago when Matty was four.” He searches my face. “I didn’t date anyone until her.”

I cringe. “I thought she was going to rip my head clean off my body.”

Ambrose sighs deeply and I expect him to shut the conversation down, but he says, “Anya is a good woman. She loves Matty and is protective over me. I know she probably didn’t leave a good first impression when you met her, but she isn’t always like that. She has her vices, like we all do. She’s just not as good at hiding them.”

“Is she getting help for her addiction?”

The question slips out of my mouth before I realize it crosses a hard boundary of privacy. Something that intimate is none of my business and I cover my eyes in embarrassment.

“I don’t know why I asked that, it just flew out of my face.”

Ambrose swirls his beer bottle slowly. “She is. She’s been doing well; Laura and I are proud of her. But she’s been seeing this new guy. He’s a dick. She thinks we don’t know... but I’ve seen him sneak into their house with her a couple of times. I think he has her using again.”

Ambrose's pained expression makes it obvious just how important Anya and Matty are to him. And unlike me, Ambrose doesn't abandon people.

"What will you do?"

He shrugs. "Nothing we can do. No matter how much you love someone, you can't save them from drowning. They have to love themselves enough to learn how to swim."

I think about that. If I'm honest with myself, it feels like I've been drowning for the last seven years, but I don't know if I'm capable of swimming. Sometimes it feels easier to just let go and be dragged out to sea.

"Enough about me and my drama. What's it like being a fancy businesswoman in the Big Apple?" he smirks.

I motion to the bartender for another beer. "It has its pros and cons, like anywhere else. I love that there's always something new to experience and the feeling of getting lost in the crowd. But I'll never get used to the smell of piss in the subways or the prehistoric-size rats."

"You do something with computers, right?"

I never told him that. He clears his throat at my surprise. "Laura may have mentioned it in passing."

I nod. "I do web design. Basically, I help a lot of companies look more professional in the internet world. It wasn't something I saw myself doing. But when I... missed high school graduation, I spent a lot of time distracting myself on my computer before fall semester began."

A cloud of silence falls over us and all the things we leave unsaid. Ambrose graciously shifts our conversation toward topics that won't overlap with the time frame of my senior year. I ask him what the deal is about businesses going under in Speck, he tells me it's a result of too many people moving out and not enough moving in. When I mention lending

some of my web design skills to small businesses free of charge, he looks at me like he's surprised I'd further involve myself with the people here. And by the time we close out our tab and thank Lorenzo for the free drinks, it's a quarter past ten. It's a long time to have hung out at a bar, but Ambrose wanted to make sure he was completely sober before driving.

Ambrose rolls into my driveway, pulling the keys from the ignition, the overhead light clicking off as we sit in the dark.

"Thanks for the ride."

"Anytime."

I turn to get out of the car.

"Hey, Mar?"

Time stops. "Yeah?" I whisper.

The car is too dark to make out the look on Ambrose's face and the only sound filling the space is from our shallow breathing. My logic center is shaky in my inebriated state, and I want so badly for him to kiss me. As if he reads my mind, Ambrose leans across the console, his face stopping only an inch from mine. His breath is a mix of whiskey and mint, and my heart rate accelerates. His hand sweeps past my head, behind me, and just when I expect his fingers to tangle themselves in my hair, I hear the click of a door lock.

"The lock gets jammed sometimes. It should work now."

He returns to his side of the car and I deflate like a popped balloon.

"Right. Thanks," I mutter, getting out.

"Good night, Mara."

"Good night, Ambrose."

Once I'm in my room, I groan into my pillow and call my only friend. She answers on the first ring.

"Well, well, well. If it isn't my long-lost best friend."

“Tally, what the hell am I doing?”

She snorts. “I know that I’m your all-knowing, wiser, better half, but you’re going to need to give me more context than that.”

“What am I doing spending time with the only guy I’ve ever loved and the only person who happens to be the biggest reminder of the worst night of my life?”

Tally goes quiet, which is extremely unlike her. But then again, she isn’t used to me divulging my secrets. I blame the alcohol. “Babe... I don’t know much about your situation. The only times you’ve given me any sort of insight into your past life is when you’re drunk off your ass. All I can say is, if something or *someone* is giving you some semblance of joy, don’t throw that away.”

I don’t deserve her. “I love you, Tal. I miss the shit out of you.”

“I miss you too. Now, I hate to leave you in your time of need, but I told Jeremy I was going to sleep early to avoid tasting his new chard stew recipe and I don’t want him to hear me.”

I chuckle. “I will never understand you two.”

“You will once you’ve had the best sex of your life.”

“And that’s my cue. Good night, Tally.”

Tally’s voice suddenly turns serious. “Mara?”

“Yeah?”

“Don’t throw it away.”

I clutch my pillow to my chest. “I’ll try.”

I really want to try.

“Presentations will begin at the start of class, first thing on Monday.”

The entire class groans in unison.

“You all have four years left of this. I suggest you get used to it now.”

A girl who goes by Cee speaks up from the back of the classroom. “But Mr. Moynihan, this weekend is homecoming. All the other teachers are postponing assignments.”

Mr. Moynihan twirls the piece of yarn he always has wrapped around his index finger. It’s a fascinating habit and one that always catches my attention. The fog on his bifocals grows thick from his heavy breathing.

“Miss Lowe, I’m aware of the festivities taking place this weekend. It’s not homecoming without sweaty teenagers, questionable dancing and young ladies crying in the bathrooms—trust me when I say that the smell of a school dance has permeated through the air.”

I laugh into my notebook.

“However,” he continues, “we will push forth with the original purpose of this institution and that is to get an *education*. Which is why I’m very much looking forward to hearing you all present on the riveting causes and aftermath of the Revolutionary War.”

The groaning continues. Everyone is pretty much in sync by this point.

“Believe it or not, when I was your age, I preferred to excel in school, rather than be consumed with the trivial nature of school dances.”

“Yeah, probably because no one would go with you,” a boy mutters from the back, eliciting a few snickers.

“Mr. Santos, since you are so eager to engage with the class, you and your partner will be up first to present on Monday.”

Louise Santos and the girl he's paired with make a sound of disappointment as the bell rings overhead, freeing us from the period. Cat loops her arm through mine as we make our way to our neighboring lockers. When Cat originally found out her locker was assigned to another hallway, she bribed the girl next to mine to switch. She still won't tell me what the bribe was.

"I hate that class," she says. "I mean, why even call it World History if we spend the majority of the time talking about the United States? No wonder the rest of the world hates us."

I secretly agree with her.

"And I'm sorry, but that yarn finger thing he does is just weird."

"Cat, it's probably a nervous tic, be nice."

She sighs. "You're right. I'm just on edge because Maitland hasn't asked me to the dance yet."

"He's gonna ask, just give him some time."

"Mara, the dance is *tomorrow*."

"Maybe... maybe he's too intimidated and doesn't know how to ask."

Cat swings open her locker and begins aggressively reapplying her lip gloss. "Whatever. He's probably going to ask Alexa Marx. Why wouldn't he want to ask a sophomore over fresh meat?" She lowers her voice and leans toward me. "I heard she got a nose job over the summer."

"Why don't you ask him? You don't need to wait around for some guy to make the first move."

She ponders my advice as I swap my history book for Spanish. "You know what? You're right. I will ask him. I love this feminist energy you're giving off—it's very Susan B. Anthony of you. Also, I still can't believe you won't come."

"I already told you, the idea of forcing myself to attend an event with

that many people makes me want to puke into a sock.”

She makes a face of disgust at the mental image. “You’re a mysterious creature, Mara Makinen.”

I laugh as the warning bell music rings out, alerting us of the one minute we have to make it to our next class. It’s only the first semester and I’m already desperate to never hear *The Lone Ranger* theme song ever again.

I hoist my bag over my shoulder. “I can’t be late for Spanish. Let me know what he says. I’ll see you at lunch.”

Cat smacks my butt as she speeds away. Her next class is four hallways over. “Au revoir!”

“That’s French!” I call.

“Tomato, potato!”

I chuckle and start hauling ass to my next period. No matter how boring school is, she always finds a way to make it entertaining.

Lunch period in high school is the *Wild West*. Students hobble shoulder to shoulder, rushing to grab food as quickly as they can to maximize their socialization time. Everyone talks over each other in an effort to be heard, and it makes me feel like I’m standing in the mosh pit at a rock concert. I’m never disappointed when the thirty minutes are up. I unwrap the sandwich I packed as Cat recounts the way she asked Maitland to homecoming. Apparently, he *was* too intimidated to ask her and he said yes before she even finished her question.

She rambles off details about the kind of dress she wants to find and I let my eyes wander around the lunchroom. They land on the same table they do every day and I start the mental clock on my daily allowance of self-wallowing. The Lucky Four sit together, their belongings spaced out, taking up an entire table meant for at least ten kids. They’re only sophomores, but they have already carved out a reputation of popularity among the masses.

Ambrose is at the head of the table, laughing at something Jackson whispered into his ear. Sasha clings to him, picking fries off his tray and dropping a kiss on his cheek every few minutes. Their relationship is a fan favorite at school and everyone knows they're a shoo-in for homecoming court. Ambrose lifts Sasha's chin with his finger and kisses her slowly. I look down at my sandwich, suddenly engrossed by the kernels in the whole wheat bread.

"Hello? Earth to Mara?" Cat says, waving her hand in front of my face.

I snap back to reality. "Sorry. What did you say?"

"I said, why is Brandon Lang walking over here?"

I follow her eyeline and sure enough, Brandon is making his way over to us, eyes locked on me.

He stops in front of our table with a kind smile. "Hey, Mara. Cat."

Cat taps on her phone without looking up. "Brandon."

Brandon is my partner for our AP world history project and Cat is still bitter that Mr. Moynihan refused to pair us together. He said best friends don't make as efficient of a team. Thankfully, Brandon is a great student and never lets me do more than my fair share of the work.

"Hey, did I forget to give you the rest of my printed slides for the presentation? I could have sworn I did," I say, reaching for my bag.

"Oh. No, you're good, I got them. That's not why I came over."

My brow furrows in confusion and Cat stops tapping on her phone.

"I came over because I wanted to see if you were going to the dance."

I don't have to look at Cat to know she's listening. She never keeps her mouth shut for this long.

"Unless you're already going with someone," he rushes.

I take in his soft hazel eyes. I've always thought Brandon was handsome ever since the first time he lent me one of his books and I like that I never

feel jittery or confused around him.

Beneath the table, Cat crushes my ballet flat under her boot, insinuating that I should take him up on the offer. I don't want to go, but I'm also flattered to be asked. He and Cat *would* make the dance more bearable.

I regard his expectant face and smile. "I'd love to go with you."

He claps his hands together. "Awesome! We'll talk car pool details later. It's gonna be a good time."

He leaves and Cat shrieks into my ear about how we need to stop by the mall first thing after school. I smile, knowing how happy my agreeing to attend the dance makes her. The bell rings and I collect my trash, casting one last glance at The Lucky Four. Ambrose watches me, his eyes as clouded over as the storm raging outside.

"That's it, that's the one," I say, popping a mint into my mouth.

Cat puts her hands on her hips, raising an eyebrow. "You said that about the last four dresses."

"They all looked amazing on you!"

She's wearing a sage-green A-line dress that falls just below her knees. It has a cinched bodice and pleated tulle skirt, giving it a whimsical flair. It's stunning.

"Hmm. I don't think this color looks good with my hair. I think my heart is set on the black-and-red one. You should try this on, though. It's made for you." She hops off the stool positioned in front of the full-length mirror.

I point to my chest. "I don't think I have the proper equipment for that dress, if you catch my drift."

She rolls her eyes, returning to the dressing room. "Please. You underestimate my mother's tailoring skills. Try it on. Now."

She throws the dress over the dressing room door and I obey her orders.

When I return to step in front of the mirror, I'm shocked. Mrs. King will need to pull in the bust, but the rest of the dress fits like a glove. The green pulls out the amber flecks in my brown eyes and the tulle adds volume to my petite frame. It doesn't hurt that I got my braces removed a few months ago. The dress is perfect for our dance's theme of *Alice in Wonderland*.

"Oh my god, you look incredible! If Brandon doesn't kiss you at the dance, I will."

I grin and turn back to the mirror for one final look. A piece of clothing has never made me feel so confident and the new emotion sits like warm honey in my belly.

We bring our dresses to the checkout counter, giggling like a pair of schoolgirls high on excitement. Cat settled on the sultry, but still very school-appropriate, black-and-red dress once I told her it embodied the Red Queen. We spend the next hour window-shopping and stuffing our faces with Cinnabon.

The next morning, I head over to the Kings' house so Alima can alter my dress. We're on a time crunch, but she's confident she can have it done before our pictures this afternoon. Cat's asleep upstairs and the house smells of fresh pumpkin bread, my favorite. I settle on the sofa in the den while Alima scours through drawers for her sewing kit.

"I could have sworn everything was in here. Mara, I'm sorry. I'm going to need a few minutes. I think Robby may have moved my stuff into the new office." She sounds annoyed, but I pretend not to notice. Robby and Alima King fight more often than not these days, but for some reason they still haven't separated.

"No problem, Mrs. King."

"Mara," she warns.

"Sorry. *Alima*." I smile. She always gets on my case for calling her Mrs.

King, saying it makes her feel old.

While I wait for her return, I decide to quickly run upstairs and grab the headphones I left in Cat's room the day before. Her bedroom at the end of the hall shares a bathroom with the neighboring room belonging to Ambrose. I walk past his door, noticing it's opened a crack. Ambrose never leaves his door open. Curiosity getting the best of me, I use my shoe to widen the gap a few more inches before peeking inside.

His room is empty and I extend my neck, searching for sounds from the bathroom but hear nothing. I step in and close the door behind me. I haven't been in Ambrose's room in two years. The eagle bedspread he used to have has been replaced by a simple navy-blue quilt and countless books are strewn about, but it doesn't look messy. His walls are no longer a shrine to *National Geographic* and the gray paint gives it a mature, but boring feel. I creep toward his nightstand, taking a closer look at a framed photo of him and Sasha. Ambrose has his arm wrapped around her shoulders with the barely there smirk I love so much while she pins him with her signature flirty eyes. I'm so busy dissecting the photo, I don't hear the window close behind me.

"What are you doing in here?"

I jump back, ramming my ankle into the leg of the bed. Ambrose stands before me wearing a crumpled white tee and heather-gray sweatpants. With disheveled hair and bloodshot eyes, he stares at the photo in my hand, waiting for my response.

I set the frame back on the nightstand with a trembling hand. "Sorry. The door was open and I thought—"

"You thought you should just barge in and snoop around?" he hisses.

"I wasn't snooping... I thought you'd be in here."

"Well, clearly I wasn't."

“Clearly,” I say. “Why were you crawling in through the window?”

He lifts an eyebrow. “You broke into my room and you’re interrogating *me*?”

“You were obviously sneaking back in.”

“Are you always this observant?” he says, ripping off his shirt before pulling a clean one over his head and my eyes catch on the quick display of his hardened abs. He never had those before. “Because if you are, you should consider a career in detective work, Mouse.”

“Don’t call me that,” I snap.

It’s the first time I’ve raised my voice at him and his eyes widen slightly. He roams my face as if he’s seeing me for the first time. He runs a hand through his hair, making it look more chaotic than it already is. “I was with Sasha.”

I can’t help myself because I’m a masochist. “Doing what?”

Ambrose takes a few steps forward, putting us toe to toe, his smirk devilish. “What do you think we were doing?”

Blood rushes through my ears and tension crackles in the air between us. His eyes drop to my mouth and I don’t realize I’m holding my breath until the shower in the bathroom turns on.

Ambrose moves away, grabbing a hoodie from his desk chair and his absence feels like a punch to the gut.

“You should go before she finds you in here.”

No longer concerned about the headphones, I slip out his door and run back downstairs just as Alima enters, cradling a large kit in her arms.

“I found it!” She grins.

I force a smile, not trusting myself to speak.

“Honey, are you okay? You look flushed.”

“Yeah.” I swallow. “Never better.”

After Cat and I get ready at my house, we're picked up by Maitland and Brandon. Maitland's dad graciously offered to drive us to the dance and pick us up afterward. We squeeze together for photos in the front yard and laugh when Alima cries at how beautiful Cat looks.

"You look stunning," Brandon whispers into my ear. He reaches for my wrist, wrapping it in a corsage swallowed by white lilies and baby's breath.

My dad clears his throat. "Bible width apart, son."

"Dad, quit it," I grumble. He isn't even religious.

We pile into the car and when I look out the window, I see a red Corvette parked in the King's driveway. The Lucky Four are already crammed inside, blaring music through the speakers.

Cat squeezes my arm. "Tonight's going to be so much fun."

I squeeze her back. "You bet it is."

I'm not one for school dances, but even I have to admit that the decorating committee blew it out of the water. The once understated gym has been transformed into a colorful, fantastical world. A red carpet guides us to the entrance, leading us through the open mouth of the Cheshire cat. Multicolored lanterns hang from the ceiling and strobe lights throw the gym into bright Technicolor. I wave at the familiar teachers volunteering at the check-in and food stations. Even Mr. Moynihan is here, which I'm sure is not by choice. He wears a purple suit and a top hat with a leaning tower of teacups on it. I don't think he enjoys it.

"Hi, Mara. Hi Cat. You girls look lovely tonight."

Mrs. Shannon, our algebra teacher, smiles, checking our names off her clipboard and collecting our tickets.

"Thank you, Mrs. Shannon," we reply in unison.

Cat loops her arm through mine, pulling me inside. "Come on, I want to

dance!”

I snatch a cup of punch from the refreshments table and down it in one gulp, praying some rebel student managed to sneak a splash of liquid courage into the bowl.

Dancing in public isn't too bad when there are tons of people around you cloaked in semidarkness. The four of us form a little circle of privacy, thrashing our bodies around with no skill whatsoever, and surprisingly, I enjoy the hell out of it. We're doing our own version of the wave when a voice amplifies over the speakers, informing us that homecoming court is about to be announced. Girls squeal left and right as we all shuffle to the outer rim of the gym, providing a space for the nominees to stand in the middle. Principal Sacks, who's usually a very serious man, stands in the center wearing a Mad Hatter coat and an orange wig.

“Settle down. Settle down.” The room quiets.

He reveals a black envelope from his coat pocket. “We'll start with the freshman. Your freshman homecoming court representatives are... Catherine King and Maitland Brown.”

The crowd goes wild. Cat stares at me with wide eyes as I jump up and down, cheering. She has no idea how many people love her and that's exactly why she deserves to be on court. Maitland grabs her hand and leads her to the center of the gym where a volunteer places sashes around them, handing Cat a single red rose.

“Moving on. Your sophomore homecoming court representatives are... Sasha Baker and Ambrose King.”

Screams resound throughout the gym as Sasha struts to the center, already reaching for her sash. Her baby-blue minidress and white stilettos make her look like the Alice our entire theme is centered around. Ambrose joins her, thanking the kid who passes him his sash. His hair is clean cut

and styled to perfection, a far cry from the state it was in when I saw him this morning. He's gorgeous in a maroon suit and somehow pulls off the most horrendous rainbow bow tie. There's a sharp pinch in my chest. I can't watch Ambrose and Sasha be irritatingly perfect anymore.

I stand on my tiptoes to reach Brandon's ear, yelling over the screams in the room. "I think I'm going to run and grab some punch!"

He glances back at the court, conflicted. "Do you want me to come with you?"

"No, stay. I'll be right back!"

I extract myself from the crowd, seeking solace in the quiet, empty hallway. A few teachers chat among themselves and I refill my cup with punch as the rest of the homecoming court representatives, as well as the homecoming king and queen, are announced inside. I take advantage of the low traffic flow and slip out one of the back doors into the courtyard.

The moon is full and gleams brightly against the dark sky. Loosening the straps on my heels, I slip them off and stretch my ankles with relief. I close my eyes, enjoying the silence.

The door behind me opens and I jump backward, cloaking myself in the shadow of a pillar. Ambrose walks forward by himself, hands on his hips, pinching the bridge of his nose. I take a step to get a better view of him and step on a sharp rock.

"Ow, *shit!*"

Ambrose whips his head in my direction.

"Hello? Is someone there?"

The only way out is through the door from which I came, which leaves me no choice but to walk out into the light of the moon.

Ambrose narrows his eyes. "Did you follow me out here?"

My face screws in disgust. "There's only one door, brainless, so if

anyone followed anyone out here, it was *you*.”

I wait for him to ream into me but instead his chest starts to shake with silent laughter and before long, I’m laughing along with him.

“Nice tie,” I snort.

“Nice dress,” he says. But when I meet his eyes, he looks utterly serious. My body hums.

Ambrose tilts his head. “You look older.”

“I am older.”

He nods, contemplating that, and we’re silent for the next few moments.

“Dances,” he says.

It only takes me seconds to cling to the game we haven’t played in years. “Overrated.”

He smirks and my heart leaps. “People.”

“Dancing.”

“Bodies.”

I regard the lack of space between us and something tickles at my spine. “Close,” I whisper.

Ambrose’s gaze latches on to mine and there are a million conversations being had without words attached. He runs his hand through his hair, destroying its perfection, before inhaling forcefully through his nose. “Go inside.” He points.

“What? Why?”

He swings his head toward me, his expression is pained. “Mara. *Please* go inside. I have a girlfriend.”

I jerk my head back. “I know you have a girlfriend...what does that have to do with—”

“I have a *girlfriend*,” he breathes, stepping closer to me. “And right now you’re making me forget about that very fact.”

His admission shakes me to my core. Not because I think it means he loathes me any less, but because I could have never fathomed he would look at me in such a way. That I would have that kind of effect on him. He tears his eyes away like the very sight of me hurts. And I understand completely. Because it's how I feel every time I look at him.

My heart seizes, but I heed his demand. I push myself through the door, gladly disappearing amid the crowd filling the hallway as they talk over snacks and drinks.

I spot the girls' restroom and shove my way inside, seeking the safety of the first available stall. I hold out a full ten seconds after I lock the door before allowing the sob to claw its way out of my throat. Mr. Moynihan's words resurface in my memory.

It's not homecoming without a girl crying in a bathroom.

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12

NOW

A week has passed since the night I thought Ambrose would kiss me.

The night I wanted him to kiss me.

He holds true to his word and continues working on the house when he isn't handling business at the zoo. I flew through the projects Helen set aside for me and now I've resorted to crossword puzzles and reading endless recipes on Pinterest as a method to stop ogling him like he's the cabana boy. Today when I offered to install the porch stairs myself after he brought over the materials, he laughed in my face before returning to his work. I didn't fight him on it.

Otso accompanies him, lounging near his feet. In Ambrose's presence, the beast is a far cry from his usual temperament. He's relaxed and at ease. So much so, he could be considered a lapdog if not for his size and I wonder how he came to be that comfortable around Ambrose. I still have to brace myself every morning when I leave my room in anticipation of being tackled by him.

Ambrose has been slaving away outside in the heat for hours on what was supposed to be my project, so I figure the least I can do is bring out a pitcher of lemonade. I incorporate my secret ingredient, clover honey, and slip into a pair of cutoff shorts and one of my dad's old band tees before heading outside.

"I come bearing gifts," I say, lowering a tray with a pitcher and two glasses onto a nearby toolbox.

Ambrose uses a small rag to wipe the sweat off his face and downs the entire glass in silence. Then another one. And another one.

"Wow. Either you're on the brink of dehydration or I make better

lemonade than I thought.”

Returning to the stairs, he grunts, “Both.”

I sip on my lemonade for a few seconds, unsure if I should go back inside. We haven’t spoken much since that night at the bar. I felt something shift in his car and although he’s been at my house every day for the past week, he feels further than ever.

“The stairs are looking great.”

“Thanks.”

“Really. Better than what I could have done. I bet your work on the house alone will be enough to get the realtor to raise the asking price.”

He hums in agreement.

“You know, I’m sure—”

Ambrose cuts me off. “I should really get back to this if I’m going to finish by this afternoon.”

Receiving the subliminal message loud and clear, I duck my head in a nod. He’s already shown me more kindness than he should—of course he’s reached his limit.

Stupid, stupid, stupid girl.

He’s here as a favor to my dad and if I think it’s anything more than that, I’m naive. Because I don’t deserve anything more than that. Not ever.

I’m collecting the pitcher and glasses in my arms when a scream rings out across the street.

Otso raises his head and barks, immediately alert. Squinting my eyes, I follow the sounds to the house next door to Ambrose. Anya and Matty’s house. Anya stands in the driveway with a man holding her forearms in a tight grip. I can’t make out what he’s saying to her and watch in confusion until she yelps again, clearly in pain.

Ambrose sees it all and drops his tools, speed walking toward the pair. I

follow closely at his heels after quickly tying Otso's leash to a column on the porch.

"Anya! What the hell is going on?"

Anya whips her head around, still in the man's clutches and searches Ambrose's face for understanding. I don't bother searching the car for Matty. I already know he's spending the day with Laura at the park.

"Nothing, Ambrose. We're fine, we're just having a little discussion."

I move out from behind Ambrose. "Then why is he grabbing you like that? Doesn't he know how to use his words?"

Shifting her focus to me, Anya's face melts into anger, but it fails to overshadow the fear she has of the man holding her. His detached gaze lands on me. His greasy hair is slick on his scalp like he hasn't washed it in weeks and although the bones jutting out of his skin make him look malnourished, he's at least six feet tall, causing him to tower over Anya like a predator.

"I can use my words," he slurs. "I can do lots of things with my mouth. Wanna see?"

Ambrose growls through clenched teeth, "Don't you fucking talk to her. Don't even *look* at her."

The man's laugh turns into a wet cough. "You were the one who came butting into our business, man. Let me talk to my girlfriend alone."

He tries to pull Anya away, but she looks at Ambrose, the plea clear in her eyes.

"You're not stepping a foot in that fucking house. Take your ass and leave before I call the cops."

He pauses, waiting to see if he's bluffing. Only when he realizes how serious Ambrose is does he release Anya.

His sinister smile raises the hairs on my neck. "Fine. No problem." He

leans into Anya's ear and whispers, "I want my money," before getting into his beat-up Toyota Corolla.

Anya avoids Ambrose's eye contact, instead glaring at me with pure disdain. "You just love inserting yourself into people's lives, don't you?"

I crumple at the accusation. "I didn't mean to cross a line, I thought he was hurting you."

Ambrose lifts a hesitant hand toward Anya as if she's a frightened animal backed into a corner. "Anya, let's go inside."

"I'm not going anywhere with her!" she shrieks, her eyes bloodshot and wild.

I wait for Ambrose to come to my defense, but he just stares at me, the dismissal clear on his face.

I nod. "I'll let you two be."

I walk back home with my tail between my legs, infuriated that I've let myself get involved. What the hell am I doing? I came here for one purpose. None of that includes getting mixed up with Ambrose again. I think back on what Laura told me and mentally kick myself for not heeding her advice. I take Otso by the collar and bring him back inside. He plops on the floor, staring at me in earnest before licking my toes. Even the dog pities me.

I make myself dinner—a sad recreation of Laura's pork fried rice—and curl up alone at the kitchenette. The only sound comes from the ticking clock on the wall, its steady clicking putting me on edge. It's too quiet and I'm afraid that before long, intruding thoughts will bulldoze their way into the forefront of my mind. It's moments like these when my fingers ache to curl around a bottle of vodka.

But I don't want that for me anymore.

I've never wanted that.

I brush my teeth and change into my pajamas before crawling into bed. I'm thumbing through my streaming app, looking for something with Julia Roberts in it, when I hear a *thump* at my window. I disregard it, typing *My Best Friend's Wedding* into the search bar. The sound comes again, this time every three seconds and I realize someone's throwing pebbles at my window. I jump out of bed, open the latch of my window and peer down. Ambrose is lit by the moon, his hands resting in his pockets.

"What are you doing here?"

His relaxed posture throws me off. Like we weren't just in an extremely awkward situation a few hours ago. "I need to show you something."

I don't know why, but I'm annoyed. "I'm going to bed."

"Meet me in the backyard in five."

Hope flutters within me, and I stomp it down. My self-sabotage comes too easily.

"No."

Ambrose begins walking away, his voice taking on a hard edge. "Meet me in five."

"Ambrose, I'm not coming down there," I whisper-yell. I no longer see his body. "Ambrose!"

I growl in frustration. I pull a ratty old crew neck over my tank top and change into a pair of sweatpants to shield myself from the cool night air. I creep downstairs, careful not to make enough noise that Otso thinks it's time to come out and play. He has more energy than the Energizer Bunny.

The backyard is a sea of darkness—the moonlight the only thing illuminating my steps in front of me. Speck Lake doesn't care much for streetlights. There's hardly a need when everyone knows everyone and cares for each other so well. They don't have to worry about monsters hiding in the shadows here.

I search for Ambrose's silhouette. I finally spot him when I see him shift in the corner of my eye. His body looms in the dark, still and stealthy. I know every inch of this backyard, but his intimidating presence makes me feel like the intruder. I close the gap between us. "Is this where you kill me? Because if it is, I would have chosen a better outfit to be found in."

Ambrose makes a sound that resembles a laugh, but without the ability to see his facial expression, I can't be sure.

"What did you want to show me?"

His shadowed arm reaches into his back pocket and with the sound of a faint click, a flashlight turns on. He moves to the side and only then do I realize we're standing next to Old Maple.

He tilts the flashlight, illuminating the small grin on his face before allowing it to disappear in the dark again. "Take a look."

I'm confused. I've been out here a million times. I know what Old Maple looks like better than anyone else. I raise my eyes to the old tree and the tree house that rests upon it. The air whooshes from my lungs, leaving me speechless.

Old Maple's treehouse looks brand new. New in a way that highlights what it's always been but fixed up to look more aesthetically pleasing. It looks safer. The cracks in the roof and walls are filled and the stairs jutting out from the tree have been upgraded. You can climb the stairs without fearing for your life now. The rot that has been taking over one of the side windows has been taken care of and there's a little pulley system installed with a basket hanging on the end.

I can't look away. "What did you do?"

"When the real estate agent saw the tree house, she wanted me to tear it down. She said it was an 'eyesore.' I told her it was a part of the house and it needed to stay. I promised to fix it up, make it a bit more marketable, and

that convinced her to concede in the end.”

I take him in then. This man who continues to surprise me. Something very far in the depths of my soul is waking up after its long slumber and it scares me. After everything we’ve been through, it makes no sense. His kindness, his openness toward me... it’s incomprehensible.

“Why?”

He knows what I’m really asking and I can tell his eyes soften, even in the dark. “You’ve lost enough.”

Those three words rock me and I have to readjust my stance to keep from crumbling into dust on the ground. I don’t speak, terrified that if I open my mouth, all the little broken pieces inside me will fall out.

Ambrose’s gentle fingers close around my wrist. “Let’s go up.”

We climb Old Maple together for the first time in a long time. Thanks to the new stairs, the climb only takes a few seconds and part of me wants to laugh at how much of a struggle getting into this tree house used to be. Ambrose enters ahead of me and when I crawl my way inside, he has his body folded in on itself. I notice my hands and knees don’t ache like they usually did when I climbed inside.

I shoot out in surprise, “Did you install *carpet* in here?”

Ambrose’s laugh filling the air answers my question. I crawl all the way in, lying flat on my back. It’s pitch black and the only indication that Ambrose lies right next to me is the heat emanating from him and the way my body instantly responds to it. We sit in comfortable silence for a few minutes.

“This tree house used to be our entire world,” I whisper. “And now it feels like a tiny matchbox.”

Ambrose breathes deeply, and his shoulder grazes mine. “It served its purpose. It made us happy during those years.” He turns his head on its side

to face me, but my eyes stay glued to the ceiling, not wanting to see the past on his face. “But we were never meant to stay this small.”

I want to erase his words. I want to be small again. I want to hide away and disappear into the crevices of these walls. The world is too expansive—its mouth always opened wide and ready to swallow us whole.

I shift my head, putting me face to face with Ambrose. Our noses almost brush and I can practically taste the mint lingering on his breath. “You said you were helping my dad with the house because you owed him. What do you owe him for?”

He turns away from me, taking all the heat with him.

I want it back more than I’m willing to admit.

“The summer after your graduation... I got into some trouble.”

I wait patiently for him to continue.

“The last thing I wanted to do was go back to school. I stayed around town for a few months and honestly, I turned into a shit person. I let my emotions get the best of me. I drank too much. Before I knew it, I was picking fights with people whose only offense was crossing my path. I was the worst version of myself.” He rakes his fingers through his hair like his confession is painful to relive. “When your dad heard about me, he got on my case. He had a way of talking to me that made me listen. You know my parents never mastered that. He bailed me out every time I was taken to the station for fighting. *Every* time. He started taking me on small build projects around town. Nothing fancy, just things to do with my hands so they wouldn’t find their way back to people’s faces. If not for him, I’d probably be behind bars right now. He pushed me to go back to school. I owe him everything.”

I have no words. Nothing I imagined comes close to what Ambrose just confessed. I don’t waste time wondering why my dad didn’t tell me about

Ambrose's struggles. When I left Speck Lake, I made it clear I was leaving its inhabitants too. Ambrose has every reason to hate me, but since I've been back, he's passed up every opportunity to completely shut me out.

He smooths out the crease in my forehead with his thumb. "Hey. I know why you left. I would never hold that against you."

I nod. It's all I can do.

Ambrose repositions himself too many times for being confined to such a small space. He wants to ask me something.

"Just spit it out," I say.

Without hesitation, he turns onto his side and lifts his head, cradling it in his hand. "Why haven't you visited Cat since you've been back?"

The ringing in my ears is surprising because I've been waiting for this question. But that's the funny thing about painful words. Anticipating them doesn't make them any less painful. Sweat breaks out across my forehead as if the small matchbox we sit in is catching fire. My body knows to run before my mind does and I scramble up onto my knees, feeling around for the exit.

Ambrose grabs my arm firmly. "Mouse, stop."

I yank it away too hard and it collides with the wall behind me. I curse under my breath. "Don't call me that."

"What are you so afraid of? You know she'd love it if you visited her."

"Oh really? *Did she tell you that?*" I hiss.

Ambrose flinches as if I've smacked him.

"I'm sorry," I breathe. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry."

We stare at each other in the dark. Two broken people trapped between four walls that look shiny and new.

"I'm not ready to see her, Ambrose," I whisper. "Not like that."

He wants to push me. He wants to push me and a small part of me *wants*

to be pushed. But I know myself well enough to know that if he pushes me right now, I'll hit the road running. It's in my blood.

Instead, he reaches behind his head, flipping a switch I hadn't noticed. The inside of the tree house is flooded in warm amber from the firefly lights woven intricately across the ceiling.

He lifts his chin toward the entrance and there's not a trace of anger when he says, "So you can see where you're going."

I begin making my way out the way we came. "Why didn't you have those lights on the whole time?" I grumble.

His warm breath curls around my ears. "Some things are easier to say in the dark."

13

THEN (AGE 15)

Christmas is always the highlight of my year.

It's the only time everyone everywhere agrees that you should put your responsibilities on the back burner and partake in all things cozy, warm, and joyful. I'm convinced even the Grinch loved Christmas and what he truly disliked was annoying people, and can you really blame him for that? Christmas this year feels cozier, warmer, and more joyful now that I'm Brandon Lang's girlfriend.

There's still ice skating, but now I get to do it holding someone's hand. There are still snowball fights, but now I receive kisses on my nose after being attacked, and there's just as much hot cocoa, but now it feels symbolic when I add the mini heart-shaped marshmallows to it. I've become consumed by it all.

When Brandon asked me to be his girlfriend after homecoming a year ago, I said yes without hesitation. I thought that's just what you're supposed to *do*. Boy asks out girl. Girl feels lucky. Girl says yes. And so, I'm Brandon's girlfriend and I tell myself I'm happy. More than being his girlfriend, I'm happy to belong to someone. I like that someone besides Cat waits for me by my locker and searches for me in the lunchroom. It's addictive—feeling seen. Feeling wanted.

On our one-year anniversary, I give Brandon a poster of his favorite comedian and he gives me a necklace with an infinity charm at its center and when I ask him what it means, he says, "*that we'll be together forever.*" I don't feel that kind of commitment to him yet, but I nod and clasp the necklace around my neck anyway. I'm seen and I'm wanted.

Brandon dated other girls before me, but he's my first boyfriend. He

assures me that while I'm new to the world of relationships, I'm the best girl he's ever been with and his favorite kisser. I never know how to respond when he says that. I like kissing Brandon, though I don't have much to compare it to. Every now and then when I lie in my bed and stare at the glowing green stars glued to my ceiling, I wonder why I don't replay Brandon's kisses at night like I do the kiss on the cheek I received years ago. But then I push the thought away before it riddles me with anxiety. *I'm seen and I'm wanted.*

Christmas break only began two days ago, but Speck Lake is in full holiday mode. Cat and Ambrose left for Florida to visit their extended family and I'm missing Cat more than ever. She spends every Christmas away, but this year feels different. We're fifteen and the throes of high school have ushered us into a weird phase in our friendship. Cat made varsity cheer and I spend most of my time writing reviews for the film club. When my dad suggested I join a sport like Cat freshman year, I choked on the cereal I'd been eating.

The only downside is that we're busy all the time. When I don't have a deadline, Cat has a competition. When Cat doesn't have a game, I have films to catch up on. We continue to eat lunch side by side, but it's becoming apparent that our presence is highly sought out by our respective groups. Still, we cling to each other like white on rice.

With only three days left before Christmas, I invited Brandon to come over and build gingerbread houses with me. I bought the kit this morning and am becoming impatient, desperately wanting to attack the cookies and frosting with my mouth. I've just thrown on my favorite velour sweater—an early gift from my dad—when I hear the doorbell. Not wanting to endure the inevitable awkward conversation between my dad and Brandon so early in the day, I swing open my door and run downstairs. I pass my dad sitting

in his armchair and he leans farther into it as if he had no intention of answering the door anyway. I'm still unable to pinpoint why he gives Brandon such a hard time.

I narrow my eyes and point a finger in warning. "Be nice."

He sticks his tongue out at me like a defiant two-year-old.

I open the door and Brandon is already smiling with his hands in his pockets, looking more handsome than ever. He's bundled in a mustard peacoat and his eyes hold a captivating sheen, no doubt due to the obtrusive wind outside.

"Hi." He grins.

My heart doesn't flutter erratically, but it does flutter. "Hi right back." I lean over the doorframe for a quick kiss before my dad can object and Brandon caresses my cheek with his warm palm, playfully nipping at my ear before I can pull away.

"Is your dad home?"

"Yes, I'm home," my dad's voice booms from the living room. "Now, close the door. You're letting all the warm air out."

"That's not how it works," I mutter.

I take Brandon's hand and lead him straight into the kitchen, not bothering to let him greet my dad. Deep down, we all know that's everyone's preference. The old wooden kitchenette table is covered in everything I bought this morning. I spent an hour neatly organizing the bottles of icing, placing the mini candied decorations into separate bowls and placing the gingerbread house pieces on each side of the table.

Brandon lays his coat over the chair, facing me, a tight smile marring his beautiful face. "You started without me?"

My hands clench instinctively and my nails bite into my palm. "I just took all the stuff out and organized it. I wanted it all to be ready for you."

He tilts his head. “Gotcha. Just thought it would have been nice to do it together. I didn’t realize you wanted us to get through it so quickly.”

I gasp, my eyes widening like saucers. “That’s not it at all, I—”

“Hey.” He chuckles, touching my arm gently. “It’s okay. You didn’t know. Now you won’t make the same mistake next time. No big deal.”

He leans forward and places a featherlight kiss on my forehead. “Let’s start.”

We sit back and appreciate our work. Brandon reaches across the table for a high five, and we laugh with pure satisfaction.

He gifts me the grin he knows I love. “Alright, babe. Dig in.”

I whoop and break off the door of my gingerbread house, mercilessly shoving it into my mouth with a groan. He laughs and shakes his head, nibbling on the mini marshmallows he strategically placed on his roof. My dad saunters in, heading straight for the coffee maker. He refills his mug and places it in the microwave before coming over to observe our work. Well, my work. He couldn’t have given a rat’s ass about Brandon’s gingerbread house.

He scratches at the scruff along his jawline. “Your entire house is covered in yellow icing? Why didn’t you go with the blue?”

Brandon interjects before I can respond. “Because yellow’s her favorite color. The blue went better with my decorations anyway.”

My dad looks at Brandon as if he’s just now realizing he occupies the same room as him. As if Brandon’s an annoying little fly you forget is there until it whizzes across your field of vision.

“Her favorite color is blue,” my dad says matter-of-factly.

Brandon doesn’t respond, just smiles at my dad. To anyone else, it would have seemed like a normal smile but there’s something imperceptibly

challenging about it. My dad looks to me then to settle the debate.

I shrug in discomfort. "My favorite color is yellow now."

I turn away from the disappointment on my dad's face as the microwave beeps. He grabs his mug and leaves the kitchen without another word.

An hour later after I've told my dad Brandon was leaving and I was going to take a nap, I run upstairs to open my window as Brandon climbs his way up the trellis. We splay ourselves across my bed, a jumbled mess of long limbs and warm hands exploring each other. I love moments like this with him. Everything's instinctual and I'm not required to take part in the mental Olympics of figuring out what I should or shouldn't say to him. I never disappoint him when it comes to my body.

Brandon kisses down the length of my neck and blows gently into the hollow of my collarbone, knowing it's one of my tickle spots and I giggle and squirm beneath him. His fingers linger at the waistband of my sweatpants, grazing the skin below centimeter by centimeter, trying to see how far he can get. When his thumb hooks the band of my underwear, I quickly roll out from underneath him, knocking the picture frame off the side table with my elbow.

"Shit."

I reach down to pick it up, but Brandon beats me to it. "Why do you still have this? Aren't you all basically strangers now?"

I snatch the frame back and clutch it tightly to my chest as if I can protect it within the confines of my rib cage. "Cat and I are still friends."

He snorts. "Barely."

I sit up straighter. "What's that supposed to mean?"

He rolls his eyes, clearly annoyed. "Nothing. Please don't make this into something it isn't."

"Sorry."

“It’s okay,” he says, leaning over to kiss my cheek. Then, “I’m gonna head out. My dad comes back from his work trip today and I promised my mom I’d help make sure the house is spotless.”

My heart softens. Brandon loves his mom immensely and doesn’t care who knows it. I’ve only met his dad a few times, but it was enough to know that his idea of love is throwing money at people or buying them things instead of developing an actual relationship. Whenever I try asking questions about how they get along, Brandon brushes me off, showering me with stone-cold silence. I’ve learned to stop asking.

“Give Sheryl my love. And if you need any help cleaning up, call me. I have nothing else planned for today.”

Brandon shifts uncomfortably before giving me a quick nod. “Later.”

I secure the latch on the window and settle back into bed, exhaustion seeping into my bones in a matter of seconds. Maybe I do need that nap. I stare at the framed photo—the last picture I have in my head before I go to bed each night. I allow the memories flowing through me to remind me of simpler times and soothe the unacknowledged ache in my chest. And as I drift to sleep, the comment I made only a few hours earlier wriggles in the recesses of my mind.

It’s not my favorite, I realize.

The color yellow.

Christmas has only been officially over for seventy-two hours, but I already miss it. Dad and I spend the day curled up on our couch, rewatching classics like *It’s a Wonderful Life* and *White Christmas*. He tops up my hot chocolate every hour and I catch him singing along to the films when I’m not looking. When my mom calls me in the afternoon, she’s on her way to some swanky Christmas party thrown by vagabond artists. I can barely hear

her above the backdrop of busy streets and pedestrians, but she assures me my gift is on its way.

“It’s a Yves Saint Laurent lipstick set. All red. *Very Parisian*.”

“Isn’t that supposed to be a surprise?” I say, popping a marshmallow into my mouth.

“You’re too old for surprises, Mara,” she says, her thick accent making my name sound like *Ma-duh*.

“*Okay*, Mom. I mailed you your gift too, but I’m not sure when it’ll get to you. Customs confuses me.”

“That’s okay, baby. I have everything that I need here.”

Except me. I’m not there, but that will never be a deal breaker. My dad must have overheard her comment because he glances over at me with pity in his eyes.

I cloak my voice in indifference. “Since you don’t care for surprises, it’s a scarf. You probably already have scarfs—*Parisian* scarfs, so feel free to toss it in the back of your closet. Listen, we’re in the middle of a movie so I’ll talk to you later. Merry Christmas!” I slam my thumb on the *End* button before she can respond and toss the phone at a nearby pillow.

“Mara—” my dad starts.

“Look, it’s my favorite part,” I cut him off, hitting play.

He lets it go.

The Kings return home the next day. Cat and I haven’t spoken for a week, a record for us, but when I text her asking if she’s still up for hanging out, she responds with one word: *duh*. We agree to meet at a small lake in the woods, a spot we’ve claimed as our own for years. It’s our hidden oasis. In the summer, the surrounding trees glint around it like emerald jewels and the winters transform it into something out of a Robert Frost poem.

I’m lacing up my winter boots when my phone dings.

Cat: Bring the sticks

Me: Seriously?

Cat: Yeah. Hung out with the fam for too long. Need to get out some aggression.

Me: Um... Am I gonna get the brunt of this aggression?

Cat: You know it

We haven't played ice hockey on the lake since Ambrose stopped hanging out with us. He was usually the referee and would talk Cat down when her competitiveness turned her into a mountain lion. I don't even care if we just pass the puck back and forth together, it'll be fun to reinstate the childhood tradition.

I trudge through the snow, finding my walk more enjoyable with the playlist I saved for winters. There's something about listening to Bon Iver when everything is cold and barren that just feels *right*. I inhale the cold air, letting his words carry me through the familiar trees, their hunched back branches marked by the passing of time.

Come on skinny love, just last the year

Pour a little salt, we were never here

My, my, my, my, my, my, my, my

I wonder how long Brandon and I will last as I step over strewn rocks and branches. I'm not naive enough to think our relationship is perfect, but I'll give anything to make it last. I need something to last.

Staring at the sink of blood and crushed veneer

I tell my love to wreck it all

Cut out all the ropes and let me fall

My, my, my, my, my, my, my, my

Right in this moment, this order's tall

I never mind having doubts about my relationship because Brandon is

always there to remind me that being together is right. It's what makes sense. But sometimes—only sometimes—I wonder if the ropes he uses are there to hold me up or to keep me bound. And if it's the latter, will I ever have the courage to take a knife to them?

A twig snaps behind me, and I whip my head around, yanking out an earbud. The woods are still and empty, the only sound coming from a muffled Bone Iver humming in my clenched fist. I'm alone, but the trees have enough girth to obscure even the widest of people.

"Hello?"

Another snap sounds to my left and I jump in place.

"Boo!" a voice bellows, hands clamping down on my shoulders as I scream.

Cat stumbles back in laughter, clenching at the side of her navy coat.

"Cat! You're the absolute worst. I almost peed myself!"

She's still laughing as she swipes a single tear from her cheek. "Oh Sally, you should have seen your face."

She imitates whatever reaction she claims I made and I smack her playfully on the shoulder. I can never stay mad at her when she uses the nickname from our favorite movie.

"Are you two done?"

A tall figure in a black coat walks forward, his dark features standing in stark contrast to the crystalline snow on the ground. Ambrose lingers two feet away from me, not bothering with subtlety as his eyes slowly scan me.

"What's he doing here?"

Ambrose raises an amused brow.

"I asked him to come. Practically made me beg. It'll be like old times!" Cat cheers, elbowing him in his side.

Ambrose reaches for the hockey sticks under my arms as if his presence

isn't an anomaly. "I couldn't leave you two out here to play alone. Knowing you ladies, only one of you would make it out of these woods."

"How chivalrous of you," I mumble under my breath. Only Ambrose would make hanging out with us sound like he's volunteering his time to a charity event.

"What was that, Mouse?"

"Nothing."

I swerve on my heels, heading toward the lake. As we break through the clearing, all my pent-up frustration dissipates. The ice on the lake is slick and untouched, proof that this place is our best-kept secret. The trees reflect off the glass-like surface, making everything look like a painting. Birds chirp in nearby trees and the sun peeking through the branches covers us in splintered light and warmth. I could stay in our little Eden forever.

We walk onto the ice without skates. We never use them. A long time ago, we realized that the risk of slipping and sliding on your shoes was a big part of the fun. I use a silk scarf gifted by my mom to tie my hair away from my face. She went on and on about how it's designer and shouldn't be worn frivolously. So naturally, I'm wearing it for outdoor horseplay. Ambrose watches me as I lift the curls from my neck and I tell myself the burning sensation in my ears is from the thirty-degree weather.

"How should we decide who takes which side?" Cat asks.

The left side of the lake puts a player at a disadvantage due to a slope under the water. It makes the ice slightly uneven and you have to constantly be aware of your balance and coordination. I hate the left side.

I rack my brain. "What about Rock, Paper, Scissors?"

Ambrose smirks. "Aw, she's sentimental. How sweet is that?"

Cat jabs him in the rib and he grunts. "Don't be a dick."

Ambrose frowns. "Who taught you to talk like that?"

She shrugs. "Maitland."

"And what else has *Maitland* taught you?"

Her grin is mischievous. "Oh, brother, I'm not sure you even want to know —"

Ambrose clamps his hand over her mouth, muffling her laughs as his face turns red.

His eyes whip to me. "Mara. Pick something."

I unsuccessfully hide my laugh behind a cough. "Okay. What about guessing a number one through ten?"

Cat nods in agreement.

"Alright. I have it. What are your guesses?" Ambrose asks.

I choose four, my lucky number, while Cat picks seven.

"The number was six. Cat, you get the right side."

Cat hollers in excitement and I narrow my eyes at Ambrose. I don't put it past him to purposefully give me the left side, but there's also no way for me to prove it.

"Stay on your toes, Mouse." He grins, as he makes his way to the starting point.

I mutter an insult behind his back. Why is he being such a prick?

Cat and I position ourselves in the middle of the lake, bringing together the tips of our hockey sticks. Despite Ambrose's taunts, excitement hums through me. Out here, it's just the three of us like it used to be. A little older. A lot changed. But still just us three. Ambrose holds the puck above our heads, counting down from five. Before his mouth has the chance to form around *one*, a voice calls out from the edge of the woods.

"What do we have going on here?"

Brandon is already making his way onto the ice, the rest of us staring at him in shocked silence. My body stays frozen in place as he stops at my

side, his warm lips meeting mine in greeting. They make me feel colder.

I find my voice. "What are you doing here?"

"I'm here to play."

"I mean, how did you *know* I was here?"

He shrugs nonchalantly. "I followed you."

I feel exposed and embarrassed, too embarrassed to turn toward Ambrose and Cat and see the judgment on their faces.

Ambrose says through clenched teeth, "We already have enough people."

I steal a glance at Cat and her glare is identical to her brother's.

Brandon laughs, but it's condescending. "Well, now that I'm here, there's four of us. If my math's correct, that means we could easily do a two on two."

"Let's just go back to my house," I suggest, tugging on his sleeve.

He doesn't take his eyes off Ambrose. "Come on, man," he goads. "Look at you. Surely you can't be intimidated by someone like me."

To a stranger, it might sound like Brandon is being playful, but I recognized the challenge in his voice. Ambrose hears it too, taking the bait.

"Fine. Cat, you're with me."

Ambrose ushers Cat a few feet away to discuss their game plan while I stare at my boyfriend in horror. "Brandon. I told you I was hanging out with Cat today."

He smiles at me, but his words are ice. "I stopped by your house as you were leaving. You left your copy of *Wuthering Heights* at my place. I just wanted to see where it was you were sneaking off to in the middle of the woods. I wasn't even going to stay."

He moves closer to my ear, his whisper harsher than any scream could be. "But then I saw *him*. It's suspicious that my girlfriend doesn't want me to know that she's hanging around another guy, don't you think?"

My nose burns at the accusation. “I didn’t even know he was coming! Cat invited him without telling me. I would never lie to you about that.”

“Are you both ready or do you need a room?” Ambrose shouts, walking back our way.

Their approaching bodies are blurry and I quickly rub at my eyes. Ambrose looks from me to Brandon, his jaw locking while Cat’s mouth turns downward.

I clap my mittens together and smile. “Let’s do it! We’re gonna crush you two.”

Not even fifteen minutes pass before I realize that I spoke too soon. Brandon and I don’t crush anything except our dignity. The score is 10-2, much to Ambrose’s satisfaction. What started out as light banter has quickly turned into outright trash talk between the guys and Cat and I take turns rolling our eyes at their testosterone battle. Ambrose even refuses to use his inhaler when he clearly needs it.

Since there are only two hockey sticks, Cat and I let the boys have them and designated ourselves as their defenders, solely utilizing our feet. Brandon snaps at me every few minutes, claiming I’m tripping over my feet too much or getting in his way, while Ambrose and Cat move fluidly around the ice, anticipating each other’s moves.

When the score reaches fifteen for Cat and Ambrose, I throw my arms up in defeat, completely out of breath. I’ll gladly give them the win if it means I can finally go home and defrost myself in a hot bath.

“I concede!” I yell. They’re less than twenty feet away from us, but the winds have picked up, making it difficult to hear.

Brandon makes a disgruntled noise behind me and I turn as he slams the hockey stick onto the ice with shameless anger. A soft *crack* escapes from where his stick makes contact, causing tiny fracture lines to stretch out

toward my boots. In any other situation, the near-quiet breaking might have been a beautiful sight. Mesmerizing, even. But I'm aware of what it means here on this fragile spot of the lake.

"Hey. Don't do that. It's dangerous," Ambrose says, speeding over. His voice is serious and firm, losing all traces of the boy who pretends not to care.

Brandon faces him. "What? *This?*" He slams the hockey stick on the ice again. The crack thunders through the air and the harsh sound reverberates in my ears. The hairline fractures become fissures and I shriek.

"Knock it off!" Cat yells.

Brandon's face morphs into an ugly mask of defiance, making him unrecognizable. He crashes his stick down again with a laugh, downplaying the gravity of the situation. The fissures turn into chunks of ice dislodging into the water at random spots around our feet. My limbs scream at me to run, but fear leaves me immobilized.

"Brandon, stop!" I cry.

"*Are you out of your mind?*" Ambrose bellows, veins bulging from his neck.

Brandon stops abruptly. His body loosens and it's as if he's escorted the unhinged stranger who'd just taken control of his body back into the recesses of his mind.

"Relax." He laughs, tossing the stick across the ice at Ambrose's feet. "I was just playing around."

Cat glares at him before stomping away. Ambrose doesn't move an inch and for a moment I think he might punch Brandon in the face. I kind of want him to. What happens next occurs too quickly for me to fully comprehend. It takes less time than it does for someone to say "*One, Mississippi.*" Less time than it takes for me to realize that my last inhale of

oxygen should have been a generous one because it was going to be my last.

I'm on the ice with Ambrose and Brandon, and then I'm not. The freezing water is a knife stabbing every exposed inch of skin. My brain becomes sluggish, like it's being dragged through mud as it tries to catch up with what's happening. The first thing that comes to mind is how dark it is under the ice considering how bright it is outside and my throat constricts, informing my brain that the need for air is imminent as my body thrashes about in survival mode.

My hands stretch above my head, confusion and panic washing over me when they're met with solid resistance.

I'm floating away from the hole I fell through.

I flap my arms through the darkness and they propel me in different directions, searching for the hole, but my obstructed vision prevents me from finding my way out. Intrusive thoughts override my focus.

You're gonna die, they say. You're gonna die, you're gonna die, you're gonna die.

My legs go slack as I swallow more water. I don't feel so cold anymore and I welcome the warmth starting at my toes, working its way upward. I remember learning that hypothermia causes your blood vessels to dilate as a last attempt at warming your limbs. I cast my eyes above me once more, noticing how beautiful the ice looks. The sun has reached its peak in the sky, making the translucent ice glow with gold and I think *this must be what it's like to be trapped inside of a snow globe.*

The first thing I become aware of is the warmth. Not warmth from being numb too long—true warmth. My feet are bundled in something plush and snug and the comfort makes me want to slip back into unconsciousness.

The next thing I become aware of is the mumbles. The voices fail at their attempts at whispering and float around my head, causing me to burrow farther into my cocoon. My muscles cry out in protest as I move and I whimper in pain.

“Mara, honey? Are you awake?”

My dad’s voice is close and I can smell the familiar scent of coffee on his breath. Words feeling too far away to grasp, I groan in response.

“*Princessa*, I need you to sit up if you can. Show us you’re alright.”

Worry laces his voice, so I blink open my eyes and slowly heft my body into a sitting position. My vision focuses on my surroundings and I see who the remaining voices belong to. Cat and Alima both sit on my bed, peering at me with identical expressions of relief. My dad exhales deeply and some of the tension disappears from his shoulders.

“What happened?” I ask, rubbing my eyes.

Cat lays her hand on mine. “You fell through the ice. You drifted away from the hole... we couldn’t find you.”

Her eyes well up and I squeeze her hand in mine. The hollows beneath her eyes are purple, as if she hasn’t slept for days.

“I remember. I tried finding my way back to it. I tried—”

“Shhh.” Alima smooths back my hair. “No need to relive it. You’re safe now.”

“How did I get out?”

My dad scratches the back of his head in discomfort. I can tell it pains him having to talk about all of this. “You wouldn’t have if that boy wasn’t so *stupid* as to jump in after you,” he says, but his voice is almost endearing.

I gasp in worry. “Is Brandon okay? Where is he?”

“Brandon?”

“You said he jumped in to save me. Is he alright?” I’m becoming frantic now.

My dad’s jaw goes slack. “*Brandon* didn’t save shit. That boy clammed up the moment you hit the water. Ambrose is the one who pulled you out of there.”

“Ambrose?” I whisper.

“What Brandon did was very irresponsible. We’re just glad Ambrose was there and you’re okay, Mara.” Alima’s voice is soft, but her jaw tightens around Brandon’s name.

My eyes scour my room. “Where is he?”

Cat and her mom look to each other, exchanging looks I can’t decipher and my heart thrashes in my chest.

“Where is Ambrose?” I demand more firmly.

It’s my dad who answers. “He’s stuck in bed, just like you. He’s alright—just has a nasty ear infection.”

I ignore the tightness in my body as I climb out of bed to pull a pair of sweatpants over my sleep shorts. Alima holds her hands up as if to say, *slow down there*.

“Whoa, whoa, whoa. You’re not going anywhere, little lady.”

I yank a hoodie over my head.

“Mara Jimenez Makinen, you get back in that bed this instant,” my dad orders. He never uses my full name and if I didn’t hurt so badly, I’d laugh. It sounds foreign on his tongue.

Cat sighs. “I don’t know why you two even bother. You know she’s not going to listen.”

The truth behind her words must resonate with them because no one stops me as I leave the house and head toward 164 Winsome Lane. I take the stairs two at a time, biting the inside of my cheek from the pain and

don't stop to knock before letting myself into Ambrose's room.

I close the door swiftly behind me, huffing from the exertion.

"Why do you look like you're running from the cops?"

Ambrose is sitting up in his bed, a book perched on his knee. His contacts are out and his black glasses frame his green eyes. They look like honeydew today. He's shirtless and I allow myself a self-indulgent glance. I did almost just *die* for crying out loud.

"I always thought you were dumb, but I didn't realize you had a death wish," I say, lowering myself to the empty spot at the bottom of his bed. My near-death experience has made me feel rather bold. Ambrose eyes me with curiosity.

"It's not like I could let my little sister's best friend die. What kind of brother would that make me?"

"You could have let Brandon save me. I'm *his* girlfriend."

Ambrose's laugh is hollow. "If I'd left it to him, you wouldn't be sitting here right now."

The weight of that truth slams into me. He clears his throat and says, "Or maybe he would have saved you. I don't know. I didn't really give him a chance—I jumped in right after you fell through."

He's trying to ease the embarrassment I feel at my own boyfriend leaving me for dead and it's a kind mercy I wouldn't have expected from him.

I chew at my nail—my worst habit. "You're like the young George Bailey."

Ambrose scrunches his eyebrows.

"George Bailey. From *It's A Wonderful Life*. When he was a kid, his little brother falls through the ice while they were sledding. George jumps in after him, saves him, and gets an ear infection. You're George. I'm little Harry Bailey, the damsel in distress," I ramble. "I guess technically, he

couldn't be a damsel in distress since he's a boy. The very fact that there isn't a male equivalent to damsel in distress is so sexist and—"

"Why does he do it?" Ambrose asks almost to himself.

"What?"

"Why does George risk his life to save him?"

I shrug, tracing the stitching on his quilt with my thumb. And when I look up, I hold on to his gaze like he held on to me under that ice.

"Because he loves him."

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I walk aimlessly through endless white corridors, my vision blurry and knees wobbly. I'm lost in some sort of maze—my only guide the sounds of hospital monitors and doctors' unintelligible conversations.

And then I hear it again. The groaning.

The sounds belong to my dad, I'm sure of it. They're subtle but carry enough pain to have me running down the white halls. Left. Right. Left. Straight. I can't tell if I'm heading in the right direction because the new sounds emanating from my dad—distraught whimpers—echo off the walls as if they don't have a singular source. As if they came from *everywhere*.

"Dad?" I cry.

The sounds are unbearable. Knives to my ears.

"Dad, tell me where you are!"

I reach out, my hand seizing the wall to steady myself, but I find myself falling into the plaster. I scream, yanking my arm back out. My legs crumble and I sink to the floor on all fours. I hear him again, this time louder.

Crawl to him if you must.

My palms recoil from the frigidness of the floor tiles. Why are they so cold? I crawl faster.

"Mara," he begs.

As I make another turn, I see a small door ajar. I crawl toward it, ignoring the crushing sound beneath my knees. The floor beneath me has turned to ice. I finally reach his room, my line of vision putting me at the foot of my dad's hospital bed. His whimpers have taken on a childlike quality. As if he'd be better off being soothed by his mother than me. Still, I

crawl to him.

Limbs numb, I grab hold of the railing near his head and lift myself up, the movement sensationless. I hover over him.

“I’m here, Dad,” I say, reaching for his hands.

He jerks back in pain. His whimpers become sobs. Crystalline icicles hang from the tips of his stiff hair. His purple lips are swollen and cracked and I want to look away, but I can’t. The same way you drive by a car crash, afraid of what you might see, but are beckoned to observe the catastrophe, nonetheless. Goose bumps race across the length of his arms and I know that if I don’t get him warm quickly, he’ll die.

I reach for him one last time, clasping his hands between mine. He yelps and uses what little strength he has left to pull away from me again, my heart plummeting.

Desperation fills me. “Why won’t you let me help you?”

“You can’t help me.” His words are chilled and the temperature drops lower than its already abysmal state. “You’re cold, Mara,” he says, pained. “So cold, you’re numb. There’s nothing for you to give me.”

I stare back in horror. Not willing to give up, I clutch his arms and will whatever warmth I have in my body to transfer to him, but the longer I hold, the colder the room becomes. I change my mind, trying to release my grip but can’t. My hands are locked on him.

He cries out as frost oozes from my fingertips, leaching onto his body, hungry for his warmth. I pull and tug as his crying amplifies.

“I’m sorry,” I yell. “I’m trying to let go! I’m sorry!”

His body seizes up and just as quickly goes slack. A small white puff escapes out from his mouth as he whispers, “*Nothing for you to give me.*”

I jerk awake, smacking my elbow on the bedside lamp. I curse and make a mental note to move it to my dresser in the morning. I bring my hand to

the front of my nightshirt, pulling the soaked fabric off my chest. The nightmares started last week and haven't let up since. I rarely sleep as it is and now the few hours I manage to scrape by with are compromised as well. I've traded one nightmare for another. I can still recall Laura's face when she told me that my dad's health had some new developments. It's code for *he's getting worse*.

Even if she didn't tell me, I would've put two and two together from the sounds that come from his room. The wheezing is excruciating to hear and his occasional groaning has me running upstairs in cowardly retreat.

I stick my hand out in the dark, grabbing for the glass of water I always leave for myself. Leaning my head back, I anticipate the cure to my dry mouth and grunt when I realize it's empty.

I slide out of bed and step into my softest pair of slippers, the only ones quiet enough to evade Otso. The rickety stairs are silent under my soles and I send up a silent *thank-you* to God. The kitchen is pitch black, but I don't need a light to find my way to the fridge. I'm not the architect of this house, but I can move around seamlessly with my eyes closed, the floor plan embedded into the fabric of my being.

I fill my glass to the rim with water, my hands lit by the sliver of light leaking from the fridge I left slightly open. It's two in the morning and the house is encased in a kind of silence that feels intrusive instead of comforting.

I gently nudge the fridge door closed and am walking past my dad's door when I hear it.

The groaning.

I freeze in place, invisible chains preventing me from running like I usually do as the groans continue. They're low in volume, yet they reverberate throughout my skull, as if amplified to a hundred and twenty

decibels.

Help him, help him, help him.

I reach for the doorknob but hesitate. Maybe it's the nightmares, the fear, or even the lack of sleep, but I swear I see a cloud of cold air fog up the doorknob. I jerk my hand away and retreat upstairs. As I settle back into bed, the entirety of the dream slowly becomes a blurred spot in my memory, but one thought remains. A kernel of truth that travels from my subconscious into my reality with great fervor, solidifying into its own being with bones and flesh and dark inky talons.

There's nothing I can give him.

Ambrose hasn't been by the house in a week. I pretend that the only reason I know the exact number of days I haven't seen him is because the realtor called me three times to inquire about the progress of the house's renovations but every day when my hands sink into the earth, I debate walking across the street to check in on him.

I could tell him that I need help choosing the best paint primer or ask what the difference between a flathead and a tri-wing screwdriver is, but pride prevents me from doing so. Thanks to the world of knowledge that is the internet, I've become well informed on home projects and I won't play dumb to quench my curiosity. Not even for Ambrose King.

So when I spot a skinny white envelope with Ambrose's name on the front lying on the kitchen table and Laura tells me it's a check for him, I insist on delivering it myself.

"Are you sure?" Laura asks, hesitation clear on her face. "I was planning on forcing him to take the money. That boy doesn't budge."

"Of course," I say. "I'm on my way out anyway and I need to ask him a question about the wood in the backyard."

If Laura calls my bluff, she's kind enough not to verbalize it. I run upstairs for a quick shower. If I'm going to fib about needing to leave the house, I may as well run a few errands. I've been meaning to go back to Nadine's Nursery and buy more plants for my dad's room. Maybe if I surround him with other living things, he won't notice that my visitations have dwindled. Again.

The leaves outside are accumulated on the lawns and I purposefully walk across Ambrose's front yard instead of the driveway so I can hear the familiar crunch under my feet. No matter how old you get, that crunch never stops being satisfying.

Fiddling with the envelope in one hand, I knock on the door, practicing my excuse as to why Laura couldn't drop the money off herself. The last time I saw Ambrose was in the comfort of Old Maple. But in the light of day, everything within me says to retreat, to disregard the secrets we divulged in the dark.

The door opens and my smile tightens when I see that it's Anya. She always looks effortlessly beautiful and today's no different. Never mind the fact that the hollows under her eyes looked bruised from exhaustion and her cheeks are hollow, she pulls it off, looking like some sort of supermodel who's experienced nothing more than a late night at the club. When I have dark circles, I look like I've survived a brawl with Rocky Balboa. Barely.

"Yes?" she says coolly.

I swallow. "Is Ambrose here?"

"Does he look like he's here?"

The smart-ass in me begs to rear its nasty head. *How would I know if you answered the door?* But it's a Tuesday morning. I can take the high road on a Tuesday morning.

"Well, when you see him, can you tell him to stop by the house? I have a

check for him.”

I don’t dare leave the money with Anya and she’s smart enough to refrain from suggesting the idea herself. I turn to leave.

“Do you want to wait inside until he comes back? He should be here in a few.” Her saccharine smile makes me sweat.

A trap.

She’s a siren beckoning me toward the dark, murky waters and alarms sound off in my mind, but I still reply, “Sure.” Like a dumbass.

We enter a den that bears no resemblance to the one I remembered. As we sit on the sofa—a deep, L-shaped monster that looks like it came from a modern design catalog—I take in the rest of the room. The accent pieces scattered throughout are sleek and sophisticated. Sexy. The only piece of furniture I recognize is the antique teak entertainment center. Its shelves are still packed with an absurd amount of VHS and DVD movies, despite the fact that streaming reigns supreme these days. My eyes travel to the corner of the bottom shelf and *Practical Magic* rests there. Just like it always has.

Promise me, Mar. Promise we’ll always be sisters like Sally and Gilly.

I promise.

Where I go, you go, right?

Where you go, I go, Cat.

“So,” Anya pierces the silence. “Ambrose tells me you’ve known each other since childhood.” Her tone is bored, but her eyes are sharp. Predatory.

“Yes,” is all I say.

“I’ve seen photos. Ambrose was all bean pole when he was Matty’s age.” At the mention of her son, her eyes gentle before resuming their harsh state. A sly smirk plays on her face. “I wouldn’t have thought he’d turn into such a sexy man. Did you?”

She’s dangling the bait right in front of me, urging me to take a bite.

“Where is Matty today?” I breathe.

She focuses her attention on a snagged piece of thread on the couch cushion and says, “He’s at a friend’s house.”

I think of Laura and for a reason I can’t pinpoint, the idea of Anya having a sibling fills me with unease. And the fact that it’s someone so kind and selfless makes it even more bizarre. I fold the envelope in my hand. “Maybe I should just give this back to Laura to pass on to Ambrose. She seems to know his schedule a lot better.”

Anya’s face sours at the mention of her sister’s name. “Laura sent you? Why didn’t she just drop it off herself?”

“I offered. She’s been swamped lately.”

Anya scoffs. “Sounds like Laura. She’s so good at playing martyr, she doesn’t even have to ask people to do her bidding.”

A sense of protectiveness for my new friend washes over me. “Laura’s not like that.”

“That’s the impression she gives me,” she says, her expression still bored.

“That’s surprising.”

“And why is that?”

“I’d have thought at least her little sister would acknowledge her genuineness.”

Anya’s expression becomes hateful and we both know I’ve caught her off guard. She didn’t expect me to know intimate information about her like she knows about me. It’s immature, but I revel in the small win.

The floodgates on her barely contained disdain open wide. “You know nobody wants a coward like you back in this town, right?”

There it is. The beast on full display. Why bother luring me into her den when she could have just ripped my head off at the door? Her words sting,

but I don't disagree with her. I'm a coward. A coward who abandoned my hometown and everyone in it when I couldn't face the repercussions of my actions.

"I want to be gone just as much as you want me gone, Anya."

She jerks at my admission. It must not have crossed her mind that I could possibly hate myself more than everyone else does. The front door opens and her jaw tightens with protectiveness. "He's made peace with what happened. Don't drag him back to that place, he blamed himself enough."

My throat seizes. "He blamed *himself*?"

Ambrose rounds the corner, stopping short at the sight of me and Anya sitting across from each other. My hands tremble and I slip them under my thighs, bearing down hard enough to focus on the pain instead of Anya's words.

Our silence is a tangible entity in the room.

"Mara... what are you doing here?"

Ambrose doesn't move any farther into the room, but his scent is already settling into the space, making me heady. Anya's sneer remains glued to her face. She's more than happy to let me fend for myself.

I clear my throat. "I was on my way out and I thought I'd drop off this check to you. Laura's been busy. And you have to accept the money. Laura won't take no for an answer."

Not a complete lie. I hold up the envelope as evidence, the tremor in my hand causing it to billow in the air like a kite. I lean forward and drop it on the coffee table.

Ambrose's eyes jump from me to Anya, as if trying to assess the temperature of the room.

"I should get going." I fumble to grab my purse and keys from the floor.

When Ambrose says nothing, I duck my chin at Anya and make a

beeline for the front door. Heavy boots trail behind me.

“Wait.”

Ambrose rubs the back of his neck. Is he *nervous*?

“Sorry to be so weird. It’s just... I haven’t seen you in that room since you were seventeen. Kind of caught me off guard.”

Oh.

I glance over his shoulder to the den and see multiple memories play out across my vision. Ambrose destroying me and Cat on the Wii. Alima setting down a platter of cookies and hot chocolate—even in the summer—while we watched *Practical Magic* for the millionth time. Ambrose ignoring my existence when we all started growing apart.

“I understand,” I whisper.

Anya’s words dance through my mind. He blamed himself. How could he have possibly blamed himself?

After mumbling an excuse about being on a time crunch for the rest of the day, I leave the house so fast I won’t be surprised if I leave skid marks on the ground.

The drive to Nadine’s is short, but it’s enough time for my subconscious to dredge up things that used to be neatly buried. I roam around the nursery in a daze, paying little attention to the plants I place into my cart. The smell of fresh leaves and flowers surround me but feel at odds with the hollowness I feel. I don’t bloom or stretch myself toward the light. I regress so far inward, shadows can’t help but be trapped within my buds.

Grace makes her way to my side, a small empathetic smile on her face. “Can I help you with something, sweetheart?”

My emotional exhaustion causes my voice to fall flat. “What makes you think I need help?”

The corner of her lip tips up as she reaches in to examine the two plants in my cart. “Has anyone ever told you that you look just like your father?”

I shake my head.

She tilts her head. “It’s easy to miss at first, but you have his smile. When you are smiling, that is.” She stares at the plants in my cart, her smile crumbling. “Are you sure you want to get these two?”

I sigh. “Yes. Why?”

“Because the succulents you have here are called *graptopetalum paraguayense*. Most commonly known as ghost plants.”

I laugh.

I laugh and then it slowly morphs into the kind of hysterical cackle that suggests I might be on the brink of a mental breakdown.

“Well,” I say between laughs. “Considering my dad’s state, these should be perfect.”

The poor woman gapes at my dark humor. Surely this wasn’t what she was expecting when she came into work this morning. Still laughing with a hand clutching my side, I leave Grace where she stands in stunned silence and head to the counter to pay for my ghost plants.

And as I walk back to my car, the sun piercing my eyes, I tell myself that the tears streaming down my face are a result of the humor of it all.

The humor and nothing else.

I drove to Duffy’s with single-minded determination. The sun set hours ago and I don’t know how long I’ve been posted up on this cold metal stool sipping away at my drink. No matter how long you sit on metal stools, they always stay cold, biting into your skin, keeping you from getting too comfortable. But the joke is on the stool because I’m never comfortable.

Mara: One.

Stool: Zero.

I snort at my private joke and the man two seats over pins me with a judgmental glare.

“Can I help you, sir?” I drawl.

He shakes his head and sighs. I imitate his sigh and drool dribbles down my chin.

“Look what the city rats dragged in.”

The silky voice comes from the corner of the bar. As the man approaches, I take my time perusing the length of him. His features are hard to make out in the dim lighting, but it’s no question he’s tall and very good-looking. Doesn’t vodka make everyone good-looking though?

The beautiful man boasts an easy smirk and his loose stance tells me he’s had a few drinks himself. The way he says my name insinuates familiarity, though I can’t place his face. He raises an amused brow. “Jackson. Jackson Healy.”

Only now do I see the same Jackson Healy who charmed his way through school when we were kids. His boyish charm has been replaced with something more manly and assertive, but that *smirk*. That smirk confirms that Jackson could still stare a girl into whatever whim he conjures up.

I offer him a small smile. “Hi, Jackson.”

He pulls out the stool next to me and sits down with such ease, you wouldn’t know we haven’t had an actual conversation since I had braces. “What brings you back to Speck Lake, girl?”

I suck on my lemon wedge. “I have family affairs to see to. I’m not staying long.”

The ever-present playful expression on Jackson’s face becomes subdued as he says, “I heard about that. I’m sorry.”

“Thanks.”

Sitting here with Jackson feels weird. We aren’t friends. And while he never made my life a living hell directly, he never defended me either.

The following silence would have made me uncomfortable if I were sober, but the social awkwardness melts off my shoulders like the ice in my lowball glass. Jackson surprises me by shrugging off his jacket and asking the bartender for a round of shots.

I raise my eyebrows in question.

“What?” he says. “You know what they say: those who speak, do; those who can’t, drink.”

I laugh at his asinine adjustment to the famous quote, accepting the shot in front of me. I clink it with his. “*Salute.*”

If I thought I was drunk before Jackson Healy arrived, I’m sadly mistaken. The brute with the easy smile has the ability to get you to toss back spirits like they’re water. I’ve officially reached the point where I’m no longer drunken sad, but drunken *glad*, and the giggles escaping my throat would be humiliating in any other situation.

We talk about a whole lot of nothing, and yet we’re content. Being around Jackson is easy and casual. Nothing like being around Ambrose.

As if thinking about him acts as a beacon, my phone buzzes against my thigh.

Ambrose.

He gave me his number a few weeks ago when we needed to coordinate a supplies drop-off for the house, but we haven’t used the method of contact since. Until now.

Hey, I need to grab a toolbox I left in your dad’s garage. Can I stop by?

Not wanting to appear like I have nothing better to do than keep my eyes glued to my phone all day, I let the message sit for a few minutes. Finally, I

type back:

I'm not home

I'm sweating.

Why am I fucking sweating?

I'm afraid to see how long it takes him to message back, so I motion to Jackson to pass me another shot, to which he responds with an enthusiastic clap. My phone pings.

Where are you?

Ambrose's forwardness isn't out of the ordinary. He's not one to beat around the bush. If he wants to know something, he'll ask. I glance at the clock on the wall that says it's eleven thirty. Everything in town besides the bar is closed by this time and I can't risk getting caught in a lie, so I type:

At Duffy's with an old friend

His response is immediate.

You don't have friends

If I wasn't so drunk, I might be offended but I can't help the giggle fit my body falls victim to. He's right. I have no friends in Speck Lake, not anymore. And I blame no one except myself for that truth. Just when I think the conversation may be over, Ambrose shoots off another message.

How are you planning on getting home?

I slump in my chair with a heavy sigh. His interrogation chips away at the fun I'm trying to convince myself I'm having. I don't know how I'll get home. I'm drunk, but not irresponsible enough to attempt driving myself. I would ask Jackson, but he's just as drunk as I am and I wouldn't be surprised if he has a list of girls who'd come rescue him from himself and tuck him into bed tonight.

As if I don't already feel terrible about my life decisions, a dull pain begins spreading through my temples. I lazily surf the internet for a taxi

service that might still be open at this time while Jackson sings off-key to the song playing overhead.

I'm opening my tenth search tab when the bell to the bar entrance jingles overhead. Fun left about thirty minutes ago and my body longs for sleep. My search for a ride is fruitless and my sluggish brain is making it difficult to be resourceful. Jackson left five minutes ago with a beautiful blonde, not the least bit concerned about how I'd be getting home. Asshole.

I'm chewing on the ice from the bottom of my glass when a warm hand encases my lower back. I shudder out a breath when I meet Ambrose's hard eyes.

"Let's go." He slightly tugs me off the stool, his posture tight.

I don't argue as I stand on shaky legs and Ambrose closes out my tab, the vision of my bed encouraging my feet toward the door. When we reach his car, I balk at the sight of Anya in the passenger seat. I stumble backward, gravel scattering beneath my boots.

"On second thought, I don't need a ride," I slur.

"Oh, really?" he grits. "How are you getting home?"

"My friend."

Ambrose crosses his arms. "What's your friend's name?"

"Car," I say.

"Your friend's name is *car*?"

I'm swaying now. "Cara. I meant, Cara."

Before I can escape, Ambrose draws closer, dwarfing my small frame. "Get in the damn car."

I puff out my chest and lower my voice as deep as it can go, imitating him. "Get in the damn car. Oh, look at me, I'm Ambrose and I can be bossy because I'm as tall as the Chrysler Building." I roll my eyes. "You know, you can't tell me what—"

Ambrose lifts me over his shoulder like I weigh no more than a sack of flour and I shriek. He swings the door to the back seat open, chucking me inside. When he reaches for the seat belt to buckle me in, I swat at his hand and he makes a sound of frustration.

“Brat.”

“Caveman!” I snarl.

When he sticks his key into the ignition, I turn my head and let out an embarrassed groan at the sight of the fourth person in the car.

Matty.

He’s half asleep, but my yelling must have roused him because he stares at me with rapt attention from his booster seat. I lean my head against the window, unable to face him in my pathetic state.

As we drive, I focus all my attention on the Toyota Corolla following closely behind us before my eyes shut, allowing the coolness from the glass window to cool my overheated skin. Ambrose and Anya’s conversation in the front is hushed, but I don’t have the energy to eavesdrop.

We come to a full stop and the gear shifts into park. I immediately let myself out, knowing we are in my driveway. I blindly stumble up the porch stairs, attempting multiple times to get my key into the keyhole—something I tell myself is taking so long because it’s pitch black outside. I personally want to donate streetlights to Speck Lake.

I don’t fight Ambrose when he pulls the key from my hand, opening the door himself, and I don’t fight him when he laces his fingers with mine, pulling me inside.

Silence engulfs us as we watch each other in the darkness of the entryway. I stand there, waiting for him to leave so I can collapse right here on the floor and sleep. Ambrose lets out a harsh sound of frustration and scoops me up into his arms with ease. I’m too drunk to be embarrassed as I

wrap my arms around him and bury my face into his neck, sleep quickly claiming me.

I don't recall the climb up the stairs or even being put into bed, but when I wake in the middle of the night in nothing but an oversized T-shirt and fuzzy socks, I can still smell the fresh linen scent lingering on my skin.

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THEN (AGE 15)

A lot of girls my age would kill to spend their summers in Paris, but I'm not one of them. In another life, I'd be enamored by the magic of the city. I'd appreciate the twinkling lights of the Eiffel Tower that look like fireflies when you squint your eyes. I'd be glad to eat my body weight in the fresh baguettes wafting through the windows on early foggy mornings. I'd walk a little slower while passing the live musicians outside the hole-in-the-wall cafés who play as if they need the music more to survive than the money being tossed into their hats. I'd see Paris for all it has to offer.

But I have qualms with the City of Light.

Paris is not the bearer of my wanderlust, but my bitterness. Paris is the shiny thing that stole my mom away from our family, enticing her with its glitter and gold. No, Paris isn't a lover of mine and I vowed from the age of ten that it never would be.

So when I'm forced to visit the city every summer as per my parents' divorce agreement, I do so with as much pushback as I can muster and this summer is no different.

As I step off the plane, I see my mom's gaze drop to my graphic tee, which reads: *Paris: The City You Smell Before You See*.

"Very funny, *mija*," she mutters, pulling me in for a tight embrace.

She smells the same even though everything is different. Vanilla with a hint of rose. For a second, I abandon my stoicism and embrace her back, inhaling her scent as my eyes sting. Every year she looks younger and more alive, as if she's aging in reverse. She walks with a lively bounce in her step and turns heads in every space she occupies. She's pure vibrancy and I understand why the city won't give her back to me. She doesn't belong in

Speck Lake.

“How was your flight?” she asks.

I readjust the duffel on my shoulder and shrug. “It was fine. The plane food wasn’t half bad this time.”

She laughs and I notice a stranger in my peripheral vision smiling at her in return. “Well, if that’s where your standards are, I haven’t done a good job at exposing you to the food Paris has to offer. Are you hungry? This little Moroccan place that just opened right next to my flat and the kefta mkaouara is *divine*. We can beat the dinner rush if we head straight there.”

She’s already thumbing through her phone, searching for an open reservation when I put my hand over hers. “Actually Mom, I’m exhausted. Is it okay if we rain check?”

Her shoulders stiffen, but she doesn’t express any negative emotions. She never does.

Feel something. Anything. Show me that it’s okay to do so.

She squeezes my hand and smiles. “Sure. Let’s get you some rest.”

The smell of fresh croissants stir me awake. The sun slips through the drapes that hang in the guest room and a male’s laughter mixes with my mom’s in the kitchen. I brush my teeth before throwing on a clean pair of jeans and a T-shirt I got when I joined the film club at school. If the only thing standing between me and fresh croissants is a few minutes of small talk, I’ll do it. Small sacrifices.

“Bonjour, Mara!” Jean-Paul exclaims, pulling me in for a hug before I’m fully in the kitchen. My arms hang limp at my sides until he lets go.

“JP.” I accept the mug of coffee my mom’s extending toward me.

Jean-Paul resembles a wind-up toy that can go and *go*. It’s like someone wound him up and he malfunctioned, never knowing when to stop. He’s

always happy—which makes me suspicious—and he always smells of praline. He’s a baker, a prestigious one according to Parisian standards, which explains the croissants.

I don’t have anything against Jean-Paul. In fact, under any other circumstance, I might enjoy being around him. But like Paris, Jean-Paul is relegated to the side of my list of *things I refuse to love on principle*.

“So, what are we to do today?” he says, clapping his hands in excitement. I’ve known him two years now and every time he speaks, I picture the little French candle from *Beauty and the Beast*.

The silence becomes unbearable as we all glance at each other, waiting to see who will speak first. My mom always makes me feel welcome during my visits, but we never actually spend much time together. She prioritizes her art and leaves me to my own devices while she drowns herself in her work. I’ve already made a list of the new bookstores and cafés I plan on exploring today.

She clears her throat. “I need to get in some studio time. Julien has been pestering me about the second phase of my ceramic series and I’m more than behind.”

She wraps a thin shawl around her shoulders as if her explanation was sufficient. I turn to Jean-Paul. “I’m heading to a few bookstores to look for a biography on Joan of Arc. But thank you for—”

“Wait a minute,” he says, holding up his hands. “Isabel, it’s her summer vacation. We must spend the time together.” I can’t tell if his frown is on my behalf or not.

My mom pins me with pleading eyes, practically begging me to get her out of spending time with me. It’s almost comical. Almost. I give Jean-Paul a casual smile. “I’ll be here for weeks, JP. We’ll have enough time for everything.”

Relief pours off my mom in waves and I brush it off before I can let it wound me. Jean-Paul looks unconvinced, but he concedes.

“Fine.” He sighs, staring directly at my mother. “But the Paris International Film Festival is in two weeks. Mara, I know you enjoy the films. We will all go. *Together.*”

Sensing the reproach in his voice, my mom quickly agrees and gives us each a peck on the cheek before escaping through the front door. I can’t decide what impresses me more; the fact that Jean-Paul has pushed back with my mom or the fact that he remembered my love of film.

Hoping my mom’s exit will conceal my own, I backtrack toward the guest room, reaching out to snag one of the croissants on my way. Before I can wrap my fingers around the delicious piece of heaven, Jean-Paul intercepts, lifting the entire plate into his arms.

“Have breakfast with me.”

I narrow my eyes as if to say *well played* and he grins smugly as if to say *I know*. We squeeze into the tiny kitchen nook and I waste no time stuffing my face with the croissant. The filling is dark chocolate—warm and gooey. We eat in comfortable silence.

“So. You have a boyfriend, yes?” He uses a napkin to brush the crumbs off his shirt.

“Yes,” I say, taking another bite.

He grins. “What is the name of this lucky gentleman?”

I speak around the chunks of croissant in my mouth. “Brandon.”

Jean-Paul lifts his eyebrow in amusement and begins to laugh.

I bristle. “What’s so funny?”

He laughs again, reaching for another croissant, this time one with assorted nuts over the top. “Usually when a lady speaks of the one she loves, she glows like the Seine River at night. I ask you about your love and

you'd think I asked you about the weather."

I shift in my chair, which isn't actually a chair, but a repurposed stool. It's uncomfortable as hell.

Artists.

"Of course I love Brandon, he's my boyfriend," I say.

"Ah. Because you cannot have one without the other?"

His question is more inquisitive than harsh and I take a moment to mull it over. Do I assume I love Brandon only because we're in a relationship?

Jean-Paul interrupts my thoughts by gently tapping my hand. "Don't let my curiosity alarm you. I'm nothing but a rambling old man. I've been letting the poetry get to my head."

I grimace. "I should go get ready." I go to put my plate in the sink and snag another croissant for later.

"Mara," he calls, and I turn at the waist. "Keep me updated. On what you learn of Joan of Arc."

My smile is genuine then. I give him a quick nod and close the door behind me.

The bookstore is smaller than any I've seen—even in Speck Lake—which is saying something. But despite its modest size, the tiny nook houses more books than any other bookstore I've visited. Books of all genres are haphazardly strewn about, stacked on chairs and tables and even the floor. How a person can find what they're looking for is beyond me and eventually I come to the conclusion that the purpose of this place may be for the book to find *you*.

I wander around the two aisles, careful not to knock over the stacks at my feet and before long I'm staring sideways at a tower of biographies, not one indicating Joan of Arc as its subject. I refrain from sighing in

frustration at the place's lack of organization, afraid the sound will echo around the tiny space. There's another bookstore I found on my map that's only a few blocks down. Maybe I'll have more luck there.

"Can I help you find something?" The woman's voice is unnervingly close and I jump back in surprise, bumping into the nearest book tower, causing a few to fall onto the floor.

I apologize profusely and bend over to retrieve the books. I hope they aren't damaged considering I only have thirty euros to my name right now.

"Leave them."

I stand from my half-bent position and gawk. Leave them? Leave the precious new books on the floor like dirty old shoes? The horror in my expression causes the corner of her mouth to twitch. Not quite a smile, but more of a suggestion of one.

"If a person cares only for the words inside when the outside is pristine, the person doesn't care very much at all to begin with." And with that, she turns on her heels, heading back to the front counter.

"Wait!" I stumble after her.

She busies herself pulling books out of a big brown box but raises an eyebrow to indicate she's listening.

"Do you have anything on Joan of Arc?"

She continues emptying the box as she nods. "The nineteen-year-old peasant girl who heard voices from God. I have two. The first is a shorter read covering more of her life before the war. The second is an all-encompassing history. That's the one you'll need if you truly want to understand the warrior. Though, I can't see why a young *chérie* like you would spend all her time reading instead of taking part in the many mistakes Paris has to offer."

I scrunch my nose. "Why would I want to make mistakes?"

“Sometimes mistakes are fun.” she winks.

The woman is older than my mom, but I can’t pinpoint her age. Not that it matters. Like most of the women I’ve seen in Paris, she’s effortlessly beautiful. She’s made no attempt at covering the crow’s-feet at her eyes or filling the lines around her mouth. Her face says she’s well lived and isn’t a stranger to laughter—so much so, the remnants have permanently etched themselves onto her face.

I pull out my coin purse. “I’d like the full history, please.”

To my surprise, she graces me with a full smile and says, “Great choice.”

While she sets off to a corner of the store that looks like it’s been ransacked by a group of bandits, I scan the contents of the basket in front of me. Handmade trinkets created by local artisans lie inside. Each handcrafted piece is unique and yet, they each carry the same sort of magic that only exists in a city like Paris.

I gently move each piece aside and a glimmer catches my eye. It’s a suncatcher in the shape of a small cat curled in on itself. It’s a tiny little thing, taking up little space in the palm of my hand and I lift it up to the morning light coming in from the window. I twist the cat side to side and fractured light breaks off in a million directions, drowning books and surfaces and my own skin in rainbow streaks. I hold the entire color spectrum in my hand.

“That one is the last of its kind. The artist who makes them, Céline, has advanced Rheumatoid Arthritis and can no longer work with her hands. Her son brought over the last of her pieces and they sold out in a day. That one must have gotten lost at the bottom.”

Her expression is grim and I wonder if she knows Céline personally. If she feels the pain in her own hands whenever she talks about her.

I twirl it in the light once more. “I’ll take it.”

I place the suncatcher on the counter alongside the biography she retrieved from the back. As she searches for tissue paper to wrap my purchases in, something else from the basket catches my eye. I only need to examine it for a few seconds to know it was created for him. We don't speak anymore and I'll probably never give it to him, but I have to buy it, if only to hold on to it for safekeeping. I set the piece on the counter for the woman to include in my purchase.

"Fifty euros," she says.

I blanch in embarrassment. I should have asked how much each item costs before allowing her to wrap them up so nicely.

"I'm so sorry," I say, placing my money on the counter. I assume the biography is the more expensive item. "I'm a bit short. Can you take out the book?"

She nods and carries the brown bag toward the register behind her to retrieve my receipt. Confusion fills me when she places the bag in my hands. It is weighty. I peek inside, seeing all three items.

"Excuse me, I think you made a mistake. I didn't give you enough money for all of this."

She shrugs and turns away from me, the dismissal clear as she begins unpacking another box.

"Like I said, *chérie*, sometimes mistakes are fun."

The next two weeks pass in a blur as I spend every spare moment I have reading about Joan of Arc. I jump in and out of bookstores, binge French films, and devour every baked piece of heaven Jean-Paul brings home each morning. JP tries not to hover and I show my gratitude by gracing him with a fact about Joan of Arc each time we cross paths. My mom remains entranced in her work and the only times I see her are before bed when she

comes in to say good night, buried under layers of dried clay and linseed oil.

I've all but forgotten about the film festival when Jean-Paul comes home one evening and stands in my open doorway with his hands on his hips.

"Um, bonjour?" I say.

"I know *casual* is the American way of life, but to wear sweatpants to the Paris International Film Festival? Mara. This hurts me."

My eyes widen as I remember the date.

"Ah, you forgot." Jean-Paul sounds relieved. "If you get ready quickly, we will still have good seats on the grass. We will leave in twenty minutes, yes?"

"Yes!" I scramble for my towel and a presentable outfit. "What about my mom?"

"She will meet us there."

Forty-five minutes later we pull into the parking lot of the festival. I grab the tote at my feet before stepping out of the car, triple-checking that I remembered to bring a small blanket and light sweater. When Jean-Paul pops open his trunk, I hold in my laugh.

Packed side by side are two tote bags and a picnic basket filled to the brim with items he's packed for the night. The tote bags hold an assortment of quilts and mini pillows, while the basket makes a clinking noise of glass on glass when he picks it up. It doesn't take a genius to guess the contents. I'm pretty sure wine runs through his veins.

Surprisingly, we made good time and we end up securing the spot closest to the jumbo screen. Families and friends scatter about on their own blankets and mats and I wonder if we all look like a quilted blanket from an aerial view. A mini stage has been erected beneath the screen with a handful of chairs and microphones resting on them.

“After each film, the director and some of the cast will give us some insight and answer questions from the audience.” Jean-Paul points.

I nod, keeping my eyes locked on the stage, feeling excitement bubble beneath my skin. I’ve never had the opportunity to witness something so close to the entertainment industry. In Speck Lake, I can watch all the movies I want, but here I get a sneak peek behind the veil.

A tall, lanky guy who looks like an intern steps onto the stage, letting everyone know that the first film of the night, a black and white indie called *La Lune est à Nous*, will begin in ten minutes.

I tap Jean-Paul’s shoulder as he organizes his makeshift charcuterie board. “Is my mom close?”

His shoulders tense and he checks the time on his phone. “She should be here any second now.”

The chatter around us dies down as everyone begins settling in. The opening credits dance across the screen and Jean-Paul leans in to whisper something about my mom running a little late due to an issue with the master kiln at the studio. I push back at the hurt begging for entrance in my chest and focus on the film. I’m not shocked, but that fact does little to lessen the blow. About a third of the way through the film, Jean-Paul whispers through gritted teeth that my mom is only going to be able to make it for the second film and I lift a shoulder in indifference, consumed by the conflict in the film. The heroine, Colette, is contemplating how to tell her lover, Françoise, that she’s responsible for his brother’s death.

It’s not until we’re halfway through the second showing of the night, a film noir called *Une Vie D’ombres*, that I give Jean-Paul my full attention. He single-handedly crushed a bottle of wine by himself and his shoulders hunch over in disappointment. My mom’s absence is affecting him more than me.

I stack prosciutto and brie cheese on a cracker before clearing my throat. “These films are great, JP. Thanks for bringing me.”

He’s silent and when he looks at me, his eyes are tired. “I’m sorry, Mara. I don’t see how she could do this.”

I don’t have the heart to tell him that this isn’t out of the ordinary for my mother and her flaking out on our plans was to be expected.

“It’s really okay,” I say with a smile, trying to lighten the mood. “She’s been like this since I was a kid.”

Jean-Paul flinches at that before taking a swig from the new bottle of wine he’s just opened. I return my attention to the film and he rasps out, “She’s an enigma, your mother.”

I grow still, letting him continue. “When I married her, I thought: there it is, there is the light I’ve been searching for. She was a torch and if you were lucky to be in her presence, she shone on you. Danced around you with that... with that *glow* of hers.” Jean-Paul twists the silver band on his finger as his eyes sadden. “But she is selfish. I don’t think she means to be. She simply... can’t see the people or things beyond her own light. And I love her. I would choose to disappear in her light any day. But I am sorry for you, Mara. I am sorry that you did not get to choose.”

I keep my eyes glued to the screen, holding my breath to keep the tremor in my throat at bay. Jean-Paul affords me a small mercy by returning to his cheeses and wines instead of pushing the conversation further. And when the film ends, I join the crowd as we stand to our feet for a standing ovation. We’re all strangers but I feel less alone.

Our trek back to the parking lot is somber and while Jean-Paul loads everything back into the car, I settle into the front seat, pulling my book on Joan of Arc into my lap. He drives in silence as I read and when we return to the flat, the flat is dark and empty. I already know my mom is still at the

studio and not asleep in her bed. I chuck my shoes by the door and mutter a halfhearted good night.

“You’ll have to let me know your thoughts when you read about Joan of Arc surrendering to Lyonnel de Wandomme.”

I turn slowly. “What did you just say?”

Jean-Paul grunts and face-palms. “Forgive me. I’ve had too much wine and look, now I have gone and spoiled the surprise.”

“You... you already know the history of Joan of Arc?”

He blinks once. Then again. “Yes.”

“How?”

He examines his fingernail before lifting a shoulder. “I had a class on the life of Joan of Arc when I worked toward my license, er—I believe it is called an *undergraduate degree* in the states.”

Jean-Paul slips off his shoes in the corner and pours himself a glass of water with complete nonchalance, as if he hasn’t just told me that he’s basically an expert on the one topic I’ve been rambling on to him about for the past two weeks.

Baffled, I ask, “Why?”

He doesn’t miss a beat. “Why what?”

“Why let me go on and on every day about her life? Why sit there through it all? You probably know more than I could ever learn from this book—why listen to me?”

He ponders my question before tipping his glass back, chugging the rest of his water. He shrugs off his jacket, throws it on the coat rack in the entryway and returns, his eyes solid.

“Because you have things to say. And people should listen.”

I haven't seen Ambrose since he dragged me from the bar and tucked me into bed like a drunken sorority girl. More than the shame I feel at making him redirect whatever plans he was taking part in with Anya and Matty, I'm afraid that he sees the bone-deep weariness that has settled into my eyes as my dad grows sicker.

Every time Laura goes to take Otso for a walk, I insist on doing it myself, glancing at the house across the street for any signs of life. Ambrose's car is always missing during the day and I refuse to look out my window at night when the sounds of wheels scrape up the driveway. I don't want to see Anya climb out of the passenger seat only to disappear with him inside. Ambrose said there's nothing romantic between the two of them anymore, but I can't help being jealous of her mere proximity to him. What can I say? I'm a flawed human.

I'm watching *Casablanca* on my phone and answering work emails when Laura calls my name from downstairs. I drag my feet as I enter my dad's room to find her hunkered down in a chair, administering a clear medication through his IV.

"Can you grab my medical bag from the living room? I think I left it on the sofa." Her voice is agitated and she doesn't meet my eyes.

"Of course." I start to leave but decide to take a step closer to her instead. "Is everything alright, Laura?"

"Yes, honey," she says, pinching the bridge of her nose. "I don't mean to be snippy. Your father needed some extra attention last night, so I didn't head home until three. And now my sister has gone MIA and my nephew is staying with me," she sighs. "Forgive me. You don't want to listen to the

problems of an old woman.”

“Anya’s missing?”

“Yes. I haven’t heard from her in two days. It’s not unusual for her to dump Matty on me or Ambrose, but she usually at least calls.”

Overwhelming concern seeps off Laura. I’m by no means friendly with Anya, but I don’t wish any ill will upon her.

“I’ll keep an eye out for her, okay?”

Laura nods, but there’s no relief in her eyes. She resembles a woman who’s lived a thousand lives and in every single one of them, she’s her sister’s keeper. I can relate to that because it’s how it used to be between Cat and me.

I let thoughts of her in then. Not for very long, maybe a second or two. A brief allowance. I speculate where she is right now and if she’s happy. In the days of protruding collarbones and knobby knees, I was her keeper and she was mine. Who kept her now? I could go see her. I owe her that much. But that would require courage and that word has never been synonymous with Mara Makinen.

I lay Laura’s bag next to her feet and lean down to kiss my dad’s cheek. And I can feel the tug of the wave. The wave of emotions that would wash me away and obliterate my existence if I let it. But I can’t. Because if I do, I’m not sure I’ll ever recover.

“Don’t look at me like that.”

Vulnerable brown eyes hold me captive.

“What you want from me... I can’t give to you.”

A whimper.

“It’s not you, it’s me.”

The harrumph that follows is entertaining enough to make me laugh.

Otso sits before me—though it looks more like standing—with a leash near his feet that he continuously nudges closer to my shoe. Laura hasn't expected me to look after him, but even I can admit that the bear-sized family member has grown on me. His big eyes alone have convinced me to take him out for walks on multiple occasions.

A whine creeps up his throat, showing me that he's not above begging.

I sigh. "So, what you're saying is... you want to go *outside*?"

At the mere mention of the word, Otso yelps in excitement, chasing his tail like a two-week-old puppy. I taunt him further.

"I don't know, you don't really seem too excited at the idea of going *outside*!" I emphasize the word even more and he resorts to a full-body bellow. Some would think me terrible for stringing along such an innocent creature, but I can't help but laugh at the scene. At what other time would I have such an enormous mammal at my mercy?

I swoop down, grabbing the leash and securing it to the collar hidden between his fur. "As you wish. Let's go."

The street is uninhabited and the sunset bleeding onto the cul-de-sac's roundabout paints the road in rich reds and cotton-candy pinks. The windows around me glow with a warm-yellow light. Everyone is home and safe behind their front doors.

Otso pulls me along the sidewalk, which is more of a hodgepodge concoction of cement and chunks of grass. In New York, something like this would be complained about and fixed within twenty-four hours lest they receive a lawsuit, but the people in Speck Lake don't mind these kinds of things. They welcome the imperfect—the things that grow within the cracks and fissures. And even though I was born and raised here just the same, I can never bring myself to see the beauty in imperfection like everyone else.

Otso leads the way and I pretend to be impressed when he drops sticks at my feet like a peasant offering gifts to the royal court. I'm oohing and aahing over one particularly impressive branch when I think I hear someone calling my name.

"Mara!" comes the small voice again, closer this time.

Matty bounds across the street, running for no good reason. The way little kids always do. His flushed cheeks match his hair and he reminds me of a little fox chasing a rabbit with haste. Ambrose follows behind and the nervous energy has me bouncing on the soles of my feet. The sunset medley in the sky encases his body. He's orange and red and pink, but his eyes... still green. Always that *green*.

"Hey, Matty." I smile, redirecting my eyes to the little fox.

He bends down, burying his face in Otso's fur and giggles when he's drowned in his saliva.

"What are you up to?" I ask. I keep my eyes on him even though I feel Ambrose's heat a few inches away now. Every part of my body reacts to his closeness and I internally chide myself for being so affected by his presence.

Matty responds in between the kisses he plants on Otso's head. "We're on an expedition!"

I grin. "An expedition?"

When he's too distracted to respond, I force myself to face Ambrose. His eyes are on me, intense and heavy as always.

"Hi," I say, lifting a hand in a small wave.

His eyes sink into me. "Hi."

"Expedition?"

He purses his lips and my gaze shamelessly latches on to his mouth. "Matty here doesn't believe that the Mourning Dove is the most widespread

backyard bird in North America. Says he has to ‘see it to believe it.’”

I kick a rock near my shoe. “I might be with you on this one, Matty. I’ve never seen a Moring Dove either.”

“*Mourning Dove*,” Ambrose corrects. “And just because you haven’t seen it doesn’t mean it’s not there.”

I study him. Physically, the man standing in front of me is the opposite of the boy I grew up with. But there, behind his eyes, lives the same brainy kid who remains obstinate about living creatures.

Matty and I smile at each other, secretly reveling in the fact that we both know how to get under Ambrose’s skin. This kid is really growing on me. Otso pulls on the leash, sniffing in the direction of a squirrel and Matty asks if he can walk him for a minute. When I hand the leash over, Ambrose says, “Stay close.”

We’re alone and thankfully, Ambrose speaks first.

“How are you feeling?”

I know the real question behind the question. How am I feeling after getting pathetically hammered and attempting to fall asleep on the cold, hard *floor*?

I cringe at the memory. “Better. I’m sorry I put you in that situation.” I rub the back of my neck. “I’m embarrassed.”

“Don’t be. It happens.”

I snort. “I doubt you’ve gotten so drunk someone’s had to carry you to bed.” My face burns at the mention of my bed and suddenly I smell fresh linen again.

His mouth twitches as he shrugs. “I’ve gotten close.”

We watch Matty as he runs around the bushes with Otso. It’s never crossed my mind that Otso might need more attention and physical exercise now that my dad is incapacitated. I make a mental note to take him out

more, even if it means being pulled around like a rag doll.

“So listen, I’m going to stop by tomorrow night. I finally found a sliding door that will fit in the back of the house, and I want to leave the parts in the garage.”

I nod. “Sure. I’ll text you the garage code.”

“I already have it.”

Of course. Because we used to be close. Because he and Cat used to spend just as much time in my house as a kid as I did.

“Right,” I whisper.

Matty skips back to us, Otso galloping in tow like the happiest dog in Speck Lake. Matty’s hair is drenched in sweat, but he doesn’t seem bothered in the least.

“We’re going to the lake tomorrow for a party! Will you come?”

I take the leash from him and lean down to scratch Otso’s ear. Matty inviting me to the lake instead of Ambrose feels a lot like your friend asking their parents if you can spend the night when you’re right in front of them. Inexplicably awkward.

“Um... I don’t know, I have a lot of things to get done around the house.”

“You should come,” Ambrose says.

Something flutters in the pit of my stomach and if I’m not mistaken, it feels a bit like hope. Ambrose doesn’t give off the impression that this is a pity invite and I’m surprised he wants me there. As if he senses my next thought, he says, “Anya can’t come. She has a few job interviews.”

I look at Matty again and he’s nodding in confirmation with a smile the size of Maine. That smile is enough to secure a yes from me.

“Alright. But I must warn you”—I bend down to tickle his side—“I show no mercy when it comes to chicken fights.”

Matty's laughter fills the streets and Ambrose stares down on him with adoration in his eyes.

"Okay, little man. If we hurry, we can scour the park for that wolf you swore you saw." Ambrose dips his chin in my direction. "We'll head out at eleven tomorrow."

"See you then," I say, waving them off.

As they drive away, I contemplate whether I've made the right decision. It's one thing, doing this back-and-forth dance with Ambrose, but I don't want to bring Matty into the middle of it. What he needs in his life right now is stability and people who will remain constant. That's not something I can say about myself.

As I make my way back toward the house with Otso, a blue Toyota Corolla screeches its way up Anya's driveway. It only takes me a few seconds to realize it's her now ex-boyfriend, the scraggly asshole who I had the displeasure of meeting weeks ago. He jumps out of his car and I feel a smug sort of satisfaction knowing no one is going to answer the door.

I watch from my driveway as he raps on the front door, the sound echoing throughout the deserted street. I intend on minding my own business until he begins yelling Anya's name. He doesn't attempt to conceal the anger in his voice, and I have to blink multiple times to realize I'm not hallucinating when I see him attempting to pry the window near the front door open. When the window doesn't budge, he eyes the trellis leading up to the second-story balcony—the balcony that opens into Matty's bedroom, which I know because I've seen him throwing paper airplanes from the ledge.

My eyes frantically search the other houses on our street, hoping someone will witness the same thing I do. A little voice in my head, probably my rationale, orders me to take Otso inside, but another part of me

can't stand the idea of him trying to trespass a place he's no longer welcome.

It's that part of me that pulls my feet forward. Men infringing on a woman's safe space doesn't sit right with me. As I get closer, Otso releases a low growl as if he too knows the man before us is of questionable character.

"She's not home," I say, keeping my distance.

He turns around slowly, a grimy smile plastered to his face. He has a smile that makes you feel violated in a million different ways.

His cough is rough and wet and he wipes his mouth with the back of his hand. "Hey, beautiful. I was wondering when I'd have the pleasure of seeing you again."

"I can't say the feeling's mutual."

He laughs, faking a blow to the chest and Otso growls again. His expression hardens. "There's something of mine in this house and I really need it."

"I'm sure when Anya comes back home, she can help you find it. Until then, I think it's best you leave."

When he takes a step toward me, I mimic him by taking a step back and he sighs. "The thing is... I can't do that."

Otso tugs on the leash harder and only then do I become aware that the sun has fully set. The street is no longer a medley of colors but darker as it dances with the shadows. The lack of streetlights aid in obscuring our presence.

I add to the distance between us, walking backward toward the end of the driveway. "You have ten minutes. If I see you still standing here, I'll call the cops."

I don't wait for a response as I speed walk back to my house and the

adrenaline pounding against my eardrums drowns out the voice in my head telling me to wait until he leaves before entering my house.

I forgot how much I missed our lakes. The changing season has officially sent our temperatures into a decline, but we swim for hours nonetheless and the chill on my wet skin feels like a resurfaced memory. Laughter reverberates through the air and I smile to myself. When we got here, my steps were slow and unsure and I pretty much used Ambrose as a human shield. But I wasn't met with disdain or judgment like I'd expected. I was hugged and loved on and for the first time in a long time, I allowed it.

I watch Matty skip rocks with a few other kids, digging my toes deeper into the wet sand. Ambrose plops down at my side with a carton of loaded nachos. He holds them out to me.

My eyes widen, mouth already salivating, as I pluck a few and shove them into my mouth. I groan. "If there's one thing the city can't replicate, it's Annie McLaine's loaded nachos." I reach for another. "Damn, you hit the jackpot too. There's not a bare nacho in here."

"I scooped up the top," he says.

I tilt my head in confusion. "What?"

"The top of the nacho platter. I only took the pieces that were loaded with the good stuff."

"You stood there and carefully extracted the nachos that had adequate toppings?" I laugh. "You don't even like nachos."

"No. But you do."

My heart sputters out and when I open my mouth to respond, a bucket of water drenches my front side. Matty runs away laughing with his friends close on his heels.

"Matty! Not cool!" Ambrose yells. "I'm sorry about that, Mouse."

I laugh, pulling my soaked shirt over my head, leaving me in nothing but the old black bikini top I scrounged from one of the storage boxes. “It’s fine. He’s just a kid.”

“Here, put this on,” he says, tossing me his crew neck. It lands in my lap.

“Oh, I’m not cold.”

He blows out a harsh breath, his gaze swinging on me. “Just”—his eyes roam the strings of my bikini top—“put it on.” He turns back to the nachos he doesn’t like and I shift my eyes toward the water, biting back a small grin.

I promise myself I’ll tell Ambrose about my run-in with Anya’s ex while we play tag with the kids, but the ease in his posture and smirk on his face pushes me into silence. Then, I try to make it happen while we roast marshmallows, but Matty and I get into a heated debate on whether s’mores are better with fully burned marshmallows or ones lightly so.

It’s too easy, spending the day together. Natural. And I’m aware it’s because Ambrose and I are no strangers to making memories in a group of three. I don’t want to ruin it.

When we finally pull into Ambrose’s driveway with sun-kissed skin and sand between our toes, it’s pouring rain. A light from the den flickers on and the front door opens. Anya runs out with an umbrella, looking casual but pretty in a mauve tracksuit. Her eyes are tired as she unbuckles a sleeping Matty from his booster seat, enveloping him in her arms.

She lays a gentle kiss on his forehead and something strikes me. I’m witnessing a woman who loves her child wholeheartedly. No matter her vices.

“Did he have fun?” she asks Ambrose, her eyes bypassing me in the passenger seat.

Ambrose’s smile is gentle. “He got a raging belly ache from all of the

food he stuffed his face with, but I think he'd do it again if he had the chance."

Anya chuckles and it makes her look younger. More alive underneath the purple bags and deep lines on her face.

"I'm glad you all had a good time."

You all? Does that include me? Before I can respond, Anya closes the door and walks in the direction of her house, carrying Matty like he weighs no more than a sack of flour.

When I face Ambrose, he looks just as confused as I am and I think better than to ask.

"Thanks for today," I say, grabbing my purse from the floor.

Ambrose nods and I take it as my cue to go. I take my time walking to my front door, not minding the rain. Once I let myself in, I turn around to latch the dead bolt, but stop to watch his house.

Ambrose leans against the side of his car, the confused expression still on his face as he stares right back at me in the rain.

I lock the door and gather a few deep breaths in the darkness of the front hall. When Ambrose looks at me, he has a way of absorbing all the oxygen in a five-mile radius.

The house is so quiet, I can hear my clothes shift across my skin as I make my way toward the staircase. I don't hear Laura nearby. The cold draft causes the hairs on my arms to stick straight up and I rub them instinctively. I follow the cool sensation, finding myself in the den where Ambrose plans on replacing the sliding doors. Nothing looks out of place, but a string of cold air curls around my neck.

I inch closer to the sliding door, examining it. I flip the light switch to get a better look, but nothing happens. It's probably because of the rain and I add it to the list of things Ambrose will need to fix. Using the flashlight on

my phone, I lift my arm out in front of me and my heart drops to my feet. It's easy to miss, but it's there. A small piece of wood holds the sliding door open no more than two inches.

Laura must have left it open on accident. She's been ranting that the fresh air from outside does more for our health than the filtered junk from our air conditioners. But where is she?

I'm kicking the piece of wood with my shoe and locking the sliding door when I hear a muffled bark from upstairs.

Otso.

Laura never puts him away in the room anymore, at least not since he's become accustomed to me. Maybe he snuck into the trash again and she got fed up. I climb the stairs, letting my phone guide the way. I stick my ears out in every direction and the barking becomes stronger to my right—near the coat closet.

I'm used to walking around the house in the dark but tonight it carries a sinister edge and my hand trembles as I reach for the doorknob. Otso leaps toward my waist, whimpering, and I clutch the doorframe to keep my knees from buckling. Behind him is a mound of doggy treats on the floor.

"Who put you in here, boy?" I whisper.

The sound of glass shattering travels from downstairs, paralyzing my movements. Otso lets out a predatory bark and I use my knee to nudge him back inside. If Laura's downstairs, I don't want her to get attacked just because he's scared.

"Go, buddy. Get back in. I'll come back in a few minutes."

He's hesitant but follows my order. He sits in the corner and his whimper makes my heart squeeze.

"Laura?" I call, heading back down. She doesn't answer and something feels off. Wrong. Every bone in my body tells me to avoid the lower level

of the house and I would if it wasn't for...

Dad.

I run in the direction of my dad's room, tripping over my loosened shoelaces. His room is dark except for a glowing night-light near the window. As I get closer, I see that he's sound asleep, breathing steadily in perfect harmony with the oxygen machine. I exhale with relief and lean down to kiss his forehead.

You're watching too many horror movies, Mara.

I close his door behind me and hear the sickening smack before I feel it. White orbs dance across my vision and then it's dark.

When I come to, the first thing I notice is the hardwood floor my face rests upon. It desperately needs to be mopped. Dust floats around my nostrils as I attempt to steady my breathing. The second thing I notice is that it's no longer dark. A small lamp resting on a table in the entryway casts a faint glow.

Sitting beside the lamp is Anya's ex.

He looks calm with his legs crossed and hands clasped in his lap. I lick at my dry lips, hyperaware of the warm liquid trickling down my face.

He tilts his head to the side, a smirk lining his mouth. "Morning. Or should I say night? Either way, welcome back from your slumber, beautiful."

I attempt to move, but my ribs reject the request.

"Oh, I wouldn't do that. You don't want to hurt yourself." He laughs.

My throat constricts in fear. "What do you want?"

"I told you what I wanted. My money."

I blanch. "I don't have your money."

He rolls his eyes as he shrugs off his jacket like I've asked him to make himself comfortable. "Obviously. But you got in the way of me getting my

money. I've got to get it from somewhere, Mara."

How does he know my name?

"I honestly wasn't planning on knocking you out. Scout's honor." He laughs, drawing an X over his heart. "But you came home before I could find anything of value in this shithole."

"Fuck you."

"Yes!" He cackles. "I love that. I love that fire. I was wondering what Ambrose saw in you and I get it now. You and Anya both have it. That *bite*." He stands slowly and lowers to his knees in front of me. I don't have the strength to move away. Bringing his lips to my face, his breath is hot and smells of cigarettes. "But unlike Ambrose, I like to bite back."

I strike my leg out like a viper, aiming for his groin, and pain shoots down my leg. When he dodges my advance, he *tsks* at me like I'm an insolent child. He digs his fist into my rib cage and I choke out a muffled scream beneath his palm firmly clamped over my mouth.

He hooks his thumb in the belt loop of my jeans and tugs before gliding his hand into my backside pocket and I began to shake. "Tell me where to find some money, Mara, or I'll have to go searching for myself."

A single knock sounds at the front door and he freezes, fingers stiff in my empty pocket.

"Expecting someone?" he whispers, tilting his head in curiosity.

I shake my head vehemently.

Ambrose.

Ambrose is supposed to drop off parts in the garage.

Hoisting me up by my forearms, he stands me upright and I bite the inside of my cheek to prevent myself from crying out.

"Get rid of them. And while you do that, I'll go and keep your dad company. Nifty little oxygen tank he has. I think I'll get a better look."

I lurch for him, but he swats me away like a fly. “Don’t you fucking touch him.”

He smiles, pointing toward the door. “Get rid of them.”

He shuts himself inside of my dad’s room and it takes everything in me not to follow him. To use my small kernel of strength left to stop him from even breathing the same air as him.

I limp toward the door at a glacial pace, avoiding the deep breaths that make my ribs throb in pain. Opening the door a few inches, I face Ambrose.

“Hey,” I whisper.

His eyes scan the length of me, even in the dark. “Hi.”

I wait for him to continue.

“Is everything okay? I was coming by to drop this stuff off in the garage and I thought I heard a scream.”

I allow faux confusion to paint my face. “Ah, it must have been the movie I’m watching. Thrillers... you know how much they love their screams.”

He doesn’t look convinced. “You sure?”

“Yea! I’m okay,” I say, but the dried tear tracks on my face say otherwise. “I should head to bed, I didn’t realize how late it was. See you tomorrow?”

Ambrose’s eyes narrow and I prepare for him to insist on coming inside, but he says, “Okay. See you tomorrow.”

I close the door and Anya’s ex slips out of the shadows. I glare at him and his eyes float to the lock I’ve purposefully left undone. He shoves me aside to lock it himself but before his skeletal hands make contact with the dead bolt, the door flies open, throwing him onto his back with force.

Ambrose flies over the threshold, a blur as they become a tangled mess at my feet. I stumble back as Ambrose punches him in the dark, the click of

the man's jaw the only indicator that his fist met its target.

"Call the cops, Mara," he grunts, pinning him beneath his arms like game in a trap. His voice is soft but deadly and I don't hesitate as I reach for my phone.

The cops arrive not long after.

Anya's ex, who I now know is named Jason, is taken away in handcuffs and I'm assured by three different police officers that because he'd been out on probation, this offense will put him away for a while. Though my ribs still ache like they're on fire, the EMT said they're more likely bruised than broken and the cut on my head is a superficial one. Ambrose and I make eye contact only a few times as we give our statements to multiple people carrying notepads.

And as quickly as they arrived, they leave—Ambrose and I are the only two people remaining on the porch, wondering what the hell just happened.

I turn to him. "How did you know?"

He wipes a speck of dried blood from his busted eyebrow and flinches. "How did I know what?"

"That I was lying."

Ambrose doesn't respond right away. Anger emanates from his body as he stares daggers into the empty street. "You were biting your lip. It's your tell."

I scrunch my nose. "I have a tell? Since when?"

He tilts his head toward me, amusement lighting his eyes despite the circumstances and his voice is gentle. "Since you were twelve."

My chest clenches at the thought that I could still be that little girl I was all those years ago. That he could still know me so thoroughly.

He shifts on his feet, preparing himself to leave.

Don't go. Don't go. Don't go.

He opens his mouth to speak.

“Will you stay?” I blurt out.

His eyes widen at my request.

“You don’t have to if you don’t want to. It’s just... Otso seems really shaken up, and he knows you so well and—”

Ambrose shuts me up by entwining his large fingers with mine, pulling me into the house. Heat engulfs me as he leads us up the stairs into the room I now occupy and I almost ask him how he knows which room to go to until I remember the night he tucked me into bed after my bar escapade. My face burns with residual embarrassment.

He stops at the foot of my bed, kicking off his shoes and then he lifts his shirt over his head and lies on the left side, I almost choke.

“What are you doing?” I squeak.

He fluffs my spare pillow beneath his head. “Going to sleep.”

“Um...”

“Come,” he says, patting the space next to him. “Sleep.”

When I don’t move, he lets out a soft sigh. “It’s just sleeping, Mouse.”

“Don’t call me that,” I mumble as I kick off my shoes and climb into bed.

Thanks to the full-size bed and Ambrose’s enormous frame, our bodies are separated by only a few inches. We both lie on our sides and I can feel the breaths that enter and exit his body.

His eyes are closed and he looks peaceful for someone who’s just kicked an intruder’s ass. And intruder who dated his ex. The ex of his ex. Thinking about it gives me a migraine.

“What?” His eyes are still closed. He must feel me staring.

“Thank you.”

His eyes flutter open and he holds my gaze. He lifts his hand and gently

brushes a stray curl from my face. His eyes drop to my mouth and I swear he leans forward an inch. I hold my breath and close my eyes as the smell of mint and linen washes across my face.

The pad of his thumb sweeps across my lip and my heart beats in a staccato rhythm.

I lean forward.

“Sleep, Mouse,” he whispers, kissing the corner of my mouth. And I know in that moment he sees the past fall like a veil over my eyes because he says, “Nothing bad is going to happen. I promise.”

I let out the breath trapped in my chest and for the first time in my life, I do exactly what Ambrose King tells me to do. The thing I haven’t been able to do without the help of alcohol or a podcast or a really long movie.

I sleep.

The school buzzes with excitement. Who knew school dances would play such a huge role in the happiness of teenagers? But then again, we're a tiny, *tiny* school so we pretty much blow everything out of proportion to make our lives seem more exciting. In the weeks leading up to prom, you couldn't walk to class or enjoy your lunch without being a witness to countless over-the-top prom proposals. *Promposals*, as we call them. Every day the banners get bigger and the screams get louder. On Monday we were hyping up Levi Clemson who'd showed up with a life-sized bear holding a sign that said "Prom would be unBEARable without you" and by Thursday he was overshadowed by Stacy Adams, the senior editor of the school newspaper, who'd taped photographs of her and her boyfriend over the length of an entire hallway. Her sign said, "Can you *picture* us at prom together?" What's become clear to me is that prom puns are where the magic happens.

I have no qualms with asking Brandon to prom myself, but he's made it clear it's something he wants to do himself. So when he asks me to hang back and show up to the lunchroom ten minutes later than usual, I can't help the anticipation that bubbles in my stomach.

The bell between periods rings and I linger at my locker, giving Brandon enough time to set his plan in motion. I smile to myself, reorganizing the books inside. I reach for the pocket-sized microfiber cloth at the back of my locker to clean the mirror on the door and a figure is reflected behind me.

"Vanity doesn't suit you, Mouse."

I stare daggers at Ambrose. If looks could kill, he'd be six feet under. "What do you want?"

He uses my mirror to search for gunk in his teeth. “I saw Blandon in the lunchroom and you weren’t trailing behind his feet. I figured I’d set out to look for the lost puppy before he put up flyers.”

“It’s *Brandon*. And you’re an asshole.”

He grins and I hate that such an annoying face can be so beautiful. “I know.”

I slam my locker shut, leaning against it. “And where’s *your* master? She might set you upon a pyre if she sees you talking to me. I’d be happy to provide her with two coins to place over your eyes for the boatman.”

His laugh is genuine and I bite down on my lip to keep from smiling in response. Ambrose is contagious like that. There are few things in this world that fill my heart with as much joy as hearing Ambrose laugh. *Really* laugh. It’s something that doesn’t occur very often these days.

“Listen,” he says, growing serious. “You think you could give Cat a ride home today? I have a last-minute tutoring session and my mom is caught up at work.”

“Sure.” I shrug. “What about your dad?”

Ambrose’s eyes harden at the mention of him. “I’m not asking that asshole for help.”

I’ve never understood how Ambrose came to feel such a strong hatred for his dad. His parents are still married and they argue all the time, but that’s just it—they argue. Nothing else. I get that it must be frustrating to hear all the time but it doesn’t seem to me like the blame should fall on one parent more than the other. Even Cat doesn’t let the fighting faze her anymore.

I push aside the fact that we’re no longer friends, the fact that Ambrose makes me feel like chopped liver on the best of days and take a step toward him, lowering my voice.

“Are you okay? I mean, really okay?”

His face goes blank before returning to its usual *I don't give a shit* state.

“Don't you have somewhere to be?”

I shake my head in disappointment. “Good talking to you too, Ambrose. And cover that hickey on your neck, it makes you look trashy.” I start walking away.

“You know you don't have to rush into anything you're not ready for, right?” The only reason I turn around is because I hear something I've never heard in Ambrose's voice. I can't quite place it but it's somewhere in the realm of fear and worry.

“What are you even talking about?”

“Don't play dumb, Mara.” The way he says my name makes me feel a way that a girl with a boyfriend should not be feeling. And yet, here we are. “You're telling me Brandon hasn't brought it up with prom being only a week away?”

The anger that builds in me is so quick I wonder if it was always sitting there just waiting to be unleashed. It's a blazing fire that grows by the second and the idea that Ambrose would try to give me *advice*, like he hasn't kept me at arm's length for years, makes me want to drag him into the flames with me. I look at the time on my phone. I'm supposed to be walking into the lunchroom in one minute.

“He didn't have to bring it up,” I say. “I already did.”

Ambrose's spine stiffens. “What?”

“I said—”

“I heard what you said.” He's close now. When did he get so close? His body radiates anger. Or maybe it's me. It's probably both. “And you're not sleeping with Brandon.”

Thirty seconds.

Ambrose is the king of making me feel invisible. He's shown minimal to zero interest in my life for years. Who does he think he is, making such a demand? "I'll do whatever the hell I want. Why do you even care?"

"I don't."

"You could have fooled me." I glance down at my phone again. Time is up. I turn on my heels. When I reach the end of the hall, I turn back and Ambrose is still standing in front of my locker, seething.

"I'm sorry, Ambrose," I say and he stills. "For whatever happened that made you this way. But I don't have time for this. I don't have time to mull over all the things you do and don't say anymore. Brandon sees me. He—"

"You think I don't see you?" his voice is low but has an edge to it.

I shake my head. "I hope you don't. I really hope you don't, Ambrose, because if this is what being *seen* by you is like? I don't want it."

I push through the doors of the lunchroom, still swaying with the heightened emotions Ambrose and I shared in the hallway. It's unclear where his anger ends and mine begins.

I almost forget to smile as Brandon walks to the center of the cafeteria with a bouquet of flowers in hand, surrounded by freshmen holding up posters that read, "1 Word, 3 Letters, Say It and I'm Yours at Prom."

From the corner of my eye, I see Ambrose enter the cafeteria, arms crossed over his chest, glaring from me to Brandon.

"Yes," I call out.

The masses erupt in cheers.

"So," I say as Cat and I exit the dress shop. "Should we get Cinnabon like old times? I'm still full from lunch but I think I can fit one in. Or three. I believe in myself."

Cat looks visibly uncomfortable as she unfolds and refolds the receipt in

her hands. “Actually, there’s something I wanted to talk to you about.”

I stop walking. “What?”

Cat’s eyes land everywhere except on me. She hates conflict. “My brother.”

“Yes?”

“Ambrose.”

“I’m aware that’s his name, go on.”

“Well,” she says. “I told him to reserve the remaining seats at our dinner table for prom.”

“You *what*?” My volume is high for someone who never raises their volume.

“Mara, it’s his senior year, and he wanted to experience prom together.”

“And it’ll just be him?”

She cringes. “And the rest of them.” She doesn’t have to spell out who *them* refer to.

“Cat!”

“I couldn’t tell him no, he’s my brother!”

I scoff. “A sad excuse for one, if you ask me.”

Her face falls and I’m instantly ashamed that I’ve said something so grotesque. Something I don’t even mean. How is it that we can do that so easily? Say things we don’t mean? “Why would you say that?” she whispers.

“I don’t know.” I swallow. “I think I wanted to hurt you.”

“Well, congratulations. You’ve succeeded. How does it feel?”

“Terrible. Like, so terrible, I think I could actually vomit right here, right now.”

“Maybe don’t do that,” she sighs. “I don’t have the energy to hold back your hair.”

“I’m sorry.”

Cat links her arm with mine, and I release a breath of relief. “I don’t like you very much right now.”

I hang my head. “I know.”

“But I still love you.”

“I know.”

I’m still wallowing in guilt when Brandon comes over that night. I think about Cat the entire time we make out, and as if he can sense something amiss, he asks, “Are you thinking about someone else right now?”

“Cat.” I frown.

He rolls over onto his back. “Usually that would be an extreme turn-on, but unfortunately, I don’t think I stand a chance against her.”

I smack his arm. “Shut up.”

He laughs, sitting up. “I have something for you.”

I scoot to the headboard of my bed and cross my legs as he pulls something small from his pocket. The little square box is a rich green velvet and has a red silk ribbon tied around it in a perfect bow.

“What is it?” I say, reaching for the box and he smacks my hand away. I fake a pout.

He pulls the small gold band from the inner cushion. “It’s called a promise ring.”

Setting my hand in his lap, he slips it onto my ring finger. I look closer and the band looks as if it’s made of woven branches. A small garnet stone lies at its center.

Noticing my confusion, Brandon says, “It’s my birthstone.”

“I know. How... sweet.”

“I just figure with how serious things are getting, it’s nice for you to have

something to represent that. To show people that you belong to me.”

“We need a ring to say all that?”

He clenches his jaw. “It’s supposed to be romantic, Mara. If you don’t like it, I can return it.”

“No, no,” I rush. “I love it. I swear. But... what exactly are you promising?”

He doesn’t hesitate. “That it’s me and you forever. That no one will ever love you as much as I do.”

I can’t decide if that’s romantic or not. It’s unsettling—the idea that no one will ever love me as much as Brandon. In fact, I think it sounds like the most depressing thing in the world but despite the warning bells in my ears, I twist the ring around my finger and lean into him.

“I love it. I love you. Thank you,” I whisper, kissing him deeply.

We settle back onto my pillows and begin discussing which movie to watch.

“Hey.” I nudge his side. “Why didn’t you use my birthstone?”

“Because I don’t know it.” He laughs as if it’s a stupid question.

And I laugh along with him, ignoring the little voice in my head telling me that there’s nothing even remotely funny about that.

We wait in line to retrieve the wristbands that permit us access to the ballroom. Brandon’s next to me, a pocket mirror in front of his face, examining himself for any last-minute flaws. His reaction to my dress was exactly what I’d hoped for and he barely kept his hands to himself the entire ride over.

The low-cut, slinky black dress is so far removed from what I’d usually choose for myself that I decided to make the rest of my appearance match. The hair that drapes over my shoulder is pin straight, coal liner rims my

eyes and my lips are a deadly shade of red. The bottom of the lipstick tube literally said “Dead Red.”

I haven’t heard from Cat since the store incident and anxiety chews away at my stomach. She told me she was going to get a ride with Ambrose and while I want to search for her and apologize again, I don’t want to put a damper on her prom experience.

We reach the front of the line where teachers are cross-checking tickets.

“Name?” Mr. Moynihan asks.

“Mara Makinen.”

He glances up at me again. “Miss Makinen. I hardly recognized you.”

I grimace. “Thank you?”

He hands me a wristband and crosses my name off the list. Brandon returns to my side, draping his arm over my shoulder. “Ready, milady?”

“Yep.”

As if he knows my history with school dances, Mr. Moynihan gives me a sympathetic look, twirling a familiar string on his finger. “Good luck in there.”

As soon as we get inside, I’m blown away by the opulence. Our school is by no means made of money, but there’s a rumor going around that a mysterious senior’s father made a generous “donation” for their child’s last prom. Everyone knows the senior is Brandon and “donation” is an understatement.

The red spotlights and velvet furniture give the ballroom a sultry vibe. Real billiard tables are scattered throughout the room and students gather at the tables lining the center, playing rounds of blackjack and craps.

Brandon squeezes my hand and leads us to a small table off to the side to find our dining seat assignments.

“Mara Makinen and Brandon Lang.”

A young girl with glasses scans the roster without saying a word.

Her voice is near silent when she says, “Table twelve.”

We glance at the linen-lined table that’s already occupied. Cat’s shoulders shake with laughter at something Maitland’s saying in her ear and the growing crowd forces us to move in their direction.

We slip into our assigned seats, pulling the attention of everyone else present. Shayla Marks simultaneously watches me and whispers in Jackson Healey’s ear—something that has him biting his lip and I cringe. Directly to their left, Ambrose studies me. His eyes take me in from head to toe and he frowns. Sasha’s glare bounces between me and Brandon, venom infused in her eyes. Cat sits next to me but she’s quiet as Maitland and I exchange polite ‘hellos.’

I’m pretty sure I had a nightmare once that went exactly like this.

I tap Cat’s hand with my finger. “You look amazing.” I smile.

She smiles back but it doesn’t reach her eyes. “Thanks, Mar. You too.”

She’s forgiven me but she still feels the effects of my words. Cat has a habit of forgiving people before she’s ready to forgive them because her heart is that big. She cares more about making sure you feel forgiven than giving herself the time to process and move on from the pain. What she doesn’t realize is that this feels worse than if she were just to be angry at me outright.

I clear my throat. “Cat, can we talk in private?”

“Mait, grab a bite with me?” she says, taking Maitland’s hand, escaping to the buffet table.

I slump in my chair and begin fumbling with the napkin in my lap.

When Cat returns ten minutes later, I throw myself into the line of fire again. “Hey, Cat?”

“Maitland, do you want to dance?” Maitland looks at me with pure pity

in his eyes before nodding to Cat. They leave the table without looking back.

Brandon returns to the table, dropping a bread roll onto my plate.

“Oh. I asked for two,” I say.

He spears his fork into his salad. “You already ate two. Trust me, I’m doing you a favor.”

Sasha laughs from across the table and my face burns with humiliation.

“I’m bored,” Ambrose drawls. “Let’s go dance.” He hooks his arm around Sasha’s waist, leading her around us. As his body brushes behind my chair, he drops an untouched bread roll onto my plate without anyone noticing. I glance up but he’s already halfway to the dance floor.

Brandon leans in and whispers in my ear, “Meet me in the lobby in five minutes.”

I don’t really want to, but it’s not like I have many options at my disposal here. When I find him waiting by the elevators, he smiles a smile that makes me think that maybe the others he’s given me over the last two years were half-assed. “Look what I have,” he sings, dangling something in my face.

“What is that?”

“It’s our room key. I booked us a room here so we could dip out early and have some alone time.”

Oh.

Bile threatens to claw its way up my throat and it surprises me how quickly my body says no to something my mind said yes to for weeks. “Right now? But there’s so much dance left.”

“Dance?” He laughs. “Forget about the dance, you hate dances.”

“No, I don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Hate dances. I don’t like them, but I don’t *hate* them.”

“Okay,” he says, growing irritated. “You don’t like dances but you don’t hate them. Whatever. Let’s go.” He reaches for my hand but I pull away.

“I don’t... maybe we should rain check.” My eyes naively scan the room for Cat.

Brandon laughs but when he realizes I’m not joking, his voice hardens. “You’re kidding me. Mara, you promised me.”

I jerk my head back. “I didn’t *promise* anything.”

“You did, you promised!”

“When exactly did I *promise* to have sex with you, Brandon?”

“*This*,” he growls, shaking my hand with the ring he gifted me. “This is your promise.”

“*What?*” I sputter. “You said—you said this ring meant—”

“Forget what I said! Come on, you’re not stupid. No guy spends that much money on a girl and doesn’t expect anything in return.”

My jaw drops and Brandon has the audacity to look like I’m the one who’s blindsided *him*.

It’s amazing how quickly things can change. One moment I’m a girl named Mara Makinen who loves a boy named Brandon Lang and the next moment I’m not. One moment, I look at him with love and adoration and the next, he’s the ugliest thing I’ve ever seen.

I don’t feel sad or heartbroken or even mad really. A part of me feels slightly bitter that I’ve given him two years of my life but what I mostly feel is an overwhelming sense of relief.

I think this is what people call an epiphany.

I twist the ring off my finger and slip it into his hand as he gapes at me.

“Thank you, Brandon.” I laugh. “*Thank you.*”

I’m already looking for Cat when my phone *pings* with a text from her.

SOS. Meet me by Ambrose's car.

The last time I received an SOS text from Cat was in the sixth grade when she started her period for the first time at school, which is why I slip off my heels and run barefoot into the parking lot.

I stop at Ambrose's car, looking in every direction for her. When I hear footsteps running up behind me, I turn to find Ambrose bent at the waist, trying to catch his breath.

"Where is she?" he asks.

"I don't know. She texted you too?"

He nods.

"I'm right here." Cat shoots her hand up, coming out from behind a minivan.

I rush to her side. "Cat, what's wrong? Are you okay?"

"I'm fine." She holds her hand up, stopping me from coming any closer. "But we," she says, pointing between the three of us. "We are not fine."

"What are you talking about, Cat?" Ambrose asks.

She crosses her arms. "We sat not a foot away from each other in that ballroom and yet you'd think we were separated by *oceans*. This has gone on long enough. I don't know when this friendship between the three of us got so complicated, but that ends *right now*."

Ambrose laughs. "You've got to be kidding me, you used SOS for this?"

"Shut up, Ambrose!" Cat yells. Ambrose clamps his mouth shut.

"You're both coming with me," she says, pulling Ambrose's keys from her clutch.

Ambrose's eyes bulge, patting his pockets. "How the hell did you—"

"And if you *don't*," she cuts him off. "I will never forgive the two of you."

As if that leaves us much of a choice. Ambrose and I bite our tongues

and slip into the car while Cat drives us to a location she refuses to disclose.

And when the car slows over the crunch of gravel twenty minutes later, Ambrose is the first to speak. “I can’t believe you parent trapped us,” he grumbles.

I snort. “I can.”

“Quiet, both of you. Mara, Ambrose keeps an obscene number of T-shirts in the back. Grab two.”

“What? Why?”

She slips out of the car only to duck her head back in. “We’re going swimming.”

Treading water in Lake Bonnie in nothing but one of Ambrose’s oversized T-shirts is the last thing I thought I’d be doing on my prom night. But here I am. Here *we* are.

“So what now,” I ask, splashing Cat.

I can tell she wants to laugh but she keeps her face stoic for show. “We need to backtrack our history. Figure out where it all went wrong.”

“I don’t think I can tread water that long,” Ambrose says. Cat splashes him and when he chokes on the water we all laugh.

“Cat,” I say, softening my voice. “People grow apart. It’s just life.”

She shakes her head. “No. See, I don’t accept that. Because I love Maitland, but us three? We’re soul mates.”

I dip my head back in the water and release a sigh. “What would you have us do?”

“A restart.”

“A restart?” Ambrose laughs. “This isn’t a video game, Kitty Cat.”

She pins him with a glare and he stops laughing. She repeats herself, firmer this time. “A restart.”

I give her a weak smile. “You know you don’t have to convince me, but this one?” I point at Ambrose. “You’ll never get him—”

“I’m down,” Ambrose says.

Cat and I say, “What?” at the same time.

“You want a restart. I could use one. Leave all the old shit behind. Let’s do it.”

I narrow my eyes, studying him but I can’t find anything in his expression that says he’s playing us.

Cat thrashes in excitement and we cover our faces to block the water flying everywhere.

“Let’s shake on it,” she says. Ambrose and I take hold of her hand. She rolls her eyes. “Grab each other’s hand, you two.”

I mentally prepare myself for whatever excuse Ambrose is about to spout but his warm hand interlocks with mine in the water.

He holds my gaze and my throat constricts. “Restart.” He nods.

I take it with a grain of salt but allow myself to give him a small smile. “Restart.”

Cat sighs in satisfaction. “Now that that’s settled, Ambrose, stop tickling my foot,” she chides.

“I’m not tickling your foot, genius. You both are holding my hands.”

Cat and I stare at each other, our eyes widening in fear. Cat’s scream is piercing and soon Ambrose and I join her. We kick our way back to shore, laughing and screaming, and for the first time in a long time, our laughter is a chorus that binds us together in the quiet night.

Something big has shifted between Ambrose and me. It isn't cataclysmic or in your face. It's steady and subtle—a mixture bubbling in a beaker on low heat. When I wake up the morning after the incident with Jason, Ambrose is long gone. I'm not offended. I didn't expect him to stay and make me breakfast even though a small, traitorous part of me wouldn't have hated that.

I strip the sheets that now smell of him and a folded piece of scrap paper floats to the floor.

Had to leave early to drop Matty off at school. Text me if you need anything. Did you know you snore?

I gasp. "I don't snore."

At the sound of my voice, my cracked door swings open and Otso barrels straight for my midsection. Tackling me onto the bed, I let him shower me—literally shower me, thanks to the excess saliva—with kisses. I still feel bad for forcing him back in the closet before I knew it was Jason who broke in. But I love the large beast now and the thought of him getting hurt pains me.

"Hi, boy," I coo, burying my face in his fur. "I'm okay. We're all okay."

Laura knocks lightly on the door even though it's wide open. "I don't mean to be a bother, I just wanted to check on you."

Laura insisted on coming over last night, but I refused her offer when she mentioned she had Matty staying over at her place. Something about Anya dropping him off in a hurry. I didn't want Matty to be pulled from another bed, so I told her I was fine.

Laura was supposed to be with my dad last night, but when she couldn't

make it, she called in a replacement last minute. The replacement's car broke down and she didn't have a signal to notify Laura, which is why the house was empty when I came home. It was the perfect storm.

"I'm as okay as can be." I smile.

"I owe you a huge apology, Mara."

I put up my hand to stop her. "Laura. In no universe should you take any scrap of responsibility for what happened last night."

She wrings her hands together. "But Anya's my sister and he's her ex-boyfriend. I should have—"

"Stop. Seriously. I won't let you assume any of his blame."

When Laura sees the determination on my face, she nods her head in defeat. She doesn't move from my door and I take a closer look at her appearance. Laura's always had a sort of effortless grace about her, but right now she looks bone deep tired. Her soft eyes are rimmed red and the creases on her face deepen under her solemn expression.

"Is there something else bothering you, Laura?"

She looks up at my ceiling, contemplating whether to confide in me. The breath she releases is weary. "It's Matty. His birthday is tomorrow. Anya told me she was reserving the Blade Arcade in the town over, but when I called them today to confirm, they said a reservation had never been set. Matty's already invited all his friends from the Big Brother and Big Sister program. I don't know what I'm going to tell him and Anya's not answering my calls."

I cringe inward. If there's one thing little kids are brutally judgmental about, it's other kids' birthday parties. "What if we have it here?"

"Here as in... your home?"

"Yes! Our backyard is massive, and Ambrose installed a new grill to impress that swanky real estate agent. We have a tree house. We can come

up with some games. I'm not the best cook, but I'm pretty sure seven-year-olds live off pizza and cake."

"I can't possibly ask that of you."

"You didn't ask. I offered." She looks skeptical. "Besides, this house could do with some giggling kids running around. A bit more *life*." I smile wide, hoping it convinces her to accept my offer.

She relents. "Okay. Let's do it. Thank you, Mara!" She runs forward to kiss my cheek. "I'll run out and get decorations today. Maybe now I can finally make use of my *Pinterest* DIY board."

She calls Otso to leave, thanking me three more times before closing my door. I brush my teeth and shower, surprisingly invigorated for the new day. As I go downstairs, I stop in front of my dad's door. Taking a deep breath, I let myself in and kick off my shoes, sliding into the empty space on his bed.

"Hey Dad," I whisper. "I thought we could have a little father-daughter date after last night's... adventure. I hope I didn't catch you at a bad time." I laugh to myself. If he was conscious, he'd find my joke funny. I prop my phone on my knee, clicking on the app of my favorite streaming site. As *Princess Bride* begins to play, I lean back into the free space on his pillow.

"This is a special book," I say, reciting the words from the opening scene. "It was the book my father used to read to me when I was sick and I used to read it to your father. And today, I'm gonna read it to you."

My dad's eyes stay closed, but his expression is soft. Peaceful. The remaining patches of golden hair on his scalp have become dull and brittle. I lean down close to his ear. "Don't worry, Dad," I whisper. "You still give Wesley a run for his money."

When Laura said she was going to decorate for the party herself, I thought it would consist of a few balloons here and there. Maybe a handcrafted banner

if she was feeling wild. But the house I come back to this afternoon after picking up food and drinks is not the same house I left.

The entire backyard is decked out with streamers hanging from the trees, barrels filled to the brim to bob for apples, and multiple piñatas hanging from Old Maple. The theme... well I can't tell what the theme is. It looks like Party City threw up in my backyard.

"I know what you're thinking." Laura takes the chips from my hand and dumps them into serving bowls. "I didn't know what theme he'd like best so I just went with all of them."

Ambrose walks over and drops a kiss on the top of Laura's head. "Are you kidding? I wish you were my aunt."

Ambrose always looks good in that not-trying-to-be-hot, hot kind of way and today is no different. His jet-black hair is wet and tousled like he just got out of the shower, and he wears an olive sweater that complements the green of his eyes. I try and fail to avoid staring at the jeans that perfectly hug his ass.

You're at a seven-year-old's birthday party, stop mentally undressing the guests.

I exhale my sexual frustrations. "I agree, Laura. It's amazing. Matty's going to freak out."

And Matty does, in fact, freak out. As it turns out, having a party with multiple, unrelated themes is perfect for children who have the attention span of a goldfish. I can't help smiling every time a kid tells Matty that it's the best birthday party they've ever been to.

Ambrose makes his rounds with the parents and program volunteers and I have a hard time not thinking about the kiss last night. Can it even be considered a kiss if it wasn't on my lips? Yes. I'm telling myself yes. We haven't talked about last night and I'm not sure Ambrose even wants to. I'm

glad he's not acting awkward around me today, but a small part of me wonders if that means last night doesn't mean as much to him as it does to me.

"Why so serious? You do know you're at a party, right?" Ambrose hands me a cup of punch.

I make a face. "Ha. Ha."

He lifts a finger to the scabbed-over cut on my head. "How are you doing? Last night was a lot."

Does he mean Jason or the kiss? Dammit, I hate that I don't know which one he's referring to. I might as well find a flower and start plucking its petals. *He loves me, he loves me not.*

"Jason..." he continues.

"Right. Yeah, I'm fine. A little shaken up, but I'm good. I'm just glad he's behind bars and can't mess with anyone anymore. Especially Anya and Matty."

Speaking of Anya, she's nowhere to be found. Laura spent the entire morning calling her, begging her to stop by for Matty's party. When I heard Matty asking Laura in the kitchen if his mom was coming, she told him Anya was away finding him a gift so amazing, it'll make him pee his pants. He giggled, accepting her response without question and it made my heart crumble into a bunch of pieces on the floor.

The sounds of children's laughter hug the space around my house as the afternoon carries on and I hope that the joy and love around us find its way to my dad's little corner of the house. I hope it makes an appearance in his dreams, comforting him.

The party mellows out an hour later and the backyard's attendance cuts down to half—only a few of Matty's friends and their parents remain. The adults are content, sipping on beers and having casual conversations while

the kids role-play kings and knights around Old Maple.

Ambrose is the only adult completely immersed with the children, pretending to beg for mercy when one of the “knights” challenges him to a duel. I walk over and stand beside a little girl whose name is Alecia.

“And who are you playing?” I ask.

Before she can answer, a boy with a buzz cut pipes in. “She’s the narrator. We already have enough kings and girls can’t be knights.”

I put my hands on my hips. “Oh, is that so? Well, in that case, I think it only makes sense that she be made commander.”

Ambrose grins at me from the side but holds his tongue as I continue. “All persons of the military have to report to someone.”

Alecia looks unsure as she twirls her braid around her finger. “But can a girl be a commander?”

“Yes.” I drop to my knees in front of her, bringing our eye levels together. “Have you ever heard of Joan of Arc?”

She shakes her head.

“She was a woman who led an entire military to victory in France. And she was only eighteen.”

Alecia’s face brightens and I continue. “There will always be knights and soldiers and infantrymen. But they will *always* need someone to lead them.”

Alecia turns toward the group of boys, puffing up her chest beneath her pink tulle dress. “You heard her boys. I’m the commander. I want everyone in a straight line, *now*,” she commands, pointing in front of her.

Ambrose and I slowly back away as the boys follow her orders without hesitation and fall into line. She gifts me the sweetest of smiles before turning her newfound conviction on the knights before her.

“I think we’ve just witnessed her villain origin story.” Ambrose nudges me in the side. I swat his arm away with a smirk.

“An honor, if you ask me,” I say, pushing my glasses farther up the bridge of my nose.

“I didn’t know you wore glasses now.”

Alecia’s shouting orders from the top of the tree house and I laugh. “What? Oh. Yeah. I guess years in front of a computer screen have finally caught up with me.” I usually wear contacts but I found Otso eating the contents of my contacts case yesterday. I spent thirty minutes on the phone with the veterinarian making sure he wouldn’t die right there at my feet.

He smirks, walking backward toward the other guests. “You look good in them.”

I shudder.

Dear Lord, give me strength.

We’re picking at the remaining snacks on the buffet table when we hear a loud crash. Anya hovers near the group of parents lounging in Adirondack chairs, a broken beer bottle at her feet and Ambrose and I rush over.

I grab an empty trash bag nearby. “Anya, are you okay? Don’t move, I’ll grab a broom for the glass.”

She looks up and I can’t stop the gasp that escapes my mouth. She looks *awful*. Her eyes are so bloodshot, the whites of them are almost nonexistent. Her hair hangs limply over her shoulders, so greasy it’s obvious she hasn’t washed it in days. Her body is slumped and her pupils are so small they make her look like a deer caught in headlights.

She sways toward me, flip-flops crunching over the broken glass. “You wiggle your way back into Ambrose’s life and now you think you can have my *boy*?” Even her flush of anger seems to exhaust her.

“Anya,” Ambrose warns.

The parents surrounding us watch in silence and, I’m sure, horror.

“Anya. Let’s go inside and get you cleaned up. We can talk there,” I say

gently, moving closer.

She stomps her foot down, and glass pierces her shoe. Blood begins seeping over her sandal, but she doesn't seem to notice. "I'm not going anywhere with you, bitch. You've taken everything from me. *Everyone*."

Before I can ask what she's referring to, she says, "Jason *loved* me. We had issues, but he loved me and now he's gone because of you. Because you couldn't mind your own damn business."

Shit.

"You deserve better than him."

Her laugh is pained. "And Ambrose deserves better than *you*. You're the reason she's not here anymore. You do know that, right?"

"That's enough." Ambrose's back straightens.

Anya turns to the silent group of parents around her, as if suddenly realizing their presence. "Did any of you know Catherine King? Do you know what happened to her? Mara can tell you."

"That's *enough*," Ambrose growls.

The smell hits me. A pungent aroma of ammonia wafts around my nose and I look down. A spot on Anya's white jeans is growing larger by the second. She's urinating herself.

"Mommy?" Matty's staring at his mom with a mixture of fear and confusion in his eyes.

My heart breaks. "Anya," I whisper, moving forward quickly to cover her front side with the trash bag.

What happens next is a blur.

I can only assume from the burn in my eyes that Anya's thrown a nearby cup of alcohol at my face. As I stumble backward, the adults around us unfreeze from their positions, their voices erupting in a frenzy. Arms carry me away and Anya's screams of protest get quieter as I'm led to the kitchen

sink. I flush my eyes out with cold water and when my vision clears, I thank Mrs. Sanchez, who I only met this afternoon, for helping me.

“Está loco como una cabra,” she mutters.

“Don’t say that.” I frown. “Thank you for your help, but don’t say that.” She throws her hands up and shrugs. Anya’s not crazy. She’s sick. Drugs make people a shell of their true selves and they need more of our empathy and less of our judgment. When I finally return outside, everyone has already left except Laura and Mrs. Sanchez’s son. I apologize to her for how the party ended and she tells me not to worry about it, leading her son to their car.

“Where’s Anya?”

Laura’s eyes are glassy. She’s been crying. “Ambrose took her and Matty home. She slammed the door in his face and refuses to let either of us in. Ambrose is going to see her dealer. He thinks she may be on something new.”

Exhaustion hits me with full force and I rub my eyes.

“I’m so sorry, Mara. So sorry.”

I do the only thing I think is appropriate for a moment like this. I hug her. “Me too.”

Sleep evades me that night.

I toss and turn in bed, jumping out toward the window every time headlights passed by. Ambrose still isn’t home yet and a bundle of nerves in my stomach keeps me on edge. How long does it take to talk to a drug dealer? I didn’t even really want to think about Ambrose having to confront someone like that. I’m staring at the blue house, willing his car to appear in the driveway when I see a faint trail of smoke emanating from the house next door. Anya’s house.

I squint, sure my eyes are deceiving me, but it’s real. Smoke is coming

from the downstairs window. When I don't see any lights in the house turn on, I dress quickly, tripping over my sneakers midrun toward the door. Otso's barks echo throughout the house on my way out. I sprint across the street, baffled at how quiet Winsome Lane is. But the calmest part of any hurricane is the eye. You could be in the midst of impending destruction and no one around you would even know it.

I hurry to the front door and stop myself before grabbing the doorknob. I lightly tap the back of my hand against the handle, reeling back at its heat. I can't go through the front door. I take a survey of my surroundings.

The trellis.

Rushing to the side of the house, I stop in front of the ivy-covered trellis. It spans up the length of the house, ending at the balcony of Matty's room. Without a second thought, I begin to climb.

I thank my Pilates classes for the strength my thighs have to carry me upward. I haven't climbed a trellis since I was a teenager and even then I'd only climbed my own. When I get to the balcony, I peer through the window, shocked at the lack of movement inside. Is anyone even home?

Not wanting to risk it, I pull off my hoodie and wrap it securely around my elbow. I take a deep breath and brace myself before breaking the glass. My hand unlocks the door from the inside and I hiss at the sting of shards cutting into my skin.

Matty and Anya are curled up together in his bed. The picture of peace.

I shake Anya hard. "Anya. Wake up. There's a fire."

"Mmm," she groans, pulling the sheets higher over her face.

I can't waste precious time being gentle. "Wake up!" I scream, grabbing the neck of her shirt. She comes to, paranoia clouding over her eyes. Considering she owes people money, I'm sure being shaken awake in the middle of the night is the last thing she wants.

“There’s a fire in your house, Anya,” I repeat.

“Fire?” she mumbles. Understanding floods her eyes. “I left the teakettle on.”

“Come on. Hurry.” I lift Matty into my arms and steer us out onto the balcony.

Anya sways on her feet, not completely sobered up yet and I say, “I’m going to carry him down.”

Matty doesn’t stir when I wrap his legs firmly around my waist. My arms scream in agony as I carry us down the trellis. My leg muscles are monsters, but my upper body strength resembles that of a newborn calf.

I gently lay Matty in the grass and he begins to wake, confusion clouding his eyes. “Don’t move, Matty. I’ll be right back.”

I attempt to climb back up the trellis, but my arms shake with fatigue. “Anya,” I yell. “Can you climb down?”

No response.

I peer above me but can’t see her from my vantage point.

“Fuck.”

I bite the inside of my cheek as I climb back up the trellis, a metallic taste filling my mouth. When I haul myself onto the balcony, Anya’s nowhere to be found.

“Anya!” I step inside. In a matter of minutes, the entire room has filled with smoke. I catch sight of a small body digging through Matty’s dresser.

“What the hell are you doing?” I shout.

“I can’t leave his baby photos. They’re all I have, I can’t leave them!”

I grip her as she stuffs the photos in her bra. The smoke billows around us and I hack into my arm. I grab a shirt from Matty’s drawer and bring it to Anya’s face. I’m worried about how the smoke will affect her with all the drugs currently in her system. She needs to get out.

“Go! I’ll grab the rest of the photos.”

She hesitates as if she might protest, but I shove her toward the balcony. “Climb down the trellis. Matty’s down there, he needs you.”

At the mention of Matty, she nods and runs out. I return to the drawer, seizing the remaining photos. Matty on a merry-go-round. Matty at the beach. Matty and Anya looking happier than ever before. My throat begins to burn and my eyes feel like someone’s taken a hot poker to them. Once I snag the last four-by-six photo, I stumble outside, gasping for fresh oxygen between coughs. Sirens blare below.

Through squinted eyes, I begin my descent. My foot snags between a handful of branches and I plummet the remaining five feet to the ground. I exhale with relief when I see firemen running up the driveway toward the three of us.

I’m curious what it says about me that I’ve experienced two life-threatening situations in a matter of seventy-two hours. It’s the opposite of a lucky streak. I won’t be buying scratch-offs anytime soon. Luckily, the smoke inhalation is minimal and none of us has to go to the hospital.

The EMTs are the same ones from two nights ago and before they leave, they say, “Hopefully we don’t see you again anytime soon.”

I agree wholeheartedly.

When Laura picks up Anya and Matty, she’s tight lipped and stoic. She doesn’t apologize this time and it’s more devastating than when she does. She’s the kind of sad that even words can’t even express.

I’ve just showered the grime and soot off my skin when I hear a banging at the front door. Dashing down the stairs before Otso has a chance to wake my dad again, I swing the door open to find an out-of-breath Ambrose.

“Are you out of your *fucking mind*?” he growls.

“Not any more than usual. Ambrose, what was I supposed to—”

“You have to be the dumbest, stupidest, most—”

“I’m not going to just stand here while you *insult* me. I had to—”

“*Shut up*, Mara!”

I clamp my mouth shut.

Ambrose grabs my shoulders and shakes me, his eyes wild. Terrified.

“Do you know what I would have done if something happened to you?”

My heart splits in two. “Ambrose,” I whisper.

“If I lost you? If I fucking lost *you*, Mara?” His voice cracks. “I wouldn’t survive it. I just got you back.”

I wrap my hands around his wrists. “I know. I’m okay.”

He’s trembling and I rub my hands up and down his arms. “I’m okay.”

His heavy breathing makes the wheeze sounds like a whistle in his chest.

Tiny beads of sweat culminate above his eyebrow.

“Just do it,” I say softly.

He doesn’t move.

“Do it,” I urge.

He reaches into his pocket and brings his inhaler to his lips, keeping his eyes locked on mine as the albuterol expands his lungs. Suddenly, I’m ten years old and I fall in love all over again and I start to smile, but I don’t get to finish because Ambrose’s lips are on mine. His eyes, once filled with hot rage have turned to molten heat as he pushes me back against the wall, the door closing with a soft *click* behind him.

His mouth is hard on mine and I gasp at the delicious pressure. The desperation. Our movements are frantic and impatient as our bodies collide. We’re the perfect fit and it’s as satisfying as setting the last puzzle piece in its place. Because Ambrose kissing me like this? I can finally see the big picture.

Ambrose pulls my body closer, like I’m not already close enough. Like

he wants us to inhabit the same body and breathe as one. He molds me to him like I'm clay and he's the potter. His hands are firm, but not painful as he lifts my arms over my head, caging me in place. His tongue opens the seam of my mouth and I finally let go, allowing a small moan to escape my throat.

"That's my girl," he coos, his voice breathy.

Heat pools at my core as he wraps my legs around his waist and hoists me up with ease. I've seen his hands carry many things. Cinder blocks. Sheets of wood. Boxes of tools. And now they're carrying me. Our jerky movements knock a picture frame off the wall and it crashes on the floor, but we ignore it. Ambrose grunts as I pull his hair, nipping at the skin exposed under his collarbone. He doesn't just smell like mint, he *tastes* like it too.

It's not until his hands graze under my shirt, causing my skin to pebble that I'm pulled to my senses.

"Wait," I breathe. "We can't."

"We can." His mouth consumes mine again and my back arches into him instinctively. Like my body was created for the sole purpose of binding itself to Ambrose King. He tugs my bottom lip between his teeth and I know if I don't stop now, I never will.

I shove him away before he can kiss me again. "We shouldn't do this, Ambrose."

He stops then, rearing his head back a bit to scan my eyes. "Do you want this?"

I don't respond.

"Tell me what you *want*, Mara."

I can't answer him. Because it's not about what I want. It doesn't matter what I want. Not anymore. I no longer allow myself the privilege of

wanting anything.

Ambrose shakes his head and his disheveled hair falls into his eyes. “You can’t do this anymore. You can’t keep punishing yourself.”

When I look away, he closes in on me again. I back up against the wall, wishing I could disappear into it. His eyes swim with rage and passion. Each emotion fighting to be front and center. I envy his ability to let himself feel so deeply.

When he speaks, his minty breath tickles my skin. “I want you, Mara. God, you have no idea how much I want you. How much I’ve wanted you. But I won’t touch you again until you ask me to. When you’re ready to admit what it is that *you* want, you come find me.”

I remain glue to the wall long after Ambrose leaves. It could be five minutes. It could be five hours. Time is an arbitrary concept when you’re in the presence of someone who lays claim to every part of your soul. For the first time in a long time, tears streak down my face as I bend down to retrieve the picture that fell to the floor. I can’t remember the last time I cried and it terrifies me. I’m unraveling. *He’s* unraveling me. I trail my thumb across the dust-covered surface, a clear streak revealing its subjects.

I smile at the picture of Ambrose, Cat, and me. We’re huddled together under a large towel at the lake, floaties at our feet, smiling wide for the camera. It’s from the summer we learned how to do backflips at Lake Bonnie and watched our first *R*-rated movie. We were safe. We were happy. We were together. I clasp my hand over my mouth to muffle the sound of my broken sobs.

Somehow, the wooden frame isn’t broken.

Oh, how I wish I was that frame.

My dad slides the bowl of scalding chicken noodle soup in front of me.

I roll my eyes. “You know I’m not sick.”

It’s senior skip day. The one day every senior in school refuses to show up to classes and instead runs around town, taking part in various shenanigans. It’s considered our last hoorah. The last time we shout our youth from the rooftops before we graduate and become adult citizens in society and are imparted with mass responsibility overnight.

So it’s senior skip day and my dad’s pretending like I’m sick so he can assuage his parental shame of letting me skip school.

“You are sick. Look at you, *princessa*, your hair is dull and your eyes look tired.”

“That’s just how I look, Dad.”

He pushes a glass of OJ and a bottle of cough medicine across the table. “I’m going to leave this here. And then I’m going out for the day to run errands. I’ll probably go straight to sleep when I get home tonight, unable to check on you. Whatever you do, do *not* leave this house,” he says, winking. “And don’t even *think* about sneaking out with your friends, especially to visit the zoo after hours where certain people tend to go on this day every year.” He’s full on smiling now.

“You’re scaring me,” I say, sipping my orange juice.

What I don’t tell him is that I plan on spending the entire day in bed. Senior year looks a lot different than junior year. Brandon and I have been broken up for an entire year. I never spoke to him after what happened at prom and he made no attempts at apologizing. We became strangers just as quickly as we fell in love. Or at least, what I thought was love at the time.

Even though Cat and I are busier than ever, we took that night at Lake Bonnie seriously. And surprisingly, so did Ambrose. I wouldn't say things are exactly like they used to be and I haven't seen him much since he's started college, but when I have seen him, we've managed to exchange words without exposing our claws.

I shuffle through the college brochures Cat dropped off yesterday and a buzz of excitement runs through me. We're still committed to moving to the city together after graduation. When Cat texted me this morning asking if I'd changed my mind about tagging along with her and her cheer mates today, I told her I was more than happy taking the day to chill alone. Also, because the idea of taking part in mischief and rule breaking makes me want to vomit.

My dad leaves the house, the giddy smile still plastered to his face. I'm positive he enjoys senior skip day more than I do. I curl up on my bed, Cheddar slinking under my sheets to nip at my toes.

"Ow!" I hiss.

His *meow* apology is insincere. He'll continue to do as he pleases. So typical for a cat. I click on the TV, pushing play on the movie I started this morning. *Ferris Bueller's Day Off*. I thought it was fitting. Halfway through the movie, my eyes become weighed down and I drift off to sleep, Cheddar licking the crumbs of Doritos off my hand.

I jerk awake at the sound of taps on my window. A glance at the clock on my nightstand says it's nine thirty at night. So much for a wild senior skip day.

Tap, Tap, Tap.

The pebbles bounce off the glass and I rub my eyes. Cheddar stares back at me with an expression that says *don't look at me, I'm just a cat*.

I toss a pillow at him. "You're no help."

I slide into my slippers and open my window. Down below is a dark silhouette I can't quite make out. Only when the person pulls down their hood does the curtain of glowing blonde hair give them away.

"What are you doing here?" I whisper-yell.

Cat makes no attempt at being quiet. "I'm rescuing your ass."

I look behind me, expecting my dad to walk through the door, but then I remember he's determined to turn a blind eye tonight. "Am I in distress?"

Cat's tone is sassy when she says, "You're the only person sitting in their pajamas on senior skip day, so I'd say yes."

Is this a pity invite? I told Cat it's fine for us to have other friends, but maybe she didn't believe me. Suspicion keeps me rooted in place. As if she senses my inner dilemma, Cat huffs in exasperation.

"They want to meet you. Seriously. Now hurry up, I'm getting cold."

I refuse to look a gift horse in the mouth. "Be right down."

When I stride up to Cat, she eyes my clothes and snorts. "What are you wearing?"

I point to the all-black ensemble I picked out for the night. "What's wrong with it?"

"Nothing... I just didn't realize a member from *Men in Black* would be joining us tonight."

"Ha. Ha. I just figured I should be incognito if we're to be taking part in questionable activities tonight."

Cat laughs and I relish the sound. It sounds like church bells on a Sunday morning.

She points to the car parked in the street. The music pulsating through the bass causes the car to shake.

"Wait," I say, grabbing her sleeve. "What if... what if they don't like me?"

She shrugs as if the answer's simple. "Then they don't like *us*."

I smile in response and she extends her hand. I grab on tight, the identical scars on our palms melding together.

"Ready, Sally?"

"Ready, Gilly."

Our first stop is the local bar. My anxiety causes my nerves to feel as though someone has taken a Taser to them and I'm sure I look like I'm Cat's hostage.

Cat pinches my butt as we walk toward the bouncer. "Relax."

"Relax?" I scoff. "I'm the only one here who's still seventeen. There's no way he's gonna let me in."

"That's why we got you this," says one of Cat's cheer friends. Her name's Ruby and she's nice. She told me my outfit gives off hot, Catwoman vibes. She hands me the fake ID.

"You're kidding me." The girl in the photo looks nothing like me. She's at least ten years my senior and her hair is red while mine is brown. "This lady," I say, squinting in the dark, "Holly Gutierrez doesn't even look like she could be my *cousin*."

Ruby yanks down her blouse to expose the lacy bra beneath and winks. "The bouncer won't pay too close attention. Trust me, his eyes will be drawn elsewhere."

The other two girls, Candice and Marie, nod as if they've done this a million times. As we get closer in the line, Cat whispers into my ear. "Mara, if you don't want to do this, we can leave."

I hate the idea of making Cat leave on my account. She always goes out of her way to make sure I'm comfortable. But what I'm realizing is that sometimes, comfort holds you back. Sure, most of the time it feels warm

and fuzzy like a hand-knitted sweater. But eventually, we grow out of that sweater. And we need something bigger to fit the new person we're supposed to become.

I remove my black jacket so all I'm left with is the black camisole that hugs my skin in all the right places. The girls hoot as I shake my wild curls out from its updo and Cat grins.

I fan my face with the ID, faking the confidence until it feels real and smile at Cat. "It's Holly tonight." The girls holler in unison.

I have more fun at Duffy's than I expected. For the first time in my life, I feel free. Like I've broken off the chains of always second-guessing myself. It's liberating. And even though we all sport Xs on our hands, notifying every bartender that we're too young to drink, we're our most uninhibited selves on the dance floor.

It's '80s throwbacks night and we jump in a circle together, belting the lyrics to Journey's "Don't Stop Believin'." We ignore every advance from the men who try to insert themselves into our little pod, telling each other to shout, "It's girls' night" in their faces when they approach. I laugh so hard, soda flies out my nose more than once. And then I laugh some more.

We're still howling over the man who looked at us in utter confusion when Cat rejected him in pig Latin when we pull into the parking lot of the zoo. A handful of cars are already parked, telling us a ton of seniors have already snuck in. It's close to midnight as we skip toward the entrance, arms looped with one another's, and enter through a door a fellow senior holds open. Marco Riley works at the zoo and is charging every senior five dollars for letting them in the easy way. Candice says the hard way includes sneaking in through the floor where they store the dead fish for shows. I much prefer Marco's way.

We hand him our money and head inside. We're on our second round of

flip cup near the Mouse Manor exhibit when Ambrose walks in with a few of his friends and my heart gives out.

I lean into Cat. “What’s your brother doing here?”

She shrugs. She must not have known he’d be here. “No clue. Maybe he wants a little pregame fun before his birthday party tomorrow.”

Ambrose is only a year older than us, but somehow college makes him seem years ahead. The once raging storm in his eyes has sputtered out into a gentle crash against the rocks. Being away from home has implanted a certain calmness into his step. Sasha is absent from his side, but I don’t get my hopes up. I know they’re still dating. It’s one of the facts I wish I didn’t know.

I didn’t forget it’s Ambrose’s birthday tomorrow. I’d never forget. But I can’t understand why he’d rather spend it back in Speck Lake than with his new college friends from his bigger college town.

Cat snaps her fingers in front of my face. “Do you need a napkin? You’re drooling on me.”

I swat her and she giggles. “I am not.”

Hearing his sister’s laugh, Ambrose starts making his way toward us. I pretend to be oblivious, suddenly intrigued by the red Solo cup in my hand.

“Hey, Mouse.”

I turn around. “Oh, hi!” I smile and I fail to sound casual.

“What am I?” Cat interjects. “Chopped liver?”

Ambrose slings an arm over her shoulder and plops a loud kiss on her head before giving her a noogie.

“Cut it out!” Her laughter is a mixture of annoyance and love. She returns to the game, leaving me and Ambrose alone.

I search for something to say. “How’s school?”

“Good. A bit of a transition, but I think I’ve got the hang of things for

sophomore year.”

The hand holding my cup shakes so bad, liquid sloshes out the sides, wetting my shoe.

Ambrose gently tugs the drink away from me, downing what was left and I swallow at the sight of his sharp jaw on my cup. “Um. Happy early birthday.”

“Thanks. Are you going to be at the party tomorrow?”

“Do you want me to be?”

He pretends to think about it and I swat his arm. He laughs. “Yeah, I do.”

I haven’t been invited to any of Ambrose’s birthday parties since I was twelve and so I’m not sure what to do with this moment.

“Okay.” I grin. “Then, I’ll be there.”

His friends call out to him, announcing they’re ready to leave. He grabs my hand and rubs my palm with his thumb. The thought of Cat seeing us mortifies me, but I don’t dare move. I couldn’t even if I wanted to.

“See you then, Mouse.”

The nickname doesn’t sound so harsh then. It’s the first time he’s said it where it makes my pulse quicken in anticipation.

He leaves and I return my attention to the game.

“Go for it,” Cat whispers, handing me the little white ball. Her expression is serious, heavy with something I can’t quite make out and a part of me thinks she may not be referring to the game.

Ambrose has more friends at his party than I’ve had in my entire life. Cars are parked bumper to bumper, overflowing from the driveway onto the street and a handful of cars trudge through the front yard. Alima will *not* be happy about that. But I guess you only turn nineteen once.

Watching the people enter, I’m glad I’ve dressed up. I didn’t have time to

buy a new dress, so I'm wearing one that toes the line of *too* short, thanks to a recent growth spurt. Growth spurt, meaning I've grown from five feet to five-four. I'm not going to be recruited to a D1 team anytime soon. I've left my hair down, thankful that my curls are having a good day, and spent a little more time than usual on my makeup.

The small gift box hangs at my side as I push my way through the crowd of people loitering near the door. Music blares from speakers I can't see and couples grind against each other in the den. I try to hunt down Cat but when I can't find her, I go to the kitchen for a drink.

I've just finished pouring soda into my cup when Sasha enters. Her eagle eyes zone in on me immediately and she scoffs. "The night just keeps getting better."

Her voice is heavy from the drinks she's already consumed. Drinks I'm sure weren't of the soda variety. I don't want to cause a scene, so I turn to leave, but she stumbles forward, blocking the doorway. "Where ya goin'?"

"Excuse me, Sasha."

"Excuse me, Sasha," she mocks in a diminutive voice.

I push past her to go anywhere she's not. She stumbles when she runs to catch up with me. "You're such a fucking saint. I'd give you some of my backbone if I could."

I cross my arms over my chest. "I just came to wish Ambrose a happy birthday. I'll leave, okay?"

I continue walking down another hall and she follows me. The volume around pounds against my head and I feel my simmering anger come to a boil. I try to escape before my emotions get the best of me, but when Sasha doesn't give me space, I turn the anger on her, letting it overflow. After all these years, I've finally had enough.

"What the hell is your problem with me?" I yell.

Sasha is momentarily taken aback by my raised voice and the words begin fumbling out of my mouth. “You have shit on me every day for years. *Years*, Sasha. I haven’t done anything to you. All I’ve done is exist. Out of your way, I might add. Don’t you have anything better to do than waste your time hating me? Because I do. I don’t even fucking *think* about you.”

My chest heaves from the adrenaline. I ready myself for her attack, but instead, her face breaks out into a slow grin. She looks... *proud*. She begins slow clapping and I bristle in discomfort.

“It’s about fucking time.” She laughs, throwing back the rest of her drink in a single gulp. “When Ambrose broke up with me, I knew it was because of you, I just didn’t understand why. I knew there had to be someone with a little more *oomph* under all that *nice*.”

“He... what?” Ambrose broke up with Sasha? The news crashes around me.

“I know.” She flips her hair. “He’s obviously lost his mind.”

Sasha makes it clear she’s done talking to me then, when she leaves me there stumped and she makes her way to the den, grabbing a guy by the neck to dance with her.

Ambrose broke up with Sasha because of *me*? A million conflicting emotions fight their way into me. I practically run to the kitchen and clutch the countertop as I catch my breath. I set Ambrose’s gift on the counter, massaging my temples with my hands.

“Mara!” Ambrose waves. I can hardly hear him above the music. He looks amazing and I hate the way my heart surrenders to him without hesitation. Without permission.

His smile is beautiful and it’s the most open his face has ever looked. “You came.”

“Why didn’t you tell me you broke up with Sasha?”

He jerks. “Who told you that?”

“Sasha. She said you broke up with her because of me. What’s she talking about, Ambrose?”

He yells so I can hear him. “Can we go somewhere quieter to talk about this?”

“You kept me at a distance for *years* and now suddenly you’re dumping your girlfriend for me? We’ve just reestablished a friendship—*barely*.”

“You don’t understand.”

“Don’t tell me what I don’t understand. I understand that you used to be one of my best friends in the entire world and then one day that meant nothing to you. I understand that you never even told me why you pushed me away. You *still* haven’t. Your communication skills are shit, Ambrose!” My voice grows raw from the yelling.

He moves closer, reaching for my hand but I pull away before he makes contact. “I know. Please. Let me explain.”

“No,” I say, backing away. “It might be your birthday, but you don’t get to have your cake and eat it too.”

20

NOW

Anya's house sits empty except for the days Ambrose goes over to fix things that were ruined in the fire. Thanks to a neighbor calling the fire department when they did, the damage isn't as bad as it could've been. But even though the flames are gone, their impact is seared into us all.

When Laura asks for a week off because Anya and Matty are moving in with her, I tell her to take two. Hesitation fills her eyes, but I promise her I won't leave my dad's side. The fact that she believes me must mean I'm making some progress.

I spend the days in my dad's room, administering the medications I can, playing movies out loud on my phone as I curl up next to him. He's always been a big man and despite his state, his stature still has the ability to make me feel safe. Secure. And I'm no longer bothered by the whine of the oxygen machine. Instead, it's become a familiar presence. I welcome it every day and the message it seems to whisper into my ears. *Listen to me breathe for him. He's still here.*

Otso claims a permanent residence at the foot of my dad's bed and I try not to let it stoke the embers of my anxiety. I read once that dogs know when someone is about to move on from this world to the next. They become more affectionate and clingier, knowing their human's time is almost at its end.

As I let the movie play, I drag my laptop onto the bed. When I submitted my sick day request the day after the fire, Helen called me not five minutes after. I haven't taken a sick day since I started working for the company, so when she asked if hell had frozen over, I wasn't surprised.

We chatted for a bit and I updated her on my dad's health. "You've been

there for almost two months now,” she said, nervousness lacing her voice.

“Yep.”

“You’ve done the agency a great service, working as hard as you’ve had remotely, but take the next two weeks off. Spend this time with your father.”

When I told her that wasn’t necessary, she became adamant. “I wasn’t asking you, Mara. Take the next two weeks off.” And she hung up.

Has everyone and Otso been provided with a countdown I’m unaware of? I don’t know how to gauge how much time my dad has left, but my heart tells me we still have time. I don’t know how I know; I just do.

When the dog in the film starts barking, I plug my ears, expecting Otso to dive into a fit of barks like he usually does at... well everything. But when we make eye contact, he looks solemn.

I scratch his ear. “What is it, boy?”

He lets out a low whine and nuzzles his face into my dad’s leg.

My heart constricts. “Don’t worry. He’s not going anywhere. Not yet.”

Am I trying to convince him or myself?

When Laura calls and asks me to bring her medical bag by her house, I don’t hesitate. I ask Mrs. Kline down the street to watch over my dad for a few hours and she’s more than happy to lend a hand. I’ve known Mrs. Kline since I was a little girl, but she’s always kept to herself. She isn’t unfriendly, just shy. She has a banana tree in her front yard and always used to offer me one when she caught me staring. She wouldn’t even say anything, she’d just point to the tree. I eventually took it as a hint to help myself. I appreciated that she never expected too many words from me.

Laura’s house looks like something out of *Lake Living*. The small cottage sits on the lake in the middle of cherry blossom trees and I remember Laura

saying how her parents planted them before her mom passed. They aren't in season and the naked branches stick out in misshapen angles like characters from a Tim Burton film but this is their home. The place where Laura and Anya grew big. Loved big. And lost big.

I knock on the door and it opens almost immediately. Matty's dressed in a pair of dinosaur pajamas, his hair an absolute disaster.

"Hey, cutie. Just wake up?"

His eyes shift to the ground. "No. All my clothes are at home. Auntie Laura says she has to buy me new ones because they got burned."

Dammit. Why didn't I think about that before I opened my big stupid mouth?

"Well, clothes are overrated. I'd rather be in my pajamas like you." I ruffle his hair, but he doesn't smile or laugh like he usually does. It should be a crime to rob this kid of his laughter.

"Are you here to see Auntie Laura?"

"Yes."

"I'll get her." He walks away, shoulders slumped.

Laura comes to the door moments later, pulling me in for a bone-crushing hug.

"Thank you," she breathes.

I pass her the bag and slip my hands into my pockets, not sure what to say next. Thankfully, Laura saves me the trouble. "How's your dad doing?"

"Great! I think. Considering the circumstances." I let out a low laugh. "Otso hasn't left his bed in days."

Laura's face crumples with concern. "Days?"

I shrug. "Yeah, but that's normal, right? I mean, he loves his owner."

"Hmm," is all she says.

I scratch the nonexistent itch on my neck. "Well... I should get going. I

left Mrs. Kline to watch my dad, but I know she doesn't like being away from her house for too long."

Mrs. Kline actually told me to take all the time I need, but me and awkward silences don't mesh well.

Laura nods and looks at me as if she knows something I don't. Before she closes the door, a hand shoots out to catch it.

Anya stands before me. She looks like she's lived a million lifetimes, but still looks better than she did at Matty's party. Without realizing it, I take a step back. I think a part of my subconscious is afraid of getting alcohol thrown in my eyes again.

Laura lifts her hand up in warning. "Anya..."

She ignores her. "Can I talk to you?"

"I don't think that's a good idea," Laura says.

Anya turns on her, annoyed. "I'm not going to throw another drink on her. Besides, all you have in your fridge is water."

Anya looks at me again, the question clear in her eyes.

I nod. "Sure."

We walk to the end of the dock and I look back, hoping Laura's watching us through the window just in case Anya decides to push me off.

Okay, I don't think she'd do that.

Okay, maybe I think her hand would accidentally slip and do the opposite of pull me in for a hug.

She sits, her legs dangling over the edge and I follow suit.

We sit, staring out at the water in front of us. I don't feel like looking at Anya just in case she attempts to kill me with her eyes.

She clears her throat. "I owe you an apology."

My head whips around so fast I'm surprised I don't break my neck.

Her laugh is dry. "I know. Wild, right? Me apologizing. I promise I'm

sober. Today at least”

She’s making a joke. Do I laugh? No. Too soon.

I study her, confused and if I’m being honest, a little suspicious. “Why?”

“Because you saved my boy’s life. Simple as that. We’re even.”

I want to point out to her that I’ve never done anything to her, but I have a strong feeling she’s keeping score of my past. And for that, I can’t blame her.

I nod. “We’re even.”

We sit there for a while, welcoming the breeze that dances through the trees. A white flag may have been raised, but that doesn’t mean the conversation will flow easily.

I play with the key chain in my hand. “Can I ask you a question?”

Her eyes are guarded, but she doesn’t say no.

“Why Jason?”

She takes her time answering. She kicks at a lone branch on the stair and blows out a breath. “Matty had colic as a baby.”

I rear back my head. “Really?”

“Right?” She smiles. “You’d never guess it by the way he is now.” She swallows. “But he would cry and cry for hours. Like he was put on this very earth for the sole purpose of crying. Like he already knew a little something about the cruel world he’d been brought into and he was mad as hell about it. And it scared me because I thought that meant he’d be like me. That he’d feel too much, too far, too wide and way too often.”

I nod, encouraging her to continue.

“The world... the world has always felt a bit too heavy for me. I see things or I hear things and I can’t forget about them like other people can. I think I recognized that same thing in you the first time I saw you. It was in your eyes.”

“What was?”

Her smile is sad. “Everything.”

My throat tightens and something soft covers my knuckles. Anya’s holding my hand. And I’m letting her.

“Anyway, when our mom died... the world got heavier. Suffocating. It weighed on me. But when I had Matty, it was like I saw the world differently. I got clean. I saw the good along with the bad. The joy along with the suffering. It stayed like that for a while but then I started to feel it again. The heaviness. It was so *loud*. And when I met Jason, he said he could help me find the quiet. It lived at the bottom of a glass pipe, but yeah... it was quiet.”

I squeeze her hand and she squeezes mine back.

“I’m an addict, Mara. I know that. I just got a little lost in the quiet I craved so desperately. But the night of the fire...” She shivers. “It was quiet and there were flames screaming all around us. I need to listen to the noise again. I need to feel the heavy. For Matty. I can’t run from it forever.”

I blow out a breath. “I get it.”

“I know you do.”

We chat a little longer before I leave. Anya’s preparing to leave for a rehab program in a few days and I offer to drive Matty to come visit when Ambrose and Laura can’t if I’m still in Speck Lake. We aren’t friends. Not even close. But there’s a unique connection that forms when you love the same people.

For Matty’s sake, I hope Anya will get better.

I’ve been standing in front of Ambrose’s door for five whole minutes contemplating whether to knock or not. Anya’s words bounce around my mind. *I can’t run forever*. It feels like someone’s sucker punched me in the

gut. Anya and I share a common thread. We run. We're runners. Because we're afraid of how heavy the weight of our emotions can be. How all-consuming. I let my mom convince me that those emotions were too much. That something was wrong with me—that I just needed to “toughen up.”

But for the first time in my life, I don't want to toughen up. I want to fall apart and I want to do that in the arms of the person I feel safest with.

Ambrose.

It's this realization that causes me to pound on his door three times.

When Ambrose answers in nothing but a pair of sweatpants riding low on his hips, my blood sizzles and I have to remind myself why I'm here. His eyes are tired, but when they meet mine they spark to life, waiting for me to speak.

“Can I come in?”

He moves just enough to create a small opening for me to slip through. He stares down at me, eyelids heavy and I can't help my audible intake of breath as my body grazes his. *When you're ready to admit what it is you want, you come find me.*

I stalk past the den, past any part of the house that's occupied by furniture. Ambrose and I could become a tangled mess on. I need to keep my mind clear when I speak to him. I can't be distracted thinking about the things he could do to me on the couches and chairs around us. The things I *want* him to do.

I contemplate which room would be a neutral location and make a beeline toward the kitchen. Kitchens aren't sexy.

I prop my hip against the marble counter and Ambrose saunters in slowly, staring at me like I'm not wearing a ratty old Tommy Bahama T-shirt with a coffee stain on it. Something about him is different. Predatory. Like he no longer cares to hide the fact that he wants me. Under the lights

of the kitchen, I can see the planes of his chest more clearly. There isn't any part of me that has inherited my mom's artistic skills, but in this moment I'd kill to paint the man in front of me.

Ambrose lifts his arms, clenching the doorframe above his head and his eyes darken when he says, "Know what you want yet?"

His voice has an edge to it and I'm reminded of when we were younger. Except this time, I want to cut myself on his edge instead of run away from it.

My voice comes out with a tremble. "I... I just—"

He turns away with a grunt. "Go home, Mara."

Anger erupts in my chest. "Don't be an asshole, *give* me a minute!"

His head turns slowly, eyebrows arched in amusement. "You've had seven years."

I shouldn't have come. I've been in his house for five minutes and we're already baring our teeth. This has to be a red flag.

"This was a mistake. I should go."

Ambrose doesn't bother looking surprised. He storms past me and grabs a beer from the fridge. "Go ahead, Mouse. Run away." He lowers his voice a notch. "You should have a fucking endorsement deal from Nike."

"Don't *call* me..."

My eyes catch on something to the left of his head. It's easy to miss, but it's there. Glued to the corner of the fridge door. I stare in awe, shocked that it's still in pristine condition after all these years.

"Where did you get that?" I point.

Ambrose looks confused, but when he follows my gaze he releases a small sigh. I reach my fingers out to touch the stained glass on the magnet.

Ambrose steps closer to the fridge, his expression a mixture of adoration and protectiveness. As if I'm going to take it back or break it into a million

little pieces. “After you left that night, I saw it sitting on the counter. When I opened it, I knew who it was from.”

It’s no bigger than a sand dollar. And it’s just a magnet. But the stained glass makes it look like a relic. I bought it for Ambrose when I visited my mom in Paris and found myself in a tiny bookstore. To anyone else, it might seem like a random gift, but it makes sense to us. The little mouse stares back at me, its eyes made from ruby and azure-colored glass. We were just getting back on good terms again, but I wanted him to have a small piece of me. Even if no one else understood its meaning. Even if the piece of me came in the shape of a small magnet on a fridge.

The lump in my throat is heavy and my eyes well. “You kept it all this time?”

Ambrose gently tugs the stray curl near my ear and his voice is rough when he says, “Of course I kept it. It was all I had left of you.”

I move first this time.

I hurl myself toward Ambrose, savoring the sound of our teeth clashing together. I immediately retract everything I said about kitchens not being sexy. Beer still in hand, Ambrose wraps his free arm around my waist and lifts me onto the counter. I clasp my ankles together behind his back, securing his core tightly against mine and he shudders out a moan.

We cling to each other, our heavy breaths dancing in the air. I rock back and forth, the pulsing sensation coiling tight at my center. I shoot my tongue out toward his but before they can connect, Ambrose draws his head back, hand clasped firmly on my chin. “What do you want?” His voice is gruff and every part of his body is hard against mine.

It’s one word but it means everything. “You.”

The sound of relief that comes from him strikes me like lightning. Ambrose’s mouth lays claim to mine and his movements become

demanding. I feel like a bomb that has lain dormant for years and Ambrose has just pushed the big red button. We're exploding together in the middle of his kitchen and suddenly kitchens are my favorite part of a house.

His beer bottle shatters across the floor as he uses both hands to hoist me into his arms, carrying me toward the stairs. We disregard the mess. Shards of glass lie broken on the floor, but I've never felt so whole in my entire life.

Ambrose lowers me onto his bed and I'm impressed by how quickly he got us to his room with his eyes closed.

He tugs at my shirt. "Lift your arms for me, baby."

I oblige.

Our breathing grows heavier and our hearts beat faster as more articles of clothing gather on the floor. When Ambrose pauses his hands at the hem of my underwear, the question clear in his eyes, I nod—unable to form the words to explain just how much I want him. How much I've always wanted him. He lowers himself on top of me and I push myself flush against him, my head cradled in his palm. He trails his fingers along my rib cage and when they glide against the hard peaks on my chest, I bite down on my lip.

"Ambrose," I beg.

When Ambrose juts his arm out toward his bedside table, I tell him I'm on the pill and he lets me pull him back into my arms. Slowly, as if needing to remember the moment for the rest of our lives, Ambrose inches into me as he trails soft kisses along the slope of my neck. Our movements are a dance we already know the steps to and when the part of me that's been wound tight for seven years finally explodes, I scream out, clawing my nails into his back. Ambrose devours the sound in his mouth, claiming it as his own. And when I grind my hips in a circular motion, his grunts of pleasure follow closely behind.

When we come down from our high, we lie together, a tangled mess of limbs on the bed I've fantasized about since I learned about hormones and puberty. The soft blue of dusk dances through the window as I memorize the shape of Ambrose's closed eyes. His breathing is even and I refuse to change my position even though my foot's falling asleep. I don't want to wake him. I've never seen him look so peaceful.

His phone buzzes on his side table and I scramble off the bed to grab it before it wakes him. I moved my thumb to silence the call, but before I do, my eyes trip up on the name.

Mom.

A sickening wave of bile burns at my throat as I think of Alima. I'm only a finger tap away from the woman who treated me like her own daughter when I was a kid. The woman whose life I've tragically altered forever.

Does she somehow know I'm with Ambrose right now? I've heard stories about a mother's intuition. Mothers who know when there's something wrong with their children. Mothers who know when you're lying. Mothers who know when their kids have sex for the first time. Mothers who just *know*.

My breathing quickens at the idea that Alima knows I'm in bed with her son, and I quickly ignore the call, hoping it severs her omniscient connection to him.

I creep around the edge of the bed, moving like a burglar in the night as I snag my discarded clothes. I dress in record time and as I'm backing out of Ambrose's room, I cast one last glance at him. My body and my heart tell me to get back in the bed. Back into the place I feel whole. But the image of Alima kicking and screaming forces me to close the door behind me without a word.

And the quiet wraps its familiar arms around me.

I'm lost in my thoughts when I walk through the front door, which is why I don't absorb Mrs. Kline's words when she says I have a visitor waiting upstairs before letting herself out.

I toss my keys on my dresser and scream when a guttural voice says, "Give me all your money!"

I swat the light switch, illuminating the person sitting on my bed. Tally's bent at the waist, laughing so hard her face is beet red. "Oh, shit. You should have seen your face." A tear streams down her face before she regains her composure. "Wait... you were almost robbed. Shit, I forgot. Okay, bad joke," she says, her voice apologetic.

"Tally, what the hell are you doing here?"

She leans back on my pillows as if it's completely normal that she's in my bedroom. In my childhood home. In *Maine*. "I missed my best friend."

"How did you even know where I lived?"

She weaves her hands together, a mischievous smile tugging at her mouth and the gesture reminds me of Cat. "I called your dad's nurse, Laura. You left her number on a sticky note on your fridge. I told her who I was and she was *very* accommodating when I said I wanted to surprise my best friend in the entire world."

I cross my arms. "When I gave you a spare key to water my plants and feed Cheddar, I didn't think you'd resort to snooping."

She snorts. "Do you even know me?"

"Wait... who's watching Cheddar?"

Tally's smile is strained.

"Tally, I swear, if Jeremy force-feeds my cat asparagus, I'll kill him."

She's laughing again.

It just doesn't make any sense. Tally hates flying. She once told me she'd rather sit through a root canal than be on an airplane, which is how I know

her visit isn't as casual as she's making it out to be. I narrow my eyes when I ask, "Why are you *really* here?"

All pretenses slide off her face and empathy fills its place. "You've been gone a while, babe. I figured you could use a friend."

Understanding hits me like a ton of bricks. She thinks I need a friend because she knows my dad doesn't have much time left. There's only so much time someone has in hospice. Saving me from talking about him, Tally lets out a dramatic yawn. "Look, I'm beat. The lady next to me on the flight kept me awake with her incessant gum smacking. Can we crash and you can yell at me some more tomorrow?"

I nod slightly before escaping to the bathroom to get ready for bed. When I return, Tally's already asleep, looking more comfortable in my house than I do. I climb in next to her and close my eyes.

As I pray for the sleep I know won't come, I can't help but think about the warm body across the street I still wish I could lie next to.

I'm not jumping over the moon at Tally showing up unannounced while I'm facing an existential crisis, but I can admit that her carefree attitude is a welcome reprieve. I didn't realize how much I missed my best friend. She talks my ear off enough to distract me from the man across the street and the fact that I haven't heard from him since last night after I fled his room like a booty call.

I come downstairs to Tally making blueberry pancakes from scratch and I laugh knowing she isn't getting her fix at home thanks to Jeremy.

I sit at the table, folding my knees up to my chest. "Are you sure you're here for me, or did you just need to go somewhere far enough to eat whatever you want?"

"I'll have you know that I finally stood up to Jeremy," she says, sticking

out her tongue.

“Really? Spill.”

She shrugs, flipping a pancake. “I told him I was my own person with my own food preferences and I don’t want to hide them anymore.”

“Wow. What did he say?”

She turns, setting a plate of pancakes in front of me. “He said the only reason he kept making me eat that shit was because I kept pretending to like it. I gotta say, communication does wonders.”

I gasp sarcastically. “You don’t say.”

“You should try it sometime.”

“Damn. Gut me, why don’t you.”

“I’m just saying, you have a tendency to avoid conflict.” The doorbell rings and before I can protest around the food in my mouth, Tally jumps up. “I’ll get it!”

I glance around, frantically searching for an escape route but leaving the kitchen isn’t an option. I’d have to pass by the front door.

“Look who’s stopped by,” Tally says, walking back into the kitchen. Ambrose trails behind her.

He jerks his chin to the pancakes in front of me. “Morning.”

My mouth is full and my voice comes out as a garbled mess when I say, “Morning.”

Tally gives me a disappointed look of disgust before regarding Ambrose. “Who are you?”

Ambrose drags his eyes away from where I sit and his smile’s friendly as he leans in for a handshake as he says, “I’m Ambrose.”

Recognition fills Tally’s eyes and I want to drag her away before she says something that will make me want to sink farther into my chair. I widen my eyes at her and to my relief, she makes her face unreadable.

“Ambrose. Hmm. I’ve never heard of you.” Her lie is so flawless, even I’m convinced.

Ambrose laughs. “And who are *you*?”

“I’m Mara’s best friend.”

My eyes swing to Ambrose, readying myself for the disappointment in his eyes but there’s nothing but a genuine smile on his face as he looks at me.

“Tally, can I have a minute with Mara?”

I shake my head quickly behind Ambrose’s back.

Don’t leave me. Don’t leave me.

“Sure! I was about to hop in the shower. I still smell like airplane.” She laughs. Tally wiggles her eyebrows at me as she backs out of the kitchen, abandoning me. Best friend, my ass.

Ambrose sits down and grasps the seat of my chair, pulling me closer to him. He takes the fork out of my hand and eats the chunk of pancake on it. “You left last night.”

I swallow. “Yes.” I don’t realize my knee is bobbing under the table until his cool hands bring it to a halt.

“Are we good?”

“Yes,” I repeat.

“Good.” Ambrose uses his thumb to wipe away the syrup on my lip and puts it in his mouth. “So, listen,” he says. “I’m going out of town this weekend. I want you to come with me.”

Despite my internal battle, curiosity gets the best of me. “Where?”

“My mom’s house. To visit Cat.”

I try to stop it. I really do. But everything in me shuts down in a matter of seconds. My posture becomes rigid and the ringing in my ear sounds like a teakettle on high heat. I shake my head. “No.”

He laughs in disbelief. “What do you mean, *no*?”

The iciness in my voice is unrecognizable. “The word pretty much speaks for itself.”

“Are you kidding me right now?”

I don’t answer.

Ambrose pinches the bridge of his nose. “I should have seen this coming.” He stands up, the chair screeching against the hardwood. “Nothing’s changed for you, has it? You’re never going to face what happened. Even if it means destroying us.”

When my silence prevails, Ambrose lets the fork drop from his hand and I flinch when it clangs against the plate.

“You’re a coward,” he whispers. “And I won’t erase her from my life just because it hurts.” He starts to leave but stops at the kitchen’s entrance, his face grim. “She wouldn’t have wanted this, Mara. Do you remember the night of prom at Lake Bonnie? Do you remember what she said?”

I do. I remember everything.

“She said the three of us were soul mates. And it’s the truth. It’s always been the truth.”

He leaves me to mull over his words, the door closing behind him more painful to hear than if it were slammed shut. I stare at the plate in front of me, amazed how one of my favorite foods in the world suddenly tastes like dust in my mouth.

21

THEN (AGE 17)

“Dear graduates. I don’t know what to say. High school was a bitch and I’m pretty sure the real world won’t be any different...”

I can’t help laughing. “Thank god you aren’t valedictorian.”

Cat slurps down the rest of her smoothie. “I could have been. If I cared enough.” She’s right—she’s not being egotistical. She’s one of the smartest people in our class, but she prefers to put her efforts elsewhere.

“You only want to be valedictorian so you can do the speech. Trust me, you’ll have plenty of stage time on Broadway.” I do a little shimmy in excitement. Cat got into the theater program at NYU, and I received my acceptance into their film school. My dream is to work on film adaptations of my favorite books. It’s the marriage of my two favorite things in the world. We’re posted up at Groovy Smoothie, writing down all the things we need to buy for our new apartment in the city. The apartment we don’t have yet.

The way the market works, we can’t even look until a handful of weeks out. So, in the meantime, we discuss wallpaper options and the best methods of lugging our laundry onto the subway. We’re also trying to figure out a way to schmooze Cat’s parents, so they’ll be willing to sign on as our guarantors. Requiring tenants to make forty times the rent price is absolutely absurd and Cat’s convinced it’s a cover-up for money laundering. Ever since we both got our acceptance letters, my body has been humming with energy. I’m ready to start this new chapter.

“Do you think we should get a dog?”

I shake my head. “With the rent we’ll be paying, we won’t be able to afford a dog.”

“A cat?”

I chew on my lip in thought. “I could bring Cheddar.”

“Never mind...” Cat says, averting her eyes to the bottom of her empty cup.

I choke on a laugh. “What’s wrong with Cheddar?”

“Nothing’s *wrong* with him, Sally. He’s just... old. He’s more like a fifty-year-aged cheddar now. I think the city might scare a few lives out of him.”

I love my cat, but she isn’t wrong. Cheddar groans the way a senior citizen does every time their back gives out and as much as I’d love for him to join us in the move, it just isn’t feasible.

Changing subjects, Cat reaches for my smoothie, helping herself. “So, the thing is...”

When I attempt to reclaim it, she snatches it away with a look of contempt in her eyes. As if I should be ashamed for not wanting to share. I roll my eyes. “There’s a thing?”

“You and Ambrose.”

If my drink was still in my possession, I’d have choked on it. But Cat is currently chugging it down, so I choke on the air instead. There’s no me and Ambrose. There’s no Ambrose and me. There’s no sentence that should ever incorporate the two of us so closely together. I express as much to Cat.

“Listen,” she says. “All I’m saying is, the last couple of times you two have been around each other, there’s been a certain... tension in the air.” She wriggles her fingers in the air and I scrunch my nose.

I begin ripping my straw wrapper into a million tiny pieces. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Cat hums in thought. “Yeah, I’m not too sure about that. And if you want to know what I think—” Maitland, bless his soul, suddenly appears behind Cat and throws his hands over her eyes. He doesn’t know it, but he’s let me

off the hook. For now.

“Guess who?” he sings.

Cat crinkles her nose. “I don’t know, but whoever you are, you smell hot. Like Sandalwood and bad decisions. Don’t tell my boyfriend.”

Maitland growls playfully and showers Cat with kisses and tickles until she screeches like a hyena.

“Are you ladies coming out with us tonight?”

He’s referring to the bonfire. It’s a tradition all the seniors take part in every year, much like senior skip day. They hike through the woods for about an hour to Penny Lake and make a five-foot bonfire. It used to be taller, but there was an incident in the ’90s where the fire got out of hand. These days, seniors play it safe. There’s music and dancing and alcohol, but the part of the tradition that sticks out to me the most is the wish burning. Every senior writes down a wish they have for the start of their post-high school life and throws it in the fire. It’s the only aspect of the night that intrigues me.

“I don’t know, are you going to carry me?” Cat rejects anything physical unless it’s cheerleading or exercising her arms by reaching to the bottom of a bag of chips. I’m no better.

Maitland laughs. “I’ll always carry you, babe.”

I clear my throat and Maitland must think I’m inquiring about who will carry me because he says, “Jensen Martinelli is coming too. I’m sure he wouldn’t mind having you over his shoulder, Mar.”

Cat bursts into laughter and my face grows hot. I take my near-empty smoothie cup from her, sipping at the remnants. Maitland says he’ll pick us up tonight before rushing off to pick up his pressed cap and gown before the dry cleaners close.

I still haven’t processed that it’s the evening before graduation. You go to

school for as long as you can remember and then one day you're just done. If you don't choose to go on to college, that is. But the liberating feeling of freedom is still there. In a matter of twenty-four hours, you're no longer expected to show up to seven classes a day or eat suspicious-looking pizza for lunch. In college you can make the kinds of friends you *want* and not because you've known them since you were in preschool and it's familiar. You can be whoever you want to be. Go wherever you want to go.

Who do I want to be? I'm still figuring that out. But the one thing I know for sure is that I want to do it all by Cat's side.

Afraid she'll remember the subject of our conversation before Maitland interrupted, I gather our trash and remind her that we're supposed to help her mom set up the house for our graduation party. Alima insisted our parties be thrown together and a deep part of me explodes with appreciation toward her. She's aware that I have significantly fewer friends than Cat and I have a feeling my dad told her my mom was unable to make it. Something about a gallery networking event she can't miss. "I'll watch it online!" she said, as if it's no more important than a video of a parrot singing the national anthem.

On the way back to Cat's house, she insists we play "Life is a Highway" on full volume and we giggle like two little schoolgirls as we roll down the windows, screaming the lyrics at the top of our lungs. Spring is in full bloom and the air that whips at my face carries notes of roses and freshly mown grass. I close my eyes, wishing I could somehow freeze the moment in time.

And years from now, I'll look back and wonder if the lyrics we sang out into the expanse around us were more of a premonition than a proclamation.

Life's like a road that you travel on

When there's one day here, and the next day gone.

It's a quarter past seven when we finally put the finishing touches on the house. Ambrose and I avoid eye contact the entire time and whenever he gets too close, I find an excuse to escape to another part of the house. Cat watches us with suspicion in her eyes and I make a conscientious effort to avoid her too. My cover-up story is that I need to be alone while I focus on folding all the napkins into swans.

Alima goes overboard with the decorations. The interior of the house is flooded with a sea of gold-and-black balloons on the floor to the point where the hardwood is barely visible. There's a six-foot inflatable teddy bear with a graduation cap and diploma billowing in the front yard and Alima even goes so far as to create her own graduation-themed menu for the guests. I'm most excited about the "Nacho Average Graduate" nacho bar.

When I ask her why she didn't go so crazy for Ambrose's graduation party last year, she bumps her hip with mine and laughs. "We weren't sure he'd even graduate."

I'm trying my hand at calligraphy for the banners inside when Cat clutches my arm. "We have to stop now, or we'll be here all night."

She drags me up the stairs, yelling to her mom that we're getting ready to head out for the night. Alima assures us she'll employ Ambrose to finish the remaining tasks and we begin getting dressed. When Maitland rolls into the driveway with Jensen Martinelli in the passenger seat, I overhear Ambrose asking Cat who he is. I'll never admit it out loud, but I secretly hope that Ambrose watches from the den window when Jensen joins me in the back seat, giving Cat shotgun.

I'm fucking hot.

It isn't because of the red body-hugging halter top Cat lent me for the night and it isn't because of the jeans I outgrew sophomore year, which I spent fifteen minutes squeezing into because Cat said they make my ass look great. It's because we're standing in front of the tallest bonfire I've ever seen in my life.

When we first arrived, the fire was at an acceptable height and it stayed that way until I learned that Jensen Martinelli is somewhat of a pyromaniac. Jensen thought it'd make the night more "memorable" if he added fuel to the flames. Literally. Maitland had to confiscate the jug of fuel from his hands when people started to complain.

Cat and I rest on an abandoned tree stump, sipping at the flask she pulled from her purse. We're both struggling to write our wishes down on pieces of scrap paper.

"Only one wish?" Cat groans. "This is too much pressure."

For once, I agree with her dramatics and nod. "I know. I'm afraid I'll wish for the wrong thing."

My leg taps nervously on the pile of branches at my feet and my gaze drifts to the woods around us for inspiration. What do I wish?

I realize the problem isn't thinking of a wish. The problem is thinking of a wish that I'd choose above all others. I wish for many things. I wish that things between Ambrose and me weren't so complicated. I wish the relationship with my mom was better. I wish my dad would find someone who would take care of him after I leave for college. I wish for many, *many* things.

As I fold my paper into a tiny square, I look over at Cat. She's bent down intently, scribbling down her wish with her lucky purple pen. I walk as close as I can to the fire without feeling like my face is going to melt off and throw the square in. As the flames crackle around it, I close my eyes.

Tomorrow, everything will be different.

Everyone loosens up as the night progresses. Where students once admonished Jensen for his fire-throwing ways, they soon goad him on, encouraging him to make the fire bigger. I blame the alcohol. The flames rise higher and so does the tension in my neck.

“Are we sure this is safe?” I ask, motioning toward the red beast.

“Sure.” Maitland takes a swig from his cup. “As long as it doesn’t spread.”

“We’re in a *forest*,” Cat slurs. She passed drunk an hour ago and when I tried to take the drink from her hands, she tried to bite me like a piranha. She isn’t going to be happy with herself when she’s forced to endure graduation horns with a hangover.

“Okay, but don’t we think that maybe it shouldn’t be so *big*—”

“Fire.”

“Yes, thank you, Maitland. I know it’s a fire. What I’m saying is—”

“No,” Maitland croaks, his voice growing frantic. “Fire!” He points behind us and when I turn, I can’t believe what I see.

In a matter of seconds, the fire sparked onto a nearby tree, engulfing its body in flames. The fire spreads quickly before our eyes and for a minute, everyone watches, frozen in horror. It’s not until someone yells, “Run!” That we all disperse like ants on a crushed anthill.

Maitland pulls Cat into a run as I swoop down to pick up our bags. The smoke is quickly closing in on us, mixing with the shadows of the night. The black plumes shroud the woods and I begin to choke. I don’t realize I’ve been separated from Cat and Maitland until all I see are unfamiliar faces whizzing past me.

“Cat!” I yell. “Maitland!” I run deeper into the woods, away from the worst of the smoke, suddenly grateful I’ve only had a few sips from Cat’s

flask. I need a clear mind.

When I come upon the clearing people are congregating in, I hear Maitland's scream. I run toward the sound, pushing through the bystanders who observe but make no move to help. *Is everyone here drunk?*

I trip on a tree root, falling to my knees in front of a panic-stricken Maitland. He holds a limp Cat, her arms slack and a steady flow of blood dripping from her hair.

"What happened?" I cry.

"We were running and she tripped. She hit her head!"

I bring my hand to Cat's face. "Cat? Cat, can you hear me? It's Mara. Open your eyes for me."

Cat groans in pain and I almost cry with relief. Pain is bad, but if she's still alert that means it's probably not life-threatening.

"Let's get her to the car," I tell Maitland. We lift her into our arms and continue our trek toward the access point. When we finally arrive back to the parking lot, firefighters are already making their way in and questioning students on the sidelines. When I ask if we should stay to give a statement, Maitland points out that we'd been drinking and we decide it'll be smarter to head straight home.

Cat comes to in the car and groans.

"What is it, Cat? Are you in pain?" I ask frantically.

The alcohol slurs her voice. "I forgot to throw my wish into the fire. I'm such a nincompoop."

I laugh and so does Maitland from the front seat.

She's okay.

"You're not a nincompoop. We can save your wish for another time."

"Okay. Because it's a really good one, Sally. Really good."

"I don't doubt it, Gilly."

“Mara?”

“Hmm?”

“Why are you always taking such good care of me?”

“Because we’re sisters.”

She sighs a happy sigh. “That’s nice. I love Ambrose but I always wanted a sister.”

I smile. “Well, you got one.” She starts to speak but I stop her. “Shh,” I say, brushing the hair from her face. “Sleep.”

As we pull into her driveway, reality hits me like a bullet train. There’s no way I can bring her into the house and have her face Alima in her current state.

I pinch the bridge of my nose as I shoot a text to Ambrose. He doesn’t respond, but I see his black figure slip out the front door five minutes later. He ignores me as he scoops Cat up from the back seat and throws Maitland and Jensen death glares. I follow closely at his heels in silence.

Ambrose gets Cat into bed and I take the time to hide out in their shared bathroom. I’m brushing my teeth for what must be ten minutes when he walks in.

“How is she?”

He leans against the doorframe and crosses his ankles. “Fine. She’s out like a light. The bleeding on her head stopped—it’s just a small cut. It’s the huge lump that’ll be a pain in the ass in the morning.”

When I face the mirror again and spit out my mouthwash, Ambrose wraps his cool fingers around my wrist. I prepare for him to ream into me for not keeping a better eye on his baby sister. His blame won’t hold a candle to the blame I’m already putting on myself.

He brings his thumb up to my cheek and smears a streak of soot that has gathered there. “Take a shower.” His voice is hard. “Then meet me on the

roof.” He stalks away without another word.

I hide in the shower until the hot water runs out. And even then, I force myself to bear the torture of the ice-cold temperature as punishment for what’s happened. It’s not until I stand naked in the bathroom that I realize I forgot to grab a change of clothes. Not wanting to disturb Cat, I peek into Ambrose’s room to make sure he isn’t there.

I quickly run to his dresser and steal a warm T-shirt and sweatpants. His minty smell envelops me and I pray his scent clings to my skin long after I return his clothes.

I climb out the open window onto the roof. Ambrose waits for me, knees bent to his chin. He doesn’t acknowledge my presence until I’m sitting right next to him.

“What you both did tonight was stupid.”

“I know.”

Ambrose traps me with his stare. “You could have gotten hurt.”

I shiver, thinking about how much worse tonight could have been. “I know.”

He kicks at something near his shoe and it tumbles off the roof and onto the ground with a soft *thud*. I don’t know what else to say, so I settle on saying nothing.

“Is there something going on between you and that Jensen guy?”

My laugh is clipped. “Why? Are you jealous?”

Ambrose faces me head-on, his expression serious. “Yes.”

Before I can respond, he clears his throat. “My dad’s having an affair.”

The shock renders me speechless. Ambrose kicks another rock before continuing. “It started when I was a freshman in high school. Some lady from the next town over. Her name’s Sharon. I saw them together one day when I was picking up eggs for my mom at the grocery store. They were

standing together in the baking aisle, reading the ingredients on the back of some cake mix.” His laugh is pained. “When I walked up to him, he didn’t even have the courtesy to look ashamed. He fucking *introduced* her to me, Mar.” Without realizing it, I slip my hand into his and he holds on to it like it’s a lifeline. Like it’s the only thing that can get him through his story.

“When I got home that night, he called me into his office. Gave me this fucking speech about the power of a ‘man’s word.’ He wanted my word that I’d keep quiet about what I’d seen.” Ambrose blows out a breath and the cold air fogs up around his face.

“And did you?” I ask but I already know the answer because I know the kind of person Ambrose is.

“I told my mom that night.” His eyes are sad. “She already knew.”

My chest is weighed down by the new secret. I’m thinking about how much of an asshole his dad is when Ambrose says, “My dad’s affair changed me, Mara. I became so *angry*. I knew that if I kept spending all my time around you and Cat, one of you would notice something was off. My money was on you noticing first. You’ve always watched people so closely. I just figured staying far away from you was better than dragging you into the shit I needed to work through.”

His explanation rocks me to my core. “Did Cat ever find out?”

Ambrose shakes his head slowly. “My mom begged me not to tell her. She said she wanted to do it herself once she got her affairs in order to file for the divorce.”

Confusion fills my eyes. That was four years ago and Mr. King is still living at home.

Reading my thoughts, Ambrose says, “I know. She’s put it off all this time. Whenever I bring it up, she either finds a way to change the topic or Cat enters the room. I think she’s afraid of being alone.”

All this information is too much to bear. The veins in my temples begin to throb. How am I supposed to keep something like this from Cat? I can't. *I won't.*

"It's okay if you feel like you have to tell her," Ambrose says. "My mom's had enough time." I just nod.

"You hurt me," I whisper.

"I know."

I tighten my hand around his. "I'm going to make you work for it."

Ambrose's eyes are so serious when he says, "You better."

I sigh. "We love each other, don't we?"

He tucks my hair behind my ear, releasing a small laugh. "Yeah, I think we do."

"I thought you hated me."

Ambrose inches closer to me and I've never seen eyes look so apologetic. "I never hated you, Mouse. And I'm so unbelievably sorry I made you feel that way. It was wrong." He licks his lips as his gaze falls to my mouth. "There were a lot of things I wanted to do to you over the years that didn't include making you feel hated."

My pulse quickens. "Like what?"

Ambrose leans forward and brushes his supple lips across mine. Something buzzes through my body and the invisible tether between us tightens, pulling me firmly against his chest.

I open my mouth and he lets himself in. Ambrose gently pushes on my shoulder, laying me flat on the roof. His fingers work their way through my hair as he traps my body under his. Heat spreads low in my stomach and all the things that felt wrong with Brandon feel right with Ambrose.

He tears his mouth away from mine, his voice tight with restraint. "That's what I wanted to do."

I gulp. “What else?”

His laughter sings through the night and I smile. He sits up and entwines his fingers with mine, tilting his head toward the window. “Come on. I’ll show you.”

The moon glows bright in the room as Ambrose and I reintroduce ourselves to each other on his bed. We kiss and touch and whisper truths that we used to keep buried deep. We talk about the things we’ve missed over the years and the things we saw when we thought the other wasn’t looking. When I mention Cat, Ambrose assures me that we’ll tell her about us in the morning. *Together*. And when I try to extract myself from his arms to go to bed, Ambrose pulls me back into his pillows. All five times.

“Stay with me a while,” he says. “I’ll make sure you’re back in Cat’s bed before morning.”

I kiss him deeply, chuckling into his ear. “You better.” Ambrose traces shapes onto my back until we fall asleep.

But it’s not Ambrose who wakes me the next morning.

I’m not there when Cat dies that night. I don’t know what time it happens. I don’t know if it hurts. I don’t know if she cries out for me or if the last thing she feels in this world is my absence. I don’t know if it’s long and drawn out or as quick as falling asleep. I don’t know any of that because I’m with Ambrose.

I’m with Ambrose when the morning light infiltrates his room and I’m with him when Alima’s bloodcurdling screams pierce through Cat’s room because we’ve overslept on graduation day. I’m with Ambrose when the paramedics pump Cat’s chest for longer than the usual twenty minutes because *she’s only eighteen*. I’m with Ambrose when the doctors at the hospital tie the words “fall” and “brain bleed” together like two ropes in a

bend knot and I'm with him when we all sink onto the cold hard floor like dominos, weeping enough to cause the eyes of the strangers around us to water. I'm with Ambrose when Alima clutches my shoulders in agony, screaming, "Where *were* you?"

Where was I?

Where was I?

Where. Was. I.

I was with Ambrose. And it's because I was with Ambrose that I can never be with Ambrose ever again.

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When Tally reveals herself from her hiding spot, I'm still sitting in front of my pancakes, frozen like a statue at the MoMa. She heard everything.

Tally's the angriest I've ever seen her as she stomps toward me. "What the hell is wrong with you?"

"Don't start," I say, getting up and chucking my plate into the sink.

"That man is clearly crazy about you, and you just sent him on his way like he was a vacuum salesman!"

"What's your point, Tally?"

"My point? My *point*? My point is, I'm tired of watching you get in your own way. You've tried so hard to block pain out of your life that you've blocked out love too. You're my best friend in the entire world and I can list on two hands the personal details I know about you."

My heart drops. "Tally..."

She shakes her head in disappointment, but she looks sad. "You can't give people crumbs forever."

Tally retreats to my room and I sink back into my chair, my legs shaking so hard they thump the underside of the table. Ambrose says I'm a coward but I'm worse. I'm the reason Cat's dead. I knew she had a bad fall on her head and I told her to go to sleep. I told her to fucking *go to sleep*. I knew better. I *know* better. It's Head Injury 101. And then I left her side to fulfill my own selfish desires. It's a decision that's haunted me for years.

I don't deserve to see where Cat ended up. After I skipped graduation and left town, I didn't want to know about the funeral proceedings. Shame prevented me from asking my dad where the Kings buried her. I'd only realized she'd been cremated when Ambrose told me his parents moved

towns. I knew Alima wouldn't leave Speck Lake without Cat.

It pains me, thinking about her. My best friend. My sister. *My Gilly*. How do I talk about her in the past tense when I feel her presence around me still? There's something that happens to a person when they lose their other half. It renders them utterly useless. For the past seven years, everything I've been able to accomplish has felt hollow. As if it doesn't matter in the end. Because my life ceased to matter to me the morning of graduation.

Graduation.

That's what hurts most of all. Cat talked about graduating high school ever since we were twelve. She was the kind of person who lived her life looking ahead. Not in the way that stopped her from enjoying the present, but in a way that inspired you to dream for the future with her. I can't forgive myself for robbing her of that milestone. It wasn't even a question for me that I'd skip graduation. You couldn't have paid me to walk across that stage.

What did people think when they saw Cat's name on the program but didn't see her walk up to receive her diploma? Did they think she skipped graduation? That she was late? I hated the possibility that anyone could be judging Cat that day. So, I skipped it. Because if they were going to judge Cat, I wanted them to judge me too.

When I got home from the hospital, I didn't waste time burning my cap and gown. It wasn't enough to throw them away, I wanted them to cease to exist—right down to the last thread. I almost felt guilty when my dad watched in horror as I threw the silky fabric and tassels into our fireplace. It took too long to burn, so I lit match after match. Three matches did the trick. Only when the garments were reduced to ashes beneath the logs did I let the tears flow. It was the last time I cried.

I flew to New York three days later with every penny I'd saved in high

school. And when Ambrose frantically banged on the front door beforehand, I told my dad to tell him I'd already left.

"You can't leave without telling him, Mara," he said.

"Tell him I'm already gone, or you'll never hear from me again." That's when I learned how cold my voice could be. How easy it is to bulldoze past people when you have nothing left. When you feel nothing but complete emptiness inside. Hurt people can be dangerous people.

So, Ambrose was right when he called me a coward.

If I'd just stayed with her, things could have ended up differently. I've played it out a million times in my head since that night. Ambrose would ask me to stay a while and I'd refuse because I know how deep of a sleeper he is. I *know* he'd forget to wake me up. I'd kiss him on the cheek and make my way back to Cat's room to sleep and when I'd hear her thrashing in pain, I'd stir awake and ask if she's okay. When she wouldn't respond, I'd call out for Alima and tell her to call 911 because I remember the fall from the woods. The paramedics would arrive in record time because there's rarely ever traffic that late at night. They'd get to her in time and when she reached the hospital, she'd be stable. They'd have to perform surgery, but the surgeon would call it a miracle. *Good catch*, he'd say to me. *She's so lucky to have a friend like you*. We'd still miss graduation the next day, but it'd be okay because we'd be curled up in Cat's hospital bed with chocolate pudding cups, making fun of the valedictorian's speech on my laptop.

But that's not what happened.

I avoided Ambrose for all these years because I was convinced he'd hate me as much as Alima did once the dust settled. We held each other in the hospital, but we were in the height of our emotions. I didn't want to hang around for the moment he realized I could have prevented Cat's death by staying with her that night. And no matter how much I wanted to punish

myself, I couldn't bear the idea of Ambrose looking at me and seeing the reason why she was no longer on this earth.

The day I ran into him in the grocery store, I was ready for it. The screams. The anger. But it never came. My confusion deepened every time Ambrose showed up at the house, willing to breathe the same air as me. And when I realized he still wanted to *be* with me, my heart soared and plummeted at the same time. A collision of my deepest wish and widest fear.

Because if Ambrose still wants to be with me, I'm sure I can't stay away from him. No matter how much I feel like I don't deserve it.

Instead of joining Tally upstairs, I walk on numb legs to my dad's room. I've found myself seeking solace with his sleeping body almost every day at this point, which is why I don't immediately realize his eyes are open. I'm stroking the leaves on a snake plant near the window when I hear his voice.

"Princessa."

I whip around, afraid that the voice is from his ghost and I've missed the moment he left this world, just like Cat. His head is still, elevated on a stack of pillows like it always is, but his expression is alert. The most alert it has been since I've returned. I haven't seen his irises in their entirety until now and I almost fall to the floor in a puddle of tears.

I run toward the bed. "Dad." I lift a hand to his cheek. "Hi."

"Hi." He smiles.

"How are you feeling? Can I get you anything? Do you want me to call Laura?"

His voice is groggy but still carries a degree of strength I've always loved him for. "No. I just want to look at you. I'm glad you're here now, *princessa.*"

The tears are flowing freely down my face. He doesn't remember that I've *been* here. That we've already spoken and laughed together. That reveals more about his current condition than anything else and I squeeze his hand tightly, as if the gesture is the only thing necessary to keep him tethered to this world.

"I'm glad I'm here too, Daddy. I'm sorry it took me so long."

"Better late than never. For everything, Mara."

My hands shake. Does he know about Ambrose and me? How could he? He must share the same omniscient abilities as Alima.

"I think I've ruined it with him. Again."

The sigh he releases reminds me of when I was a little girl and it sparks a new wave of tears. Now that they have started, I can't stop them. "Why won't you let him love you?"

I shake my head forcefully. "There's too much pain and I... I don't want to feel it all. The last time I did, it broke me."

My dad's voice is scratchy as he tries to respond, so I grab the cup of water on his bedside and slip the straw into his mouth. After a few sips, he gathers his energy to continue. "It didn't break you, Mara. It changed you. There's a difference. You've always felt things so deeply, ever since you were a little girl. It's one of my favorite things about you. I know your mom tried to teach you to hold it all in. It's how she was raised. But we need to stop that cycle here. With you. Because feeling deeply isn't a curse. It's a gift."

I'm soaking his pillow with the tears I've kept hostage inside for years.

"Mara," my dad whispers, laying his fragile hand on mine. "Be grateful. Love is the *best* thing that can come from pain like that."

I shudder out a long breath and it's like someone's taken a match to the ice that was frozen around my heart. The innermost parts of me thaw and

the warmth that claws its way out reminds me of the summers Ambrose, Cat, and I used to spend together.

A pained thought tickles at my brain. “I’m sorry. I’m sorry I had nothing to give you during this time. I’ve been pouring from an empty cup.”

“You’ve given me the best thing a father could ask for.”

I lean back, searching his face. “What?”

“You gave me a daughter who loved me.”

Sobs rack my body and his voice is gentle when he says, “Can I ask something of you, *princessa*?”

“Anything, Dad.” I sniff. I would do anything for him in this moment, I realize. But his request is simple.

“Watch a movie with me.”

I smile so wide, my jaw feels stretched. Salty tears fall into my mouth as I reach for my laptop. “What should we watch?”

“*Princess Bride*. It’s one of my favorites.”

My smile is watery. “Since when?”

“Since it became one of your favorites.”

My chest cracks open and I can swear people hear the sound from miles away. I lift my dad’s comforter and join him underneath. Otso doesn’t hesitate to snuggle between us. I grab hold of one of his paws for comfort. More for mine than his. Leaning forward, I kiss the top of my dad’s brow.

“As you wish.”

My dad dies on a Wednesday. The day we praise for getting us halfway through the workweek. *Hump Day*. I never gave too much thought to the exact day he’d leave this world. I stopped thinking so intricately about loss when Cat died. But when it happens, I know I’ll look at Wednesdays differently for the rest of my life. I’ll hate them just a *little*. Just for him. He

deserves that much.

I believe that wherever my dad ends up, Cat is there waiting for him. She'll greet him with her arms open wide and insist on giving him the grand tour. They're each other's keepers now.

Take care of him, Gilly.

Take care of her, Dad.

The funeral is beautiful. There are more kinds of flowers than I knew existed and I thank Nadine profusely for donating so many from her nursery. Her eyes overflow with tears when she says she'd bring an entire garden to my dad's funeral if she could. Comments like that happen a lot. I learn just how many lives my dad touched. Like me, he was quiet but unlike me, he loved loud. I have a lot to learn from him.

I'm thanking people for coming and inviting them to stop by the reception at the house for food when I spot Ambrose watching me from afar. His black dress pants are pressed, but the sleeves rolled up to his elbows make him look casual. Dad would have loved that. He hated fuss. Ambrose resembles a sentry as he leans against a large sycamore tree. Like he leans against cemetery trees all the time.

I embrace Laura and Tally, letting them know that I'll meet them back at the house and walk over to him. Despite the way we left things the last time we saw each other, Ambrose grabs me, enveloping me in his arms. I breathe him in and cling to him like my life depends on it. I think it does.

"I'm sorry for your loss," he whispers into my hair.

I search his eyes. "I'm sorry for your loss too." Even if I wasn't there to witness their relationship over the years, I know my dad's passing weighs heavy on him.

We hold each other's gaze for what feels like hours before I force myself to speak. "There are things... I need to work through, Ambrose. And I can't

give myself to you until I take the time to work through them.”

He’s quiet for a minute before nodding. “I’m a patient man.”

Blood rushes through my ears and I drop my forehead to his chest.
“Why?”

“Because I love you, Mara.”

My eyes fly to his and his smile is sad and hopeful all at once.

“Don’t look so surprised.”

My voice trembles. “Since when?”

“Since the day you knocked on my front door with that godforsaken cat in your arms.”

I choke out a warbled laugh and his voice becomes rough with emotion.

“I’ve loved you since that kiss outside of Old Maple and I’ve loved you since we both lost the person we loved the most. I loved you then and I love you now. And if you’ll have me... I’ll love you until my last breath. You’re the love of my life, Mara, but you’re my best friend too. I like you as much as I love you. I could have a million lifetimes with you and it still wouldn’t be enough.”

Words won’t form around the soft sobs escaping my throat, but Ambrose doesn’t push. He uses his thumb to wipe away the tear sliding down my chin. “So, take your time.”

“I—”

“Don’t say it.”

My face falls. “What? Why not?”

“Because when you say those three words,” he says, dragging his thumb across my bottom lip, “I want to see our future in your eyes. Not our past.”

His lips brush across mine so gently and it’s as soft as the cold breeze around us. He turns, leaving me alone beside the sycamore.

As cars find their way out of the parking lot, I walk back to my dad. The

cemetery workers use an intricate pulley system to lower him into the cutout piece of earth and the flowers people placed on top of his casket follow him into the ground. I make a silent wish that they'll grow around him and keep him safe.

I dig through my purse and pull out my phone before I change my mind.

It rings twice before the voice on the other end picks up and I sigh in relief.

“Mom? It’s Mara. I’m sorry to call so late but... I need you.”

I didn’t realize how much I’ve missed Paris. The moment I let go of all the resentment I hold toward my mom, I let go of all the resentment I hold toward the places and things connected to her.

When she picks me up at the airport, I don’t fight her embrace. She’s heartbroken to hear about my dad’s passing, but she doesn’t cry. The shield around her emotions is ironclad. And as much as I want her to crumble alongside me, I realize that sometimes you have to love people more than you want to change them. She’s on her own journey and I’m on mine.

She gives me my space over the following days. I walk through the cobblestone streets and pretend like everywhere I go, I take Cat with me. So far, I’ve taken Cat to experience the Louvre, the Eiffel Tower, and overpriced crepes. Maybe that’s how we are supposed to honor those who are no longer with us. Maybe we’re supposed to keep living *for* them. And if that’s the case, I’ll do it for Cat. And my dad.

When I’m ready to leave, JP drives me to the airport.

“You look different. Lighter. I’ve never seen you look at Paris through such eyes,” he says. His rich, ebony skin glows in the morning light. I’m lucky to know someone like him and I’m glad he’s able to love my mom in a way I’m not able to.

I hug him as I grab my duffel bag. “I have a feeling I need to take another look at a lot of things.”

I start therapy the day after I get back to New York.

It’s easy to fall back into my old routine when I return to the city, but I’m determined to keep my promise to Ambrose and take the time to work on myself.

When I have my first session with Mitsu, she tells me she does things a little differently and I don’t really know what that means but I know I need different.

She’s kind and patient and she gets me to talk about Cat in a way that feels like I’m celebrating her and mourning her at the same time. I really like that. I like that I don’t have to choose between the two. Because I’ll always mourn Cat.

“Healing isn’t linear, Mara,” Mitsu says. “Some days it’s five steps forward and other days it’s seven steps back. There’s no finish line. The goal is just to keep *stepping*.”

So I do just that. And there are days when thinking about Cat makes me laugh until my belly hurts and days where it makes me cry so hard I’m afraid I’ll drown.

But I’m thinking about her.

On the day that marks two months since our first session, Mitsu hands me a box with a green bow.

“Are you supposed to give clients presents? Doesn’t that cross some sort of line?” I tease.

She rolls her eyes at me. I like that she doesn’t treat me like porcelain about to break. “It’s not a present. It’s *homework*.”

I open the box to reveal its contents. My eyebrows scrunch in confusion as I hold up the broken pieces of a ceramic bowl. “Thank you?”

She chuckles. “It’s called kintsugi.”

I repeat the word back to her and she nods. “It’s the art of putting broken pottery pieces back together with gold. The idea behind it is that even when something’s broken, we can always put it back together. And when we put it back together and embrace those cracks of imperfection, it’s even stronger and more beautiful than before.”

And as I glue the pieces together that night on the floor of my tiny New York apartment, I imagine Ambrose, Cat, and I as the shards in my hands finally coming back together. Held firmly in place by the gold. A material known for being malleable; open to change, but one that never tarnishes.

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“This doesn’t feel like a good idea. Or at least, a sanitary one.”

Cat and I sit cross-legged on the floor of her bathroom, a razor blade in the middle of us. She snuck into her dad’s closet and stole one from an old-school barber kit he was gifted at his bachelor party years ago. It’s slightly tarnished and slightly questionable. She keeps reaching for my hand, but nerves make me pull it away.

“Of course it’s sanitary. I put it under hot water. Don’t be such a baby.”

I scoff. “If I’m the baby, why don’t *you* go first?”

“Because if I go first, I won’t be able to do yours and we both know you won’t do it.”

She has a point. Blood makes me queasy.

We just finished watching *Practical Magic* and Cat can’t get over the scene where Sally and Gillian cut their hands to make a blood oath. Apparently it’s an act that binds two people together forever. A promise of sorts.

So here we are on Cat’s floor, palms exposed like we’re about to play a game of hot hands. Except we’ll be slicing each other’s hands instead of slapping them. I think I prefer the latter.

“All I’m saying is, is this really necessary?”

Cat blows out a dramatic sigh and leans her head against the toilet. “We’re thirteen, Mar. We just started high school and whether we like it or not... things are gonna change.”

Unease fills my stomach. Cat’s rarely ever worried about the future.

“I just want us to promise to always be there for each other. A promise so big, it goes beyond words.”

I understand where her head's at. I really do. Even the discussions we've already had about our hopes for high school are different from each other's. Cat's thinking of trying out for the cheerleading squad and I'm planning on joining the film club. We're becoming two people who have more differences than similarities, but that doesn't mean we want our bond to be severed.

"Two sides of the same coin," I whisper.

Cat sits up. "Hmm?"

"We're like two sides of the same coin. Different... but the same. High school *will* change things. But you're always gonna be my best friend, Cat. You're always gonna be my sister."

I push the sleeve of my shirt up even higher and thrust my palm forward. "Do your damage."

Cat's grin transforms the atmosphere around us and suddenly, I'm excited about what we are about to do. She has the ability to do that. She brings my hand close to her face and her jaw becomes set with laser focus.

Five minutes later and we're clasping each other's hands, a steady stream of blood leaking onto the floor.

"Um... we should get some Band-Aids and clean all this up." I start to get up but Cat yanks me back down. "Wait!" Her expression is serious. "Promise me something."

"What?"

"Promise me..." She scrunches her nose in thought. "Promise me that no matter what, it'll always be the two of us."

I grin, squeezing our clasped hands. "The two of us. I promise."

When we finish cleaning the bathroom and wrapping our hands in first aid gauze, we return downstairs to finish the movie. We ignore Ambrose's suspicious glances as we each hide a hand behind our backs.

“What are you doing?” I say as Cat pushes the rewind button on the remote.

“I want to watch it again.”

I grab the bowl of popcorn and we throw our heads down, sharing the large pillow between us.

Sally: I feel like I’m never gonna see you again.

Gilly: Of course, you’re gonna see me again, we’re gonna grow old together! It’s gonna be you and me.

Living in a big house, these two old biddies with all these cats. I mean, I bet we even die on the same day!

Sally: You swear?

Gilly: Here. My blood. Your blood. *Our* blood.

Sally: I love you, Gilly-bean.

Gilly: Yeah. I love you too.

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As I wait for the door in front of me to open, a breeze dances through the trees, lifting the hair off my shoulders.

“Hey Cat,” I whisper at the sky. “Stay close to me for this one.”

As if she’s whispering in response, the wind picks up and swirls the leaves at my feet into tiny wind eddies.

The door opens and Alima stands before me, a baking apron tied securely around her waist and a speck of flour on her cheek. She looks older, but the same as I remembered. Her warm-brown eyes are still warm even though they hold a shade of somberness, a permanent addition, I’m sure. For all of us. Neither of us speaks for a handful of seconds. Seconds always feel fast until you need them to be and right now, seconds feel like the slowest unit of time in existence.

Alima pulls the door open wider, motioning for me to come in. My heart beats so fast, I can hear it thrumming in my ear and I become afraid of not being able to hear anything she’ll say.

She leads me to a small living room area and gestures toward the matching love seats. When I sit down, I begin fiddling with my keys, trying to remember the first part of the speech I’ve prepared. It’s Alima who saves me from my loss of words.

“I’ve waited for this day for seven years,” she says, sitting down next to me.

Her voice is neutral and I’m unable to gauge the level of anger I know she feels toward me. I’m uncomfortable with how close she’s sitting next to me. Would she slap me? Oh my god, would Alima *slap* me? I would if I were her. I try to put a little distance between us and start scooting away

when she reaches forward and takes hold of me.

Alima's hug is the saddest expression of affection I've ever experienced. Neither one of us moves as our sobs of brokenness fill the air. The notes of our pain sing out together into the space around us and it's a devastating melody.

"I'm so sorry," I cry into her sweater. I'm soaking it, but she doesn't seem to mind.

Alima pulls back to look me in the eyes. "No, Mara. If anyone should be apologizing, it's me. I let my emotions take me someplace ugly that day. I needed someone to blame and you were a nearby casualty."

I sob harder as she strokes the curls away from my face. "When the fog cleared enough for me to realize how I must have made you feel, you were already gone. Your dad wouldn't tell me how to get ahold of you."

"I thought you blamed me," I whisper. "*I* blamed me."

Alima shakes her head, her expression solemn. "I could never blame you, Mara. I could never blame someone Cat loved so much. You were like a daughter to me. You still are."

I can't believe the words coming from Alima's mouth. My brain hurts at the idea that she doesn't hate me. It's difficult to accept that the truth of the situation is different from the story I've been telling myself in my head. But that's the thing about truth. Sometimes we mistake our emotions for the truth. Sometimes *our* truth isn't the truth at all.

Alima and I huddle close on the love seat as she asks about my life and everything she's missed. She seems happy that Ambrose and I have crossed paths again and I want to ask her if she's become aware of any omniscient abilities lately.

She divorced Ambrose and Cat's dad, Robby, after Cat passed away. She didn't want to waste life taking the important people for granted and giving

too much of herself to those who didn't deserve it. When she said she started a baking business after receiving too many horrible baked goods after Cat died, I couldn't help but laugh. Alima's baking skills always put *everyone* to shame.

I'm not surprised in the least when she explains how her new business focuses on providing quality baked goods to those who've experienced loss. It's the first time I realize there can be good things that are birthed out of such horrible situations.

"I did always love your chocolate chip cookies," I say. "I'm pretty sure they're to thank for giving me any semblance of curves in high school."

Alima laughs and it sounds so much like Cat, I want to make her laugh again and again. "Come, let me show you something."

She leads me into the kitchen just as the timer above the oven goes off. I laugh when she pulls two sheets of chocolate chip cookies out. We help ourselves to the cookies and chat some more. I lose track of how long I'm there until I see the golden glow of the sun setting outside.

"I don't want to keep you. It's getting late. I should go."

Before I finish buttoning up my coat, Alima motions for me to follow her to the back of the house. The patio opens out into a huge wheat field, the land going on as far as my eyes can see. I was confused when I drove up to the house—it's in such a remote location—but now it all makes sense. A secluded residence like this has the advantage of providing an ample amount of land.

"It's beautiful."

She hums in agreement, looking at the field with similar adoration. As if she's seeing it for the first time too. She points to a lone tree in the middle of the field, about fifty feet away. A maple tree, its large branches and foliage creating a shaded oasis. You'd think the tree felt lonely, standing

there all by itself, but it looks right. Like it's there for people to take refuge under it.

"That's where Cat's ashes are," Alima whispers, tilting her head toward the tree.

I want to be buried under a huge tree. The biggest tree. So everyone can come and rest under me.

What comes out of me is a mixture of joy and sorrow. I'm crying, but I can't stop the laughs escaping from my throat. "It's her tree!"

Alima grins. "She made sure I knew how she wanted to be buried too. I think she told everyone."

My laugh deepens. "That sounds like her."

"Go. Go rest under her for a little while," Alima says, placing a palm on my back, giving me a gentle push.

As I stand under the maple tree, the sunset becomes an explosion of gold. I sink to my knees and graze my fingers over the flat headstone.

Catherine Marie King

Jan. 13, 1995 - May 13, 2013

Our beloved daughter, sister, and best friend

May we always look forward to tomorrow like you

I trace the indentation of the words *best friend* repeatedly. It's a small gift, one I'm not even sure Alima knows she gave me.

"I'm sorry it took me so long to get here, Gilly," I whisper.

When I stopped by the store before driving to Alima's house, I didn't think I'd be able to have this moment in front of Cat. I stand up and pull the Snickers bar from my jacket pocket. I peel back the wrapper and take a huge bite, choking out a laugh.

"A Snickers bar in your honor. Are you happy?" I laugh harder when I remember the other part of the request Cat made when we were thirteen. I

don't allow myself to ruminate on the fact that Alima could be watching as I start swaying my hips with abandon. I move my arms to the invisible beat, dancing to the song playing in my head.

"Well, I heard about the fellow you've been dancin' with all over the neighborhood..." I sing.

I only get to the third line before I bend over at the waist, clutching my side from the laughter.

"Okay, that's enough," I gasp between laughs. "Your mom's going to think I've lost it."

I can picture it. Cat smiling down or up or around at me from wherever she is.

"I love you, Gilly." I wipe at my eyes. "I'll come back again real soon."

It's a promise I don't intend on breaking. I turn to head back to the house when a myriad of colorful fractals dance over my body. I glance above me and gasp. Hanging from a low branch is the suncatcher I got for Cat when I was in Paris. It sways in the wind, painting the ground in Technicolor and my heart soars. It's the best place my gift could have ended up. I grin and tap the cat-shaped suncatcher with my finger, watching it sway in the light.

"Bye, Kitty Cat."

I'm sitting in Ambrose's den, counting down the minutes until he's supposed to get home. When Anya offered to lend me her copied key so I could surprise him, it sounded like a good idea. But now that I'm here, my nerves are getting the best of me. I should have called first.

The front door's handle jiggles and I stand up, smoothing out the creases in my skirt from sitting so long. Ambrose is typing something on his phone as he walks into the den, so he doesn't see me immediately. When I clear my throat, he jumps back, startled.

“Oh, fuck! *Fuck*. Mara, you scared the shit out of me.”

I flinch from embarrassment. “Sorry.”

His breathing evens as he walks slowly toward me. “What are you doing here?”

I begin pacing the room, trying to garner courage from the carpet to my feet like static electricity.

“I have some things I need to say to you. So, you just... you stand right there.”

Ambrose’s eyebrows lift in surprise, but the corner of his mouth twitches. “Okay.”

I face him full on. “I’m not perfectly healed. I’m not sure that I ever will be. What happened to me, what happened to *us*... it was life changing. We’re changed forever, whether we like it or not. But what I’ve learned is that... that’s okay. Because the changed version of me still loves the changed version of you. I’m *in* love with you, Ambrose.” I take a step closer, my voice shaking. “I’ve loved you since the moment I knocked on your door with that godforsaken cat in my arms.” My eyes water as I repeat his words. “I loved you then and I love you now.”

Ambrose’s eyes are glassy, but he doesn’t speak and I begin to sweat. His eyes drop to the vase in my hands. “What’s that?”

I lift the vase a little. “It’s kintsugi. It’s the imperfect parts broken.” I squint my eyes, trying to remember the eloquent words Mitsu used but my nerves cause me to fumble. “The broken parts are our imperfect pieces, coming together.”

Ambrose starts walking toward me.

“Even amid the imperfection... it’s still beautiful.”

He’s within reach now, his green eyes dancing over every inch of my face.

“We’re still beautiful, Ambrose,” I whisper, stepping toward him.

“Wait,” he says, his voice rough from unshed tears. “If you take another step...that’s it. You’re stuck with me. I will *never* let you go again, Mara.”

A sound of relief escapes me and I fly forward, colliding my mouth with his. Ambrose and I cling together and it feels both like drowning and coming up for air.

Ambrose pulls away abruptly and smiles at me. “I have to show you something.”

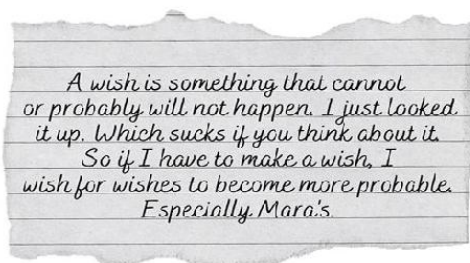
I groan. “Right now?”

“Yes, right now.” He laughs. “Don’t move.” He’s only gone twenty seconds before he returns with a shoebox in his hand. He sits on the couch and pats his lap. “Come here.”

I curl up on him, burrowing myself into his neck. When he pulls a folded piece of scrap paper out of the box and rests it on my lap, I stop breathing.

“My mom found it in her things. It’s from the night of the wish burning.”

“She forgot to throw hers in,” I whisper. I pick up the piece of paper and unfold it. And in the arms of the man I love the most, I read my best friend’s last wish.



Tears stream down my face but I’m happy. I think I’ve never been happier. Ambrose’s mouth grazes my ear. “I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

We abandon the need for words as Ambrose tucks the paper back into the shoebox for safekeeping and carries me up the stairs. And this time when he

lays me down, I have no intention of ever leaving his side again.

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EPILOGUE

FIVE YEARS LATER

The clouds dance overhead—clear and vibrant strokes against the unmarred pallet of the sky. We lie under Cat’s maple tree on a handful of beach towels because Ambrose forgot to put the picnic blanket in the laundry after Sol spilled fruit punch on it. Again.

I glance over at the little boy to my left. *Our* little boy. He’s turning four in a few weeks, but some days it feels like he’s turning forty. He has an old soul.

“Do you think clouds get lonely?” he asks, pointing to a big clump of white drifting away from the others. Ambrose looks at me and smiles. Sol has a habit of personifying inanimate things. He can’t fathom the idea that not everything has feelings. He’s intuitive. Gentle and kind. Like his grandfather, whose name he bears.

“I don’t think so,” Ambrose says, scratching his head. “But even if they do, all clouds come back together eventually, so it won’t be lonely for too long.”

Sol nuzzles into Ambrose’s side, satisfied with his answer. Ambrose always knows how to answer his questions in a way that encourages his curiosity rather than stifles it. I wink at Ambrose, letting him know he did good.

“Cat! Cat!” The little girl in my arms wriggles out of my grasp, jumping and pointing at the sky.

I tilt my head, looking for the animal she sees. As if he understands the word and its meaning, Otso stirs from his slumber, the warning growl from his mouth making Sol giggle. Otso’s getting old, but he still has a lot of spunk left in him. Enough to keep the kids entertained. We let him join us

outside since Cheddar lays claim to the guest room. Every day that cat is still alive shocks us all.

I squint up at the sky. “You see a cat? Where, baby?”

She jumps faster, impatience filling her body. “Der! Der!”

We all laugh. She’s only two, but she can’t for the life of her figure out how to correctly say the word *there*.

“I think I see it,” Ambrose says.

I snort, assuming he’s just trying to appease her, but then he points to his left. And right there, clear as day, is a cloud in the shape of a cat’s head—pointy ears and all.

“Do you think it’s Aunty Cat?” Sol asks. We told him recently about who Cat is and how she was no longer with us, but that she would’ve loved being his aunt. Ever since then, he’ll ask if different things are Cat. The breeze through the trees. The butterfly on the windshield. The cloud in the sky. His imagination reminds me of her and it makes me love him even more for it.

“It could be,” I say.

Alima waves her arms from the sliding door to let us know that the cookies are ready. Sol doesn’t waste time running toward the house and Ambrose follows close on his heels, challenging him to a race.

We make it a point to visit Alima’s house as often as we can. Family takes precedence over everything for Ambrose and me. And when he asked me what I wanted as a wedding present the year after my dad died, I said, “To go back home.” So, we packed up the tiny New York apartment we shared and moved back to Speck Lake, making 164 Winsome Lane the place we started our new chapter. I was able to take the new position in my job fully remote, focusing on designing websites for authors and filmmakers, and Ambrose was happy being able to run operations for the

zoo in person again. And when a little girl knocked on our door saying she'd just moved into the house across the street, the one that looked like a lemon drop, I stood to the side, watching history repeat itself as Sol accepted her invitation to play in a familiar tree house. Winsome Lane has witnessed a lot of things fall apart, but it's witnessed a lot of things come together too.

"Mom, hurry! Matty, Laura, and Anya just got here!" Sol calls, poking his head out the sliding door. I grin to myself, knowing how excited he is. He's Matty's little shadow.

I bend down to pick up my daughter with curls the same color as the wheat field before me. The same color as her aunt's.

"You ready for some cookies?" I ask, tickling her sides.

Her giggles ring out into the sky and the birds chirp as if they're singing back to her.

"Cookies! Cookies!" she chants. "I love you, Mommy."

She's generous with her *I love yous* when food is involved, and I laugh.

"I love you too, Gilly."

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This being my debut novel, I never in a million years thought I would get to this page—the page where I thank people. I am incredibly thankful.

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